

The Adjuster

Book 1: Act of God (chapters 1-19, still being written)

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Chapter 1: The Envelope

The rain had been coming sideways since four in the afternoon, and by nine it had found the one place in my office roof I'd been promising to fix for three years.

I moved the bucket six inches to the left and went back to my desk.

That's the job, mostly. Somebody's roof leaks, somebody's boat sinks, somebody's warehouse fills with smoke at two in the morning with nobody inside. Then somebody asks me to say whose fault it was, and how much it should cost, and whether the person asking for the money is telling the truth. My office is over a chandlery on Commercial Street in Portland, Maine. It smells like rope and wet dog. I'm good at what I do.

I'm good at it because I learned from the best. Hollis Dunn used to tell the new hires at Atlantic Mutual Casualty that every loss is a story somebody

is telling you. *Your job isn't to believe it*, he'd say, stirring his tea, no sugar, never any sugar. *Your job is to find where it doesn't fit the water.*

I'd added a rule of my own in the years since. Nobody is that unlucky.

Not the man whose barn burns the same month his creditors call. Not the woman whose husband slips in the shower six weeks after the policy doubles. Bad luck is lumpy and random and it doesn't keep appointments. When a loss keeps appointments, somebody made the appointment.

My phone buzzed against the desk at 9:12. The screen said DESMOND REYES, and I let it ring twice, because Reyes was the vice president of claims at Atlantic Mutual and I'd learned that he valued people more when they didn't pick up on the first ring.

"Theo." He had the voice of a man who'd been born in a good suit. "You're working late."

"I'm working under a bucket."

"Still? I'll send you a roofer." He didn't laugh. He never did. "I need you on something. A death in Port Carrow, last night. Alan Farrow."

I didn't say anything. Outside, a gust leaned on the window and the glass answered.

"You remember the name," Reyes said.

"I remember the name."

"His wife, six years ago. You closed that one."

"Accidental drowning," I said. "She went over the side of their boat in March. Blood alcohol of point one eight. No sign of anyone else aboard."

"That's what the file says." A pause, very small, the kind you leave on purpose. "Now it's Alan. They found him this morning in the boathouse behind his house. The tide came up in last night's storm and the boathouse flooded. He was face down in four feet of water with the door locked from inside. The state police are calling it a misadventure, pending the medical examiner."

"And the policy?"

"Accidental death and dismemberment, four point two million. Increased a month ago from two. Sole beneficiary is a daughter, Cora, twenty-four."

I wrote 4.2 on my legal pad and underlined it, though I'd have remembered. "A month ago."

"I thought you'd like that."

"I like it fine. I like it so much I'm wondering why you're calling me instead of one of the staff adjusters."

"Because you wrote the first report." He let that sit. "If there's something in the first death, Theo, I want the man who looked at it to be the one who

looks again. Quietly. I don't want a *pattern* in the Farrow family getting to a newspaper before it gets to my desk."

Quietly. Reyes had said *quietly* the way other men say *please*.

"Day rate, plus expenses," I said. "I need access to the original file. All of it."

"Done. It'll be in your inbox by morning. The Port Carrow causeway floods at high tide, so check the table. High water's eleven-forty tomorrow morning, just after midnight tomorrow night. Allow for the storm. Don't get stranded." Then, as if it had just occurred to him: "Hollis Dunn lives out there now, you know. Retired. You might look in on him."

"I know where Hollis lives."

"Of course you do."

He hung up. I sat there with the pen in my hand, listening to the bucket.

Lydia Farrow.

I hadn't thought about her in a long time. You don't forget the ones that went wrong. You forget the ones that went exactly the way the paperwork said.

I pulled my own memory open like a drawer and went through it: a gray March, a fifty-one-foot motor yacht named *Salt Ledger* moored off the Port Carrow breakwater, a woman in her late forties found two days later by a lobsterman. A husband in shock. A harbormaster who'd seen her aboard, alone, with a bottle, the evening before. A medical examiner's report. A file that closed neatly, the way a drawer does when everything's in the right place.

Under that was something I'd never given a name to. A pebble in a shoe I'd decided to keep walking on.

I'd been sober then. Six months, for the first time in my life. I'd thought the pebble was just me, a man who couldn't trust his own nerves.

I looked at the clock. 9:41.

It was October ninth. In five days it would be five years since my wife died.

I don't usually say that sentence to myself with the date attached. The date is a fence, and I've spent a long time learning to walk beside it without leaning. Mara went into the water off the Port Carrow breakwater on a night much like this one. The state called it an accident. I, who made a living out of not believing things, believed it.

I believed it because the alternative was a door I couldn't open. Also because I had no memory of that week to argue with.

That's the other thing I don't say. There are ten days missing out of my life, the ten days before Mara died. I know what I was doing in the general sense. Drinking. I'd gone back to it that autumn, hard and stupid, and when I surfaced, it was the fifteenth, I was in a hospital corridor in Rockport, and a state trooper was saying my name carefully, like it might spill.

One thousand eight hundred and twenty days since then. I count them. It's a stupid habit and it keeps me alive.

The buzzer downstairs went at 9:58.

Nobody rings the buzzer at ten at night in a storm unless they're delivering something or collecting something. I went down the back stairs with the flashlight, through the chandlery's dark aisles of shackles and coiled line, and opened the street door on the chain.

The man on the step was around seventy and soaked to the knee. He wore a dark overcoat that had been good thirty years ago and held a leather

document case against his chest with both arms, the way you'd carry a child out of a fire.

"Mr. Theodore Brandt?"

"Who's asking?"

"Ferris Quill. Attorney." He tried to produce a card, found that the rain had dissolved it, and let it go. "I'm very sorry about the hour. I had instructions about the hour, in fact. I was to deliver this to you within twenty-four hours of a certain event, in person, and on no account to leave it with a third party." He studied my face. "You look the way she described you."

Something cold went through the middle of me that had nothing to do with the rain.

"Who described me?"

"Your wife, Mr. Brandt." He drew the case away from his chest, unbuckled it, and took out a long cream envelope with a worn crease across one corner. "Mara Brandt retained me in October, five years ago. She paid in advance. She gave me this, and a very specific instruction, and I have kept it in my safe since the week she died. This morning I read in the *Press Herald* that a man named Alan Farrow had been found dead, and I understood that my instruction had come due."

I took the envelope. I'd like to say my hand was steady.

My name was on the front. *Theo*. No surname, no address. The pen she'd used was a blue felt-tip she'd kept in the kitchen drawer. I could see the faint crimp at the end of the *o* where she always stopped, then pressed again, because she'd learned cursive from a nun who disapproved of lifted pens.

"What did she tell you?" My voice came out wrong. "When she gave it to you."

"Very little. That you would likely not believe it at first." Quill stepped back from the door. "She said you were the kind of man who needed to see the water before he'd believe it was wet. And she said I was to tell you one thing, if you asked about it." He frowned, as if reading a line off the inside of his own forehead. "'He'll want to call someone. Tell him not to.'"

"Call who?"

"She didn't say." The wind tore at his coat. "I'm sorry. I have done what I was asked. I'll be at my office on Exchange Street if you need me. I'd prefer it if you didn't come to my home."

"Mr. Quill—"

But he'd already turned, hunched over the empty case, and was walking back into the weather. I stood in the doorway until he was gone.

I carried it up the stairs and set it on the desk under the lamp, and I looked at it for what might have been two minutes or ten.

I read evidence for a living. Postmarks, signatures, the weight of paper, the age of a stain. I examined the envelope's edges, the flap, the seal. Then I opened it like I was opening a stranger's.

Inside were two things: a single sheet folded in thirds, and a small brass key on a loop of string. The key had a plastic tag on it, stamped with a number, 114, and the name of a self-storage outfit in Rockland.

I unfolded the sheet.

It was her handwriting, all of it. Blue felt-tip. Four paragraphs, the second half of the page cramped where she'd run out of room and refused to start another.

Theo,

If you're reading this, then Alan Farrow is dead, and I'm either dead too or I've failed. I'm writing it down because I'm a coward about

saying it aloud, and because I know you. You'll want to hear it from someone you trust, and I need you not to.

Alan didn't kill Lydia alone. Nobody does anything like this alone. There are others, and they've been very, very careful, and they've used you, without your ever knowing, to make the careful look like luck. I'm sorry. I should have told you months ago. I tried on Sunday night and I lost my nerve halfway through.

The key opens everything I have. Go to Rockland. Don't go to the police first, not the local ones, not the state, not yet. Read the Doyle file again, the cannery one, the one with no name on the closing page. You'll see it. You always see it, once you stop being polite.

And Theo. Whatever you do, don't tell anyone you got this. Not a soul. Not even the people who love you. Especially them. I'm sorry. I love you. I always did, even in October.

Under it, no signature. Just a small drawing she'd done on every note she ever left me. A wave, three lines, a little crest.

I read it three times. The first time like a husband. The second like an adjuster. The third like I was holding a sheet of glass that someone might drop.

Then I did what Hollis Dunn had taught me, because I didn't know what else to do. I stopped asking what it said and started asking what it was.

The paper was ordinary stationery, creamy, heavy, hers. The ink had the slight bronzing blue felt-tip gets with age. The folds were worn but unbroken. That told me very little about how long it had been inside the envelope. A water stain, small, at the lower right corner. I tilted it toward the lamp. A white crystalline rim marked where it had dried.

Salt, perhaps. Seawater would leave a mark like that. So would other things. I wanted it to tell me where she'd been. It couldn't.

I checked the envelope again. No postmark, of course. No date on the letter, either. Quill had said October, five years ago. The week she died. Everything more precise than that came from me.

Sunday night, she'd written. *I tried on Sunday night and I lost my nerve halfway through.*

Sunday. October the fourth. That was ten days before she died.

That was the first day of the ten I couldn't remember.

I got up and walked to the window. The street was black glass and rain. Beyond it, the harbor lights vanished and returned as the squalls passed.

Tried to tell you on Sunday and lost my nerve halfway through.

Halfway through what? I had no memory of Mara trying to tell me anything. I had no memory of Sunday at all. I'd spent five years assuming those days were blank because I'd drunk them into a blank. I'd been grateful for the mercy of it. I'd pictured bottles, rooms, hours lost. Never Mara trying to tell me something. Never myself answering.

I stood there until my breath fogged the window.

Then I went back to the desk and did the things a man does when his dead wife has asked him a favor.

I looked up the storage company in Rockland. Its website advertised twenty-four-hour access for tenants. I had a key and a unit number. I didn't have a gate code. I wrote down the office hours: nine to five.

Then I pulled the Port Carrow tide tables from the drawer where I keep everything that might kill me. High water was 11:40 the next morning, as Reyes had said. The causeway would close well before that and reopen after it, if the storm let it.

Rockland first. Then Port Carrow when the road was clear. I put the key beside my car keys. A route, two places, things I could do with my hands.

My hand went to the phone.

I knew who I'd call. I always called him. When the file didn't fit, when the room felt wrong, when the old fear came up out of the floor at three in the morning, I called Hollis Dunn, and he picked up on the second ring, every time, and said *Tell me where it doesn't fit the water*. He'd got me through five years of nights. He'd been at the funeral. He'd been at the meetings. He'd been, God help me, the closest thing I had to family.

Not even the people who love you.

I took my hand off the phone.

It was a small thing, and it cost me. I stood in that cold office with the bucket going *tink, tink, tink* and I felt the loneliness of it arrive, whole, the way weather arrives. Mara had asked me to carry this alone, and in all our years together she'd never asked me to carry anything alone. She'd always taken the other handle.

Especially them.

I told myself it meant nothing. A frightened woman, a bad week. A note written by somebody who might not have been thinking clearly, who had maybe

been wrong about everything.

Then I pulled up the file on Lydia Farrow, the one Reyes had said would be in my inbox by morning, and found that it was there already.

It had arrived at 9:12.

The same minute he called.

I sat looking at the timestamp and thought about men who say *quietly*, and a file sent before I'd agreed to take the job.

I opened it.

It was thirty-one pages, my name on every page. The first six were as I remembered them: the boat, the lobsterman, the harbormaster's statement, the blood alcohol. Clean and orderly. I'd been proud of them.

Page seven was a one-page addendum, a supplementary finding, typed in a blocky, slightly smudged font that I'd never once used in my life. It summarized an interview with the victim's husband. It concluded, in language I could have recited in my sleep, *no evidence of third-party involvement*.

At the bottom was my signature. The same crowded capitals, the same drag of blue-black ink below the line. Exactly where I'd have put it.

I'd been sober when I worked that claim. I'd interviewed Alan. I'd signed a report. All that I remembered.

I had never seen that page before in my life.

And I had no way, none, to be sure that was true.

Chapter 2: Slack Water

The Rockland office of Midcoast Secure Storage opened at nine, and I was standing in its parking lot at 8:52 with the wipers going and a key in my pocket that felt heavier every time I touched it.

The place was a gravel yard behind a chain-link fence, four long rows of orange roll-up doors under a sky the color of dishwater. A keypad stood on a post at the gate. I tried 1-1-4, because I'm not above trying. The keypad blinked red and told me nothing.

At nine exactly a woman in a fleece vest unlocked the office door from the inside. She had a lanyard, a space heater, and the expression of someone who has told a great many people no.

"Unit 114," I said, and put the brass key on the counter.

She looked at the key, then at me, then typed. "That's a B row. Tenant of record is Mara Brandt."

"My wife."

"Is she here?"

I'd practiced a few answers in the car. None of them survived the question. "She passed away. Five years ago this month."

The woman's face did something small and decent. She took her hands off the keyboard. "I'm sorry. I really am." Then she put them back. "It's prepaid. The whole term, in one payment, through the end of this month. Cash, it says. That's unusual."

"It was a long time ago."

"I can't open it for you, Mr. Brandt. I'd need your ID, a certified copy of the death certificate, and either letters of administration or a signed release from whoever's handling the estate. Corporate's strict. We had a thing with a divorce." She said it the way people mention a plane crash. "And the gate code's only given to the tenant of record, or the estate. Not to the key."

"I have the key."

"Everybody has a key. Keys are the least secure thing in the world." She slid mine back across the counter. "Bring the paperwork, and I'll walk you down myself. The manager's in Thursday if you want a ruling."

I could have argued. I'm good at arguing with clerks, I do it for a living. But the clock above her head said 9:14, high water was at 11:40, and Port

Carrow was an hour and a half south and east, with a storm surge sitting on the bay like a lid.

I said thank you. I took the key. And I looked down row B through the rain, at a hundred orange doors, and picked out the one I thought was 114 and hated it.

Five years she'd had that door. Five years I'd lived two hours from it.

I reached the causeway at 10:50. The sea had already made up its mind.

It's a mile and a quarter of single-lane road across the tidal flats, with a concrete rail on the bay side and a line of yellow poles marking where the road is supposed to be when you can't see it. At the mainland end there's a gravel turnout, a sign that says PORT CARROW IS AN ISLAND TWICE A DAY, and a pole with a gauge painted in feet. The gauge said three and a half. The road, forty yards out, had gone under a sheet of brown water that moved sideways, like a river that had lost its way.

A town truck was parked across the lane with its lights going. The man inside lowered his window an inch and shouted through the rain that the surge was

running two feet over the table, and that the road would likely open around four, maybe five, if the wind came round.

“Four or five,” I said.

“Or six. Or tomorrow. It’s the sea, mister.”

So I sat in the turnout with the engine off and the rain beating on the roof like a thousand small fingers, and I did what I’d have told anyone else to do. I read the file.

I read all thirty-one pages of it again, slowly, with a pencil, the way Hollis taught me: once for the story, once for the seams. I read the harbormaster’s statement, a single typed paragraph over a name I’d forgotten and a signature I hadn’t. *Observed the decedent alone aboard the Salt Ledger at approximately 1930 hours, with what appeared to be a bottle.* I read the ME’s finding: drowning, with a blood alcohol of .18. I read my own summary, my own words, a young man’s careful, sober, confident words.

And I read page seven, again and again, until it stopped looking like a page and started looking like a hole.

I couldn’t have said when the rain turned to something thinner. I only knew that the gauge dropped a foot, and then another, and that around three o’clock the town truck pulled out of the lane

and a man in a slicker walked along the yellow poles with a stick, testing the road the way you'd test a frozen pond.

The causeway opened at 4:20.

By then the light was going. I crossed in the last gray hour with the water still lying in sheets across the flats on both sides of me, flat and bright and dead still. Low tide, the turn between ebb and flood, when the sea stops pretending to make up its mind. Slack water. There's a stillness to it, like a held breath. The old fishermen say it's when the bay will tell you the truth, if you're stupid enough to ask it.

I wasn't asking. I was thinking about a dead woman's handwriting, and a hundred orange doors, and a man called Alan Farrow who'd been found face down in his own boathouse.

Port Carrow came up out of the dusk piece by piece. A white church. A gas pump. A harbor with the lights coming on one by one, and the long gray line of the breakwater running out to the bell buoy.

I didn't look at the breakwater.

I looked at it anyway.

The Farrow place stood on the north shore, at the end of a private road lined with rhododendrons that had been planted by someone who expected them to be admired. The house was big and shingled and dark. The boathouse stood below it at the water's edge, a long barn of a building on pilings with its big doors toward the cove, and a yellow ribbon snapping across the path.

A woman was waiting under the boathouse eave with her hands in the pockets of a black rain jacket. She watched me park, get out, and cross the wet lawn, and she did not appear to be in any hurry about any of it.

"You're Brandt," she said.

"Theo."

"Detective Nell Castellano, Maine State Police." She was perhaps thirty-seven, hard-faced in the way of people who sleep badly, with dark hair scraped back and the kind of eyes that make a list. She looked at me a half second longer than strangers do. Then it was gone, filed. "Atlantic Mutual said they'd sent somebody. They didn't say it was the same somebody who signed off on Lydia Farrow."

"They didn't mention it to me either, at first."

“No,” she said. “I’ll bet they didn’t.” She lifted the tape. “Don’t touch anything. If you do, I’ll know, and I’ll enjoy it.”

“Noted.”

“You’re allowed one question per minute. I’m in a mood.”

I ducked under the ribbon. “Why are you here at all? I thought it was a misadventure.”

“It is. Pending.” She got out a flashlight and clicked it on. “That’s what it says on the paperwork, and the paperwork is what the county medical examiner told us it should say. I’m here because I’m a nosy person who didn’t like the door.”

She pushed it open.

The boathouse was one big room, perhaps forty feet long, with a slip down the middle where a boat would sit in a normal week. The boat was gone, hauled for the season. What remained was black water, lapping at the pilings, level now with the walkway on either side, and a smell of salt, diesel, damp wood and something sweeter under it all, whisky. A workbench ran along the left-hand wall with a vise, a coil of line, a shelf of paint tins, and a green glass bottle, three-quarters empty, standing next to a heavy tumbler.

A second tumbler sat upside down on the drainboard of the little sink. Dry. Nell's light slid over it and kept going.

"This was the water line last night." She traced the wall with the beam, a stain a foot above her head. "Surge came over the sill about eleven. By midnight it was four feet in the slip and a little over the walkway. By two it was going out again. He went in, or he fell in, or somebody put him in, somewhere in there. The ME says between nine and midnight. He'll say more tomorrow."

"Who found him?"

"His housekeeper. Seven thirty, came to see why the house was dark. Door was shut. She couldn't open it, so she called the neighbor, the neighbor kicked at it for ten minutes, and in the end they got a pry bar. The door was locked from inside." She turned the light to the door we'd come through. "Look."

I looked. It was a heavy plank door, hung on iron strap hinges. On the inside, at about chest height, was a cast-iron hook that dropped into an eye bolted to the frame. A simple old gravity latch. The pry bar had torn the wood around the eye and left the hook hanging, a little bent.

"That's the only way in or out," she said. "The big doors on the cove are bolted from inside with a bar, and they're swollen shut. We checked. The windows are painted shut. He'd have had to walk in here, drop that hook behind him, pour himself a drink and fall in the water. Alone. Which he might've done. He's sixty-one, he had a bottle, he had a bad few months."

"But you don't like the door."

"I don't like any door that closes that neatly." She clicked the light off. In the dark the water made small sounds. "Tell me about the policy."

"Increased from two million to four-two a month ago. Cora Farrow's the beneficiary."

"The daughter. The one who can't stand him." Nell said it without inflection. "You'll want to meet her. Everyone does, sooner or later. She's made it clear she'd like to meet you first." A pause. "Where were you last night, Mr. Brandt?"

"Portland. In my office, under a bucket."

"Anyone with you?"

"A bucket."

"I'll put that in the report." But the corner of her mouth moved, and I thought, for the first time, that she might be funny when she wasn't working. "I'm

not accusing you. Yet. I just like to know where everyone was. Where were you before that? The week Lydia Farrow died. Six years ago."

"Portland. Sober, as it happens. I'd interviewed Alan, interviewed the harbormaster, got the ME's report. I wrote it up. It closed."

"It closed." She nodded slowly. "A lot of things in this county close, Mr. Brandt. They close very smoothly."

Something in her voice made me look at her. She met my eyes and gave me nothing.

"Go have dinner," she said. "I know you're going to; Hollis Dunn's been calling every motel on the island since noon. He heard you were coming. He's put a pot on."

"You know Hollis?"

"Everybody knows Hollis." She walked me to the tape. "He's the nicest man in Port Carrow. Mention the boathouse and he'll cry."

Hollis Dunn lived in a gray shingled cottage on Quarry Lane, up the hill from the harbor, with a garden he never weeded and a mooring he never skipped. His cutter, *Second Opinion*, rode below the house on the end of a pennant, a small tidy shape in

the dusk. He had the porch light on. He was standing in the doorway when my headlights found him, wearing the gray waxed coat that he'd worn for as long as I'd known him, with a dish towel over one shoulder, a pair of reading glasses on his forehead, and the smile that had been getting me through bad nights for a decade.

"Theodore," he said. "You look like a drowned cat."

"I feel like one."

"Good. It builds character. Come in, come in. There's stew, and God help you, there's tea."

It was the kitchen I knew, low-ceilinged, warm, smelling of woodsmoke and thyme, with the same chipped blue kettle on the stove and the same shelf of sailing paperbacks gone soft from the damp. He took my jacket and hung it by the fire, and for a few minutes, I'll admit it, I let myself be looked after. He ladled stew into a bowl and put it in front of me. He stirred his own cup, no sugar, never any sugar, and watched me eat.

He was sixty-eight and looked sixty. White hair that stood up in a crest, big gentle hands, a face made for being kind. He'd taught me everything I

knew. He'd driven to Rockport the morning I surfaced, sat with me for six hours in a plastic chair, and never once said *I told you so*.

"It's the anniversary," he said, at last. "Next week."

"Five days."

"I know. I've been thinking about her all week." He turned his cup a quarter turn on the table. "She was the best of us, you know. The rest of us just looked at the numbers. Mara looked at what was wrong with them."

I put down my spoon. I thought of a cream envelope in the inside pocket of my jacket, hanging a yard from the fire. I thought of *Not even the people who love you*. It's an odd thing to find out how much you'd like to confess something. I'd have told him everything in a breath. I wanted to. I could feel it sitting behind my teeth.

"They've sent me on the Farrow thing," I said.

"I heard." He wasn't surprised. "Reyes called me last night. Told me he'd put you on it, said it was about time somebody who'd seen Lydia's file looked at it. I told him I thought it was a terrible idea." He gave me a rueful look. "Not because you wouldn't be good at it. Because you'd be good at it, and it's the week it is, and nobody's looking after you."

"I'm fine, Hollis."

"You're a man who's counted eighteen hundred and twenty days of fine. Let me worry." He got up, poured more tea. "Is it true? The boathouse, the locked door?"

"Locked from inside. Nell Castellano thinks it's too tidy."

"Nell's a good cop." He shook his head. "God, poor Alan. That boathouse. That latch sticks in damp, always did. I told him a dozen times he'd lock himself in one of these days and drown like a rat."

"It's a terrible way to go," I said.

"Isn't it? The cold. The dark." Hollis stared into the stove for a moment, and I saw his eyes were wet. "I'm sorry. I knew him, you see. Not well. We sailed the same waters. He was a hard man, harder than he looked, but he was lonely, and there's no accounting for that." He cleared his throat and gave me the wry half-smile I'd loved for years. "I'm an old fool. Eat your stew."

I ate my stew.

He asked me about the work, and I told him some of it. He asked whether I'd found a way to sleep and I said there was a bucket in the office that helped, and he laughed until he had to take his glasses off. He asked whether I'd been to a meeting this week and I

said yes, which was nearly true. He told me about a family of otters that had moved into the cove. He told me about a woman at the library who'd been trying to marry him for a year. He didn't ask what I'd learned about Lydia, or what I'd found in her file, and I noticed, in a vague way I'd think about much later, that he didn't need to.

At nine he walked me out to the porch. The rain had stopped. A skin of cold had come down over the island, and the sky had broken in the west into long bars of black and silver.

"You'll stay at the Anchor Inn?"

"Yes."

"I'd have given you the spare room."

"I know. I wouldn't sleep."

"Nobody sleeps in the spare room. That's why I keep books in it." He put one big hand on my shoulder, and I felt the weight of it, and the warmth. "Theo. You'd tell me, wouldn't you? If there were something you needed to say."

For one second the porch went very quiet.

"Of course," I said.

"Good." He squeezed my shoulder and let go. "Go to bed. The sea will still be there in the morning."

My phone rang as I got to the car. A number I didn't know, with a Maine State Police prefix.

"It's Castellano," said the voice. "Where are you?"

"Quarry Lane. Leaving Hollis's."

"Don't go to the motel. Come to the county building on Mill Street. Around the back, there's a loading door. I'll be there." She didn't say please. "I need you to look at something."

"What?"

"Something that was in Alan Farrow's hand."

"His hand?"

"His right fist." Her voice was low and entirely level, which was how I knew she was frightened. "We didn't see it at the scene. They'd closed his hand around it, and it took the morgue to open it. It's a brass evidence tag, the old kind, with a string. A little stamped number and a name." She waited. "I'm told you'd know the style."

Behind me the porch light was still on. Behind that, in the shape of the window, Hollis stood with his tea, small and gray and gentle, watching me go.

"What does it say?" I asked.

"It says *T. Brandt, oh-four-one-seven.*"

I found myself sitting on the wet hood of the car, cold seeping through my trousers. The voice in the phone was ice-clear. I knew that tag, the stamp of it,

the exact fall of the numbers. Years ago, in a different life, I'd stamped that format on every exhibit I'd ever logged.

Tag 0417 had been Lydia Farrow's. The ship's log, in a sealed bag, in my own handwriting.

And the file I'd signed said it had never left my office.

Chapter 3: Tag 0417

The county building on Mill Street was a brick box from the sixties with a flagpole and no ambitions. At ten past ten at night the front was dark. Around the back, under a caged bulb, a steel loading door stood open six inches, and Nell Castellano stood in the gap with her arms crossed, as if she had been holding it against the weather for some time.

“You took your time.”

“I ate stew.”

“Of course you did.” She stepped back to let me in. “Walk where I walk.”

We went down a corridor that smelled of floor wax and refrigeration, past a door marked with a county seal and the word MORGUE in letters somebody had meant to make friendly. She didn’t take me in there. She took me instead to a windowless room with a steel table and two chairs, and shut the door, and put on the table a clear evidence bag with a flat brass tag inside.

I didn't pick it up. I didn't have to.

It was the old kind, the kind Atlantic Mutual stopped issuing the year before I left, a stamped oval the size of a pocket watch with a hole punched at the top and a loop of waxed cord run through it. The number was cut in with a hand die, the digits a little off the line. *T. BRANDT*. A dot. *0417*. The cord had been cut, not untied, and what remained was stiff and dark with water.

"That's mine," I said.

"Say more."

"The format's mine. I stamped every exhibit that way in my last three years at Atlantic. The claims office had a kit: dies, a block, a mallet. When they went to printed labels I bought the kit off the supply cage for forty dollars." I made myself look at it. "*T. Brandt* is my name. Zero-four-one-seven is the exhibit number. April, the seventeenth entry. Or the seventeenth exhibit of that year. I never decided which."

"And what was exhibit 0417?"

"The ship's log from the *Salt Ledger*. Lydia Farrow's boat. It was in a sealed bag with this tag tied through the zip. The log went to Atlantic's evidence archive in Portland when I closed the file, and the file says the tag went with it." I heard myself

saying it. "The file also says it never left my office, which is a contradiction I noticed about forty minutes ago."

"Forty minutes ago you were at dinner."

"I read the whole file on the road. The exhibit list on page twenty-nine says the log was tagged and bagged and held in my office pending transfer. Page thirty says transferred. Nobody mentions a tag coming off."

Nell sat. She did it slowly and kept her eyes on me while she did. "Was it ever off?"

"Not that I know of."

"Where's your kit now?"

"My office. In a banker's box in the closet, under the bucket." I paused. "Under the second bucket."

"You have two buckets."

"The roof has opinions."

She didn't smile, which told me it was going to be that kind of evening. She took out a notebook and uncapped a pen, and for the next hour I was a suspect in the death of Alan Farrow.

She was good at it. I know, because I've done the same job from the other chair. She never raised her voice. She asked the questions in the wrong order and then in the right one, and she wrote down what I said without looking at the page, and every few

minutes she asked something I'd already answered, in different words, to see whether it came back the same.

Where was I on the night of the eighth? In Portland, alone, until about ten, and then still alone. Did anyone see me? The man who runs the chandlery downstairs saw my light. Did I speak to anyone on the phone? No. Had I ever been inside the Farrow boathouse? Never. Had I seen Alan Farrow since Lydia died? Once, at the hearing on the estate. He hadn't spoken to me.

"Why did Atlantic pick you?"

"Reyes said I was the only adjuster who'd already read the file."

"Reyes sent you the file at 9:12 and called you at 9:12."

I stopped. I hadn't told her that. "How do you know that?"

"I asked his office for the time the file went out. They had it to the second. He was proud of it." She turned a page. "You didn't think that was strange?"

"I thought it was efficient. Then I thought it was strange."

"And in between?"

"I had other things on my mind."

"Such as?"

I thought about the letter. I thought about the key beside my car keys, and a dead woman's voice saying *especially them*. It was a long way to the surface of that answer.

"My wife's anniversary," I said. "Three days."

"October fourteenth," said Nell.

It was a light thing, said lightly, and I almost didn't catch it. But I hadn't told her the date. I had said *three days*, and she'd put the date on it the way you do with a number you've carried a long time. I looked at her. She was looking at her notebook, and her pen had stopped.

"It's in the paper," I said. "When she died."

"It is." The pen started again. "Five years. I'm sorry."

It sounded like a thing she'd had to say. And, I thought later, like she'd stopped herself from saying something else.

"Let me tell you what I have," she said. "I have a man dead in a locked room who was strong enough, and sober enough on a normal night, to be hard to drown. I have a bottle of whisky with only his prints on it. I have a boathouse door that was latched from the inside, on a night when the tide came over the sill. I have a tag with your name on it in a dead man's hand. And I have you, the man who signed off on his

first wife's death, arriving the day after, from a town two hours away, with a face like you've been up since Tuesday."

"It's Saturday."

"It's Sunday," she said. "Past midnight."

I hadn't known that either.

"Here's what I don't have," she went on. "I don't have a reason for you to put your own name in his hand. If you did it, you're a fool, and you don't strike me as a fool. If someone else did, they went to the trouble of getting a thing out of your old files and putting it where I'd find it. That means they wanted me to look at you. Or wanted you to look at yourself." She closed the notebook. "Which is it, Mr. Brandt?"

"I don't know."

"Good. That's the first honest answer you've given me."

She went to a metal cabinet against the wall and took out a manila folder, and from it a sheaf of papers stapled at the corner. She laid it in front of me, face up.

"Scene inventory. Everything we bagged in the boathouse. I'd like you to read it and tell me what's missing from the story you're building."

It was eleven pages of small type. I did what I'd been taught and read it twice, once for the story and once for the seams. Tools. Line. Paint. A pair of reading glasses, a dead flashlight, a cushion from the bench. The bottle, the tumbler, the prints. A brass padlock without a key. A wallet and a set of house keys in Alan's coat, which had been hanging by the door. Two rolls of paper towel, one wet. Under *Trash receptacle (galvanized, beside bench)* a short, boring list: a crushed beer can, a cigar butt, a banana peel, a used tea bag with string and paper tag, a torn receipt from Hanley's Hardware. Under *Sink*: one tumbler, inverted, dry, clean, no prints.

"Clean," I said. "No prints at all."

"Rinsed and wiped. Or never used." She leaned on the table. "Alan Farrow lived alone. A housekeeper comes in at seven. He drinks his own whisky from his own glass, and a second glass, washed and dry, is sitting on the drainboard of a sink in a boathouse. Why?"

"Because he had a guest."

"Or because he was tidy."

"Is he tidy?"

"His housekeeper says he left coffee cups in every room of the house for thirty years." She tapped the line with a fingernail. "So I'll say it again. Why?"

“Someone drank with him. Or was offered a drink and said no.”

“And left, and latched the door behind them?” She shook her head. “You can’t latch that door from outside. I tried it for an hour this afternoon with a screwdriver, a coat hanger and some very bad language. Then I got a locksmith who said you can’t do it, either. I hated that.”

“Then he was alone.”

“Then he was alone, or a ghost took the other glass.” She straightened. “That’s two things I can’t make fit. A door and a glass. I’ve learned to be nervous when it’s two. One’s an accident. Three’s a conspiracy. Two is somebody thinking.”

I read the line about the glass again, and the tea bag, and the hardware receipt, and none of them told me anything. A man had been in his boathouse with a bottle of whisky and a banana. It was a night in a storm. I pushed the paper back to her.

“It’s a good inventory,” I said. “I don’t see what you don’t.”

“Neither do I.” She looked tired. “I’m going to ask you something, and I’d like you to think before you answer it. Is there anything you aren’t telling me?”

I thought about the envelope in the inside pocket of my jacket, which was on the back of my chair. The brass key in my pocket. *Not anyone. Not even the people who love you.*

"Yes," I said.

She waited.

"I can't tell you yet."

"Can't, or won't?"

"I got something the other night. It's from someone I trust more than I trust myself. She asked me not to tell anyone until I'd seen what it leads to. I don't know why. I'm going to find out. When I know, I'll tell you." I heard how it sounded. "I realize that's what a guilty man would say."

"It's what a guilty man would say," Nell agreed. "It's also what an honest one would say, if he was scared." She stood, and I stood, and for a moment we were two tired people in a windowless room. "I'll give you until the ME report. Tuesday. After that I come looking, and I bring paper."

"Fair."

"It isn't," she said. "But it's what I've got." She opened the door. "Stay in Port Carrow. Don't leave town. Don't touch the boathouse. Don't talk to Cora Farrow."

"Why not Cora?"

“Because she’ll talk to you first, and I want to know what she says.”

The Anchor Inn had eleven rooms, and by the look of the lot I had the only guest. A night clerk with a paperback gave me a key to number six and a look that said the town had already talked. The room smelled of lemon polish and old radiator. The window faced the harbor and the breakwater. I pulled the curtain across it without looking and lay on the bed in my clothes with the tag still behind my eyes.

I slept for a few hours. I know because I woke at six to a gray light, a gull on the sill, and the sure feeling that someone had been standing at the foot of the bed. The room was empty. The chain was on the door.

At seven I went down to the dining room for coffee and found that the town had indeed talked. The waitress put a cup in front of me without being asked and said, in a low voice, “You’ll want the corner table.” I didn’t know why until I saw who was sitting at the next one.

She was twenty-four and looked like her mother. I’d lived with her photograph for a month, six years ago: the long jaw, the dark brows, a stubbornness

that had gone to the bones early. Cora Farrow sat very straight with both hands around a mug and her coat still on, as though she'd refused the invitation to stay. She had the flat, scrubbed look of someone who hadn't slept and didn't intend to apologize for it.

"Mr. Brandt."

"Ms. Farrow. I'm sorry for your loss."

"Which one?" Her voice was low and steady, with no softness in it anywhere. "I'm not asking to be difficult. I've had two in six years, and I've never been sure which of you people to thank for the paperwork."

"I'm sorry about both."

"Don't be. Sit down."

I sat.

"I'm told you can't talk to me," she said. "The police woman told me that at the house. She wanted me to know it. I thought you should hear that I don't care." She took a breath. "My father is dead and I'm going to be rich and everyone in this town thinks I did it. I don't mind. I want to know who did."

"Then we want the same thing."

"I doubt it." She reached into the pocket of her coat and put something on the table between us. A folded sheet of paper, soft at the creases, as though it

had been opened and closed many times. “My mother called you.”

I didn’t touch it.

“Eight days before she died,” said Cora. “March fifth. I was eighteen, at school in Vermont. She called me that night from the kitchen and told me she was frightened of my father, and that she’d phoned a man at his insurance company who’d promised to look into it. A man who said he’d take care of it.” Her voice didn’t waver, and I understood that was the cost of it. “She never said the name. She said, ‘He was very kind.’ Then she died, and a man named Theo Brandt came to the funeral in a good coat and told me he was sorry, and said there was no sign of anything wrong.”

“Ms. Farrow—”

“I’ve kept her phone bill for six years. It was in a drawer at the house. I took it the week after the funeral, because I thought, someday.” She slid the paper an inch toward me. “That’s the page. The number’s highlighted.”

I unfolded it. It was a cell phone statement for March, a single sheet with a column of numbers and times. One line, near the bottom of the page, was marked in yellow.

03/05 4:52 PM Outgoing 207-555-0188 9 min.

I knew the number. I'd had it for eleven years.

It was the direct line to my desk at Atlantic Mutual. It had stayed with me through three office moves and a transfer. And I'd have remembered a call.

"I never spoke to your mother," I said. "I never spoke to her before her death. I met her in a photograph."

"Nine minutes," said Cora. "Somebody answered it. Nobody has that long to leave a message."

"I was in the field on the fifth. I know that because —" I stopped, because I didn't know it. I only knew the file said I'd been in the field, in a hand I'd always trusted. I tried to summon the day and got a gray square, flat and dry, like a photograph of a wall.

March fifth. Eight days before she died. Six years ago. Sober. I'd been six months sober and counting every one.

"Mr. Brandt?"

"I didn't take that call," I said. "Somebody did."

"Then who?"

I looked at the page. The yellow line. The number I'd had for eleven years, answered for nine minutes by a man who'd been kind, and who had, a week later, typed a page I'd never seen and signed it with my name.

Chapter 4: The Seventh Page

Dolores Pike answered on the ninth ring, with a television going behind her and the voice of a woman who had been interrupted at a Sunday roast.

"Theo Brandt," she said. "Well. I'd heard you were back on the Farrow thing. Desmond's had the whole third floor whispering since Friday."

"I need a favor, Dolores."

"You always do. You always say it like that, too, like you're asking to borrow a kidney."

I stood at the window of room six with the curtain open an inch and Cora's phone bill flat on the sill. Down on the harbor road a man in a yellow slicker was hosing the deck of a lobster boat that didn't need it. I asked her what she remembered about the phones in the claims annex six years ago.

"The phones." She turned the television down. "Lord. You mean the Nortel business."

Dolores Pike had run the claims annex front desk for twenty-two years. She knew where every file was and every person who had lied about where it was. When I started at Atlantic she told me which vending machine gave change and which supervisor to never, ever get in an elevator with. I had once watched her talk a man out of a lawsuit using only a stapler.

"The direct lines," I said. "Mine was 0188. Who picked it up when I was in the field?"

"Whoever was nearest. You didn't have an assistant, hon. You had *me*, and the overflow." She paused. "In March? You were out half that month. The Searsport total loss, and the cannery thing in Rockport."

"The cannery thing."

"Don't ask me, it's your cannery." I could hear her thinking. "We forwarded your line to the overflow desk when you were out. Anybody on the floor could take it. And the retirees who still came in for the training program had the overflow desk on Thursdays. March fifth was a Thursday, wasn't it?"

It was. I'd looked it up in the car.

"Who had the desk that Thursday?"

"Theo, I can't tell you that. I couldn't tell you what I had for lunch." A spoon rang against a cup. "There's a log. The phone system kept forwarding records. Or

it did until the changeover. They wiped everything older than four years when we went to the new system. Desmond signed off on it himself, I remember, because Legal squawked.”

“Reyes signed off.”

“Reyes signs off on the weather. He’s that kind.” Her voice softened. “Is this about the girl? The daughter?”

“It’s about a call.”

“Then I’ll tell you what I’d tell any adjuster who asked. If it was a call that mattered, somebody wrote it down. Look in the overflow binder. Pink sheets. Anyone who took a call for you filled one out, and I filed them by quarter.”

“Where’s the binder?”

“Archive, in Portland. Or the dumpster. Honestly, either.” She let out a long breath. “Don’t go in there on a Sunday. I’ll look tomorrow when I get in. Nobody watches me. I’m furniture.”

“Dolores, don’t tell Reyes.”

“Hon,” she said, “I haven’t told Desmond Reyes a thing since 2011.”

When I hung up the gull was on the sill again, looking at me with one flat yellow eye. I told it I’d tried.

Hollis's study was at the back of the cottage, a narrow room that had once been a pantry and now held about two thousand books, an oak desk, a green-shaded lamp and an old Selectric under a quilted cover, which he used, he'd told me once, for Christmas cards and letters to the editor. A gray waxed coat hung from a hook behind the door, still stiff with last night's weather. The room smelled of tea and paper and the particular dust of a man's lifetime.

He'd said come at noon. When I got there he'd already cleared the desk and set out two mugs.

"You look like something the cat declined to bring in," he said. "Sit. I've read your message four times."

I'd told him on the phone only that I needed a second pair of eyes on the Lydia file. I'd said nothing about the tag in Alan's hand, nothing about Cora or the phone bill. I'd had the odd, closed feeling in my chest that you get at a door you've walked through all your life, and I hadn't examined why, because I didn't want the answer.

I opened the laptop and brought up the scan. Thirty-one pages. I turned the screen toward him and scrolled to the seventh.

He read it the way he read everything, slowly, lips pressed, one finger moving down the margin without touching the glass. The blocky type. The smudged capitals. Three paragraphs summarizing an interview with Alan Farrow, and then the sentence I'd been staring at for two days: *There is no evidence of third-party involvement.*

"I never wrote this," I said. "I remember the interview. I remember what Alan said, and it isn't what this says. He was shaking. He wouldn't look at me. I wrote that down. It's on page six, in my own words. This is a different page, in a different hand, that agrees with a conclusion I hadn't yet reached."

"Hm." He scrolled up, then down. He went back to the signature. "That's your signature."

"It looks like my signature."

"It looks *exactly* like it." He took his glasses off and pinched the bridge of his nose. "Theo, I have to say something that you won't like, and I'd rather say it now than have you hear it from Castellano. You were six months sober then. Six months is a raw age. You did a hundred things that year you don't remember doing. You wrote me a postcard from Bangor I've still got, and you've never been to Bangor."

"This isn't a postcard."

“No.” He put the glasses back on. “No, it isn’t. I know it isn’t. I’m only saying: before we decide somebody forged a page, let’s agree what we’d have to believe. That someone had access to your file. Knew your signature. Had a typewriter and a reason.” He tapped the page with one finger. “That font, now. Do you know what that is?”

“I thought maybe an old Atlantic template.”

“It’s Courier. A poor man’s Courier, run through a bad ribbon. Atlantic used it on addenda in the eighties and nineties. Any adjuster who’d been there before the redesign would have the form in a drawer.” He looked up, and his face was gentle and clear. “I could produce that page myself in ten minutes, if I had to. So could Alan’s lawyer. So could Desmond Reyes, who started in the mail room.”

I looked at the quilted shape on the stand across the room, and it was only a typewriter. A man with a typewriter in his study is not a clue. A man with a typewriter in his study is a man who writes Christmas cards.

“Who else saw the file?” he asked.

“Reyes had it in the archive. Pryor, the ME, saw the autopsy portion. Tarbell gave the statement.”

"Ned Tarbell." Hollis nodded slowly. "The harbormaster. I'd talk to Ned. He's a good man, a bit slow, and he's afraid of the sea, which is a strange thing for a harbormaster. If he signed something he didn't read, he'll know." He closed the laptop gently and slid it back to me. "And Theo, I'd keep this between us for now. Reyes especially. Don't tell him what you've found. A man who sends the file at 9:12 and calls at 9:12 is a man who's thought about it."

I stared at him. "How did you know it was 9:12?"

It came out too fast. I heard it in the room.

"Reyes, I expect," Hollis said, with no pause at all. "He rang me Friday night. Or somebody did, Theo, I've had a houseful of telephone calls since Alan, and half of them were Port Carrow's finest asking me to be quiet." He smiled, a little rueful. "My memory's gone to rags. Forgive me."

I hadn't told him. Nell had told me, in the county building, after I'd left his table. But Reyes had phoned Hollis the night before, and Reyes was proud of the minute, and Reyes was exactly the kind of man to say *I sent it the very second*. It was a small thing. It was nothing. I'd have said it myself.

"It's all right," I said.

"I'm an old fool," said Hollis. He stirred his tea. I never took sugar either.

The Cutter's Rest was the one diner in Port Carrow, and on a Sunday afternoon it held a few fishermen, a table of church ladies and one man in a corner booth with his back to the wall.

I knew he was Voss before he stood up. I'd never met him, but you can tell the ex-cops by how they take up a booth. He was in his fifties, thick through the shoulders and thinner everywhere else, in a tweed jacket that had been good during a previous administration. His hair was cut short by someone who did not love him. He had a coffee, a half-eaten slice of pie, and in front of him, face-up on the table, a business card.

"Barrett Voss," he said. "I'd offer a hand, but I'm told you don't trust mine."

"Who told you that?"

"My client. Sit down, Mr. Brandt, before the ladies in the corner decide I'm arresting you."

I sat. The waitress came, and I ordered coffee. When she'd gone, he slid the card an inch across the table. BARRETT VOSS, INVESTIGATIONS. A Portland number and no slogan.

"Cora hired me in June," he said. "Before her father died, which I want you to note, because the Staties will make a meal of it. She wanted someone

to look at her mother's death. She'd found a name in her father's papers, and she'd got it into her head that someone was lying about Lydia. I told her what I tell everyone. Eighty percent of the time, nobody's lying. The other twenty, it's the person you least want it to be."

"What did you find?"

"Mostly a closed file, with your name on it." He said it without heat. "It was a good one, I'll give you that. Complete. Clean. Well documented. I read it in a motel in Camden and I thought, this man's careful. Then I got to the harbormaster's statement and I thought, this man is *very* careful, and I didn't like it."

"Why not?"

"Because it's perfect." He put down his fork. "A witness who saw the victim aboard alone, drinking, the afternoon before. Who happens to be the one man in the harbor positioned to see it. Who's never been interviewed on anything else in thirty years. Who signed in blue-black ink, a month after the signature was typed. That kind of statement doesn't happen. It gets made."

I said nothing. I was thinking of page seven.

"I tried Tarbell in August," Voss went on. "He wouldn't see me. Sent his wife to the door. Said the matter was closed and it upset him. Then, in

September, I'm in the Rite Aid parking lot in Rockland, and he walks past my car with a bag of pills, and he looks at me like he's seen a dead man in a window. Twenty seconds. Then he's gone." He turned his coffee cup a quarter turn. "Something's eating that man. He wants to say it, and he can't, and I'm the wrong person to say it to. You're not."

"Why would he talk to me?"

"Because you signed the file. If he lied, he lied to you, in a way. Men like that get a sense of obligation." He leaned back. "Also, because he's scared of cops and scared of me. He isn't scared of you yet. Use that."

"I've been told to stay out of this."

"By the nice detective? She'll tell you the same thing she told me. She's right, and it won't help." He finished the pie in two bites. "One more thing. Not free advice, but it's on the house. Somebody's been behind me for a week."

"Behind you."

"Gray Buick. Maine plate, rental sticker. Parked across from my motel in Rockland for two days. Followed me up Route 1 on Thursday and back on Saturday. I lost him once, at the Dunkin' in Thomaston, and found him again in the same spot, which tells me he knew where I was going." He

wiped his mouth. "He doesn't know who I'm following, but he knows I'm following. I thought you ought to know it's getting crowded."

"Why tell me?"

"Because Cora says you're not the one who killed her father," said Voss. "And Cora has a very good nose for liars. She's had practice."

I thought about that for a moment. "She told me this morning she doesn't care who says I can't talk to her."

"Did she?" He seemed pleased. "Then she's decided you're useful. Same thing, with her."

He stood, dropped a ten on the table and picked up his hat, which was an actual hat. "Tarbell lives on Pier Road, the green house with the dory in the yard. Go before dark. He eats at five, and he goes to bed with the radio. After seven he won't open the door." He looked at me levelly. "And Brandt. Whatever you've got in that jacket, the one you keep touching, I'd put it somewhere safer than your pocket."

I hadn't noticed I was touching it.

I went to Pier Road. It was ten past four. The green house stood at the end of the road with its back to the water: a narrow clapboard house, shutters

closed, a battered dory propped on blocks in the yard with ferns growing out of the bow. A woman in a cardigan came to the door and told me, through the chain, that Ned was lying down. She didn't ask who I was. She looked at my face, and I saw that she knew.

"Come back tomorrow," she said. "Please. In the morning, when he's himself."

"Mrs. Tarbell, it matters."

"It's mattered for six years." She shut the door. It was very quiet.

I stood in the yard with the wind coming off the harbor. The dory's name was painted on the transom in white: *Second Chance*. The boat in the yard looked as if it hadn't been in the water in a very long time. I wondered what it was to name a boat for a thing you didn't believe in.

My phone rang as I got back to the car. The screen said GUS CHANDLERY.

"Theo." Gus's voice was thick and careful, like a man walking on ice. "You need to come home. Somebody's been in your office."

"When?"

"I don't know. I was out front doing the Sunday tally, and I saw your door was open. Frame's cracked." He swallowed. "They didn't take the

computer. They didn't take the cash in the drawer. I've been up there twenty minutes. Whoever it was, they went straight to the closet."

I closed my eyes. "The banker's box."

"Under the buckets. Yes." A pause. "How'd you know?"

"What's missing, Gus?"

"The box is gone," said Gus. "And Theo, I looked around. Nothing else is. Not your files. Not your pens. They left it all. They just took that one box. The one with the stamps in it."

I stood in a stranger's yard with a dead dory at my back. I wasn't thinking *who*. I was thinking about the day. They knew which closet, which box, and that it mattered before I'd said a word about it to anyone.

Somewhere behind the green house, in the dusk, a radio came on.

Chapter 5: The Statement

I called Nell from the car, before I had time to talk myself out of it.

“Castellano.”

“Somebody broke into my office in Portland this afternoon,” I said. “They took the kit I use to stamp exhibits. The one that made the tag in Alan Farrow’s hand.”

The line was quiet long enough that I checked the screen. Then: “You’re telling me this now.”

“I’m telling you the hour I found out.”

“You told me last night your kit was in the closet. That was a statement. Now it’s gone, and you’d like me to hear it as bad luck.”

“I’d like you to hear it as what it is. Whoever did it wants you to think I made that tag last week, and nobody can say I didn’t.” I started the engine for the heat. “I’m not asking you to like it. I’m asking you to send somebody to look at the door.”

“Portland PD has a car on it already. Your landlord called it in.” Another pause. “Mr. Brandt, I want you to hear how that sounds from my side. A man who’s the only suspect with a reason to say ‘someone’s framing me’ gets framed on cue.”

“Yes.”

“I also think a man who wanted to hide a kit would have burned it, not left an open door and a cracked frame for the whole street.” She exhaled. “Tuesday. Nine a.m. Don’t make me come find you.”

“Understood.”

“And Brandt.” Something in her voice shifted, as if she’d put down a heavy thing and picked up a lighter one. “Sleep.”

I didn’t, much. I ate a bowl of chowder at the Anchor Inn standing up, and went to bed at nine, and lay awake with the radio from Pier Road still going in my head, a thin tune under a man’s snoring. At two I got up and checked the chain. It was on.

Dolores called at ten past eight on Monday. I was already in the car on Pier Road, a hundred yards short of the green house, with a bag of doughnuts I’d bought so I’d have something in my hands.

“I found it,” she said, “and I wish I hadn’t.”

“Tell me.”

“The binder’s in the archive, in a banker’s box marked ADMIN OVERFLOW, Q1. Right where I said. Fourth cage from the back.” She was whispering. I could hear a fan. “I went in at seven, before the day crew. The pink sheets are all there, Theo. January, February. Then March first, March second, March third, March fourth. Then March sixth.”

“Not the fifth.”

“Cut out. Not torn. Cut, along the perforation, with a blade. You can’t tell unless you hold the page up and look at the stub. And the carbon behind it’s gone, too.” She swallowed. “Whoever did it was careful. They didn’t leave a ragged edge. They knew the sheets were in duplicate.”

“Who’s signed the archive log?”

“Sign-in sheet, front desk. Last person in that cage was somebody with a badge from the third floor. Friday the ninth, three in the afternoon.” Another breath. “The log says ‘D. Reyes, office.’ Not Desmond himself. His office.”

“Friday afternoon.”

“After he sent you the file. Before anybody could’ve known you’d ask for the binder.” She stopped. “I don’t know what that means. I’m furniture. I’m just telling you what the paper says.”

Reyes had sent me a thirty-one-page file at 9:12 on Thursday night and, by Friday at three, somebody from his office had gone through a cage to cut out one slip of pink paper. It could mean he'd known exactly what he was sending me. It could mean someone wanted the paper to say so.

"Thank you, Dolores. Leave it where it is. Don't touch the stub."

"Honey," she said, "I've been touching nothing since 1998."

Mrs. Tarbell let me in this time.

She stood aside without a word, in the same gray cardigan, with her hands folded in front of her as though she were holding a hymnal. The house was close and warm and smelled of coffee and radiator dust. A kitchen with a yellow table, a calendar from the Co-op, a window over the sink that looked straight out at the dory.

"He's up," she said. "He's been up since four." She seemed about to say more and didn't. "He'll want you to eat something. He won't say so."

I put the doughnuts on the table. She looked at them and, to my surprise, nearly smiled.

Ned Tarbell came in from the back room in a wool shirt buttoned to the collar. He was past sixty, a big soft man who had been bigger once, with a harbormaster's windburned face and hands. He held his shoulders like a man carrying a pail too full of water. His eyes went to me and then to the floor.

"You're Brandt."

"Yes, sir."

"Sit, then."

I sat. He stood a moment longer, then lowered himself into the chair across from me with a sound that wasn't quite a sigh. His wife poured coffee and withdrew as far as the doorway, where she stayed.

I'd planned an opening. I'd planned several. I'd rehearsed them in the car with the heater running and discarded them all. Looking at him, I saw the thing I'd come to say was already sitting on the table between us. He'd been carrying it for six years, and he was tired.

"Mr. Tarbell," I said, "I read your statement about Lydia Farrow."

"I know you did."

"I'd like to hear it from you. Not the paper. What you actually saw."

He picked up his cup and put it down without drinking. "Why? You wrote it."

"I didn't."

It was a very small word to say into a kitchen. I watched it reach him. His head came up, and for the first time he looked at me directly, and I saw that his eyes were a pale, washed gray, red at the rims.

"You came to the harbor office," he said. "April. A Tuesday. It was raining."

"I wasn't there."

"You were. You sat in the chair by the stove." He lifted a hand and put it flat on the table, as if bracing it. "You had a briefcase. You said you were Theo Brandt from Atlantic Mutual and you showed me your card. I looked at the card. It had your name and the little blue anchor. You said Mrs. Farrow's death was a sad business and they only needed to tidy up a few points for the file. You had it typed already. A page and a half. You said, you just sign at the bottom, Ned, and it's done. You said I'd done a kindness, to tell what I'd seen."

"And what had you seen?"

He was quiet. The refrigerator hummed.

"I told you I'd seen the boat on her mooring the evening before," he said. "Salt Ledger. I saw a light in the cabin. I told you I'd seen Mrs. Farrow on deck, once, about six. And you said, and was she alone? And I said, I think so. And you said, and was she

drinking? And I said, I don't know. I couldn't tell you. And you smiled and said that's fine, we'll put 'it appeared so,' and you read it back to me. It sounded right. You read it nicely." He lifted his eyes to me. "I signed it."

"You said it was typed already."

"I said you had it typed. Then you wrote some things in the margin. Then you took it away and brought it back clean, in a day or two. And that was the one I signed." He rubbed his thumb along the table's edge. "It wasn't what I said. Not exactly. I didn't say 'bottle.' I never said 'bottle.' But it sounded the way I'd have said it if I'd said it. And you were so kind about it."

"Mr. Tarbell." I kept my voice level. "Look at me. Is that the man you met?"

He looked. I let him. I sat in the thin kitchen light and let a frightened man go over my face as if he were searching a drawer. He looked at my mouth. He looked at my hands. His wife, in the doorway, had stopped breathing.

"I said it was you," Ned Tarbell said slowly. "I've said it for six years. I said it to the police. I said it to my wife."

"But?"

"But I thought you were—" He stopped. His hand moved on the table. "No. It was you. You said your name. I had the card."

"Cards can be handed to anyone."

"The man said he was Brandt." He said it as though pressing on a bruise. "That's what I know. I wrote it down. I know what I know."

"I'm not saying you're lying," I said. "I'm saying someone may have walked into your office with my card and my name and my signature, and been kind to you."

"Why?"

"I don't know yet."

"Did you do it?" he asked.

"No."

He nodded, once. Then he turned his head toward the window, and the dory, and the gray harbor behind it, and said in a different voice, very low, "I never saw her drink."

His wife made a small sound.

"I saw the boat, and the light, and her on the deck at six. She had a cup in her hand. A mug. She was looking at the water, and she waved at me. She waved. I've never told anyone that, because nobody asked, and the man said it didn't matter." He wet his lips. "She wasn't drunk. She was lifting her hand."

And I put my name to *it appeared so*, after she was already in the ground. And every night since I lie there and think, if she wasn't drunk, how did she go over? A woman who waves doesn't go over. And somebody's got to say."

"Say it to Detective Castellano."

He stiffened.

"She's honest," I said. "I think she's the best chance you've got. If you tell her what you've told me, there's a record, and you're the man who came forward, not the man who got caught. Tomorrow at nine, the county building. I'll drive you."

"I don't leave the house much," said Tarbell.

"I know."

"I don't like the water." He gave a laugh with no breath in it. "That's a joke on a harbormaster. I was thirty before I told anyone. I'd stand on the wharf and my hands would sweat. But I like the harbor. The lights at night. I just don't like to be in it." He turned back to me. "You'll drive me?"

"I'll be on the step at eight-thirty."

His wife came forward. She put a hand, briefly, on his shoulder, and he reached up and covered it. It was the most private thing I'd seen in a month, and I looked at my coffee.

“There’s one more thing,” I said. “The man who came that Tuesday. Anything about him that wasn’t me? I don’t mean his face. Anything. A smell. A habit.”

Tarbell frowned at the table. A long minute passed. The refrigerator cycled off, and in the quiet I could hear the wind working at the shutters.

“He took his coat off,” he said. “And put it back on. Like it was warm, and then it wasn’t. He was a talker. He made you feel you’d done well.” He shook his head. “I’m sorry. I thought it was you, so I never looked for anything else.”

“That’s all right,” I said, and found that my voice wasn’t entirely steady. “Tomorrow, then.”

At the door Mrs. Tarbell gripped my sleeve. She was a small woman and her fingers were strong.

“He hasn’t slept in a week,” she whispered. “Since the storm. Since they said Mr. Farrow’s name on the radio. He’s been walking the house.” Her eyes were wet. “You’ll bring him home?”

“I will.”

I didn’t know what to do with the rest of the day, so I did what I always do, and went to find Hollis.

The cottage on Quarry Lane was warm and smelled of bread. He'd been baking, which he did when he was worried and wouldn't say so, and he put a hot heel of it in my hand at the door before I'd said hello.

"Sit. Eat. You've the look of a man who went into a church and came out of a confessional."

I told him about Tarbell: the card, the page and a half, the wave. I had no reason to hold anything back from the man I'd been confiding in for twenty years. When I got to the part about tomorrow, he put down his knife.

"He's going to Castellano."

"At nine."

"Good," said Hollis. He said it quietly, warmly, with his eyes on the loaf. "Good man. It's a heavy thing to carry that long. I'm glad he's put it down." He glanced up. "And you'll go with him."

"I told him I would."

"Of course." He cut another slice and buttered it, and did not look at it. "Theo, tell me. When he looked at you. Did he know you? I mean, did he *know* you? A man can look at a card for six years and see the wrong face."

"He wasn't sure."

“Poor devil.” Hollis shook his head. “I’d tell Castellano to go gently. Frightened witnesses fold if you push. He’ll want his wife in the room.” He pushed the plate toward me. “Now eat that. It’ll be a long day tomorrow, and I’d like you standing up for it.”

I ate it. It was good bread. I was grateful for it, and I remember being grateful.

I told him, too, about the pink binder, the cut stub, the log: *D. Reyes, office*. He listened with his head tilted, and said, “Well. That’s a man who can’t be bothered to lie well.” And then, after a moment, “Or one who wants to be seen not bothering.”

It was a clever thing to say, and I said so.

“I had a good teacher,” said Hollis, and winked, and refilled my tea.

I left at nine with a loaf under my arm. He stood in the lit door in his shirtsleeves until I’d reached the lane. The night was clear and cold, the storm’s wind finally gone, the sky above Port Carrow so thickly starred that it looked unreal. In the harbor, the cutters moved gently on their moorings. I stood for a minute at the end of the lane and breathed.

Then I went back to the Anchor Inn, put the chain on, and for the first time in four days slept like a man who had set something down.

The phone woke me at ten to six.

I knew it was Nell before I looked. There's a way a call comes through in the dark that feels like a hand on the shoulder.

"Brandt."

"I'm here."

"Where were you last night?" She said it flatly. No hello. Her voice was thick and a little hoarse, and behind it I could hear wind, and gulls, and the slap of water on a hull.

"The Anchor Inn. In bed by ten. The night clerk saw me come in."

"Anyone with you?"

"No. Why?"

"Because I'm standing on Pier Road, at the town landing." She stopped. I heard her take one breath, then another. "A lobsterman found Ned Tarbell's skiff at five-fifteen, drifting off the breakwater with the engine cut and a hand trailing in the water. He was in it."

I sat up. The room tilted. Outside the window the harbor was a flat pewter plate, and on it, a long way out, small and dark against the lightening sky, was a boat with men standing round it.

“His wife says he went out at midnight,” said Nell. “She says he never went out. That he was afraid of the water.”

“He was afraid of the water,” I said.

“Yes,” said Nell, very quietly. “That’s what I keep thinking. Get dressed, Brandt. And bring that envelope.”

Chapter 6: Gray Water

The town landing at six in the morning looked like a place where nothing had ever happened to anyone.

A strip of wet concrete, a hoist, a stack of lobster crates, and the harbor lying flat and colorless beyond it. Two Port Carrow patrol cars sat nose to nose with their lights off. A uniformed officer was stringing yellow tape between a piling and a bait barrel, and the tape kept lifting in the wind, as though it didn't want to be part of this either.

The skiff was already on the hoist. Twelve feet of white fiberglass, an outboard tipped up on its bracket, a green plastic bailer. Ned Tarbell lay in the bottom boards in the wool shirt he'd worn to talk to me, buttoned to the collar. Someone had closed his eyes. His right hand still hung over the gunwale and nobody had moved it yet, the fingers just brushing the air above the water he'd been afraid of for sixty years.

I stopped at the tape. I'd seen a lot of the dead, in my line. Mostly after: in photographs, in reports, in the tidy past tense of a file. I had not seen one I'd drunk coffee with the day before.

"Brandt."

Nell Castellano came up the landing with her hands in the pockets of the black jacket and her hair coming loose from its clip. She looked as though she'd been awake for a week. She took in my face and something in her own gave a little.

"Sit down before you fall down," she said. "There's a bollard."

"I'm all right."

"You're the color of that boat." She didn't wait. She took my elbow, steered me to the bollard, and I sat. "Breathe. Then I'm going to ask you things, and you're going to answer them in order."

I breathed. A gull walked along the lobster crates, looking at us with professional interest.

"The lobsterman is Eddie Marsh," she said. "He was hauling at five, saw a skiff turning on the current with no one at the tiller. Thought somebody'd been drinking. He came alongside, found Ned. Cold, wet, face up. His head was against the thwart and his

hand was in the water.” She lifted her chin at the hoist. “No marks I can see. No blood. The engine was cut, not stalled. The kill-cord was in his pocket.”

“He didn’t go out on the water.”

“So I’m told. By everyone who knew him.” She crouched in front of me so our eyes were level. “Where’s the envelope?”

I took it out of my jacket. I’d been carrying it in the inside pocket for three days, against the ribs, and it had warmed to the shape of my body. I gave it to her without a word.

She opened it standing, reading with her back to the wind. She read the first lines, and I watched her go still in a way that wasn’t the stillness of an investigator. It was the stillness of a person who has been handed the voice of someone they thought they’d never hear again.

“Your wife’s hand,” she said.

“Yes.”

“I know that handwriting.”

I looked at her.

“From the file.” It came out half a beat late. “I read her death report when I took this job. The one the state police closed. Her signature was on the

incident form as a witness to nothing. It's very distinctive." She folded the page along its creases, carefully, as if it could still be hurt. "The wave."

"The wave."

"May I keep this?"

"Photograph it. I'll keep the original."

She looked at me a long moment, then nodded and took out her phone. While she did, I told her about the key, the Rockland storage unit, the clerk's refusal, and Quill's instruction on his client's behalf: *He'll want to call someone. Tell him not to.* I kept the other line to myself. *Not even the people who love you. Especially them.* I wasn't sure why. It seemed like private property.

"I can get a paper for Rockland," she said, when I'd finished. "Death certificate, estate letters. I'll have it by tomorrow if I lean on a judge, which I'm going to do anyway." She handed the envelope back. "I'm not going to say you should have shown me this Saturday."

"Thank you."

"I'm going to say you should have shown me this Saturday." She stood. "Now. Mrs. Tarbell."

The green house had every light on.

She sat at the yellow table in her gray cardigan with a state trooper beside her and a mug of tea going cold under her hands. She didn't look up when we came in. The calendar from the Co-op still hung on its nail. Through the window over the sink the dory sat on its blocks with the sun coming up behind it, fern-filled and absurd.

"Mrs. Tarbell," Nell said gently. "Tell it again for Mr. Brandt. As you told me."

She raised her eyes. They went past me and came back, like someone checking a stair in the dark. "The phone rang at twenty to twelve," she said. "The kitchen phone. Ned was still up. He hadn't been to bed. He was sitting where you were yesterday, with the radio on low."

"Who called?"

"He said, 'Hello.' Then he said, 'Oh. Oh, it's you.' And he listened for a while." Her mouth worked. "And he said, 'No, I can't sleep either.' And then, 'All right. I'll come down. Yes. The landing. I know where.' And he hung up and put on his coat."

"Did he say a name?"

"He said it was Mr. Brandt." She said it plainly. She looked at me, and in her face there was grief and a terrible reluctance to be unfair. "He said, 'It's Mr. Brandt. He's nervous too. He wants to go over it

once, away from the house, so I don't frighten you.' And I said, Ned, it's midnight. And he said, 'He's been very good to us.' He wanted to be good back."

The kitchen was very quiet.

"It wasn't me," I said.

"I know you think so."

"Mrs. Tarbell, I was in a bed at the Anchor Inn."

"I'm not saying it was." Her hands tightened on the mug. "I'm saying he said your name. He said it twice. He wouldn't have gone for anybody else."

"No," I said. "He wouldn't."

Nell touched my shoulder. It was a very small movement, and it did not feel like comfort. It felt like a hand being placed on something to hold it still.

"Landline," she said to me, outside, in the thin cold. "Incoming number blocked. I've asked the phone company, and they'll tell me it was a prepaid in a drawer somewhere, and the drawer will be empty." She stood with her back to the house. "Do you know what I've got, Brandt? I've got a man who was terrified of water, found in a boat, after a call from a man he'd said he trusted. I've got a witness who says that man was you. I've got a tag in a dead man's fist with your name stamped on it, and a kit that went missing in the nick of time. I've got your wife's letter."

“Which says someone used me.”

“Which says that to the one person who’d want it saying.” She said it without cruelty. “If I were reading this file, I’d have me do exactly what I’m doing. I’d have me say come in.”

“Am I under arrest?”

“I’d like it if you came in for a statement.” She didn’t smile. “I’d like it very much.”

They kept me at the county building on Mill Street until half past one.

Nothing happened that I could point to. Just a room with a bolted table, a pitcher of water, and a clock above the door that ran two minutes slow. Nell had a notepad. Beside her sat a second detective, Ouellette, with the face of a man who had never been talked out of anything. I told it in order. The kitchen, the wave, the coat that went on and off. Tarbell’s hand on the table and his wife in the doorway.

I told them where I’d been. The Anchor Inn, nine o’clock, chain on the door. The night clerk was a girl of twenty with a ring in her nose and a thesis on Hardy, who said she’d seen me come in at nine-thirty and go up, and had not seen me after that, because she’d been, in her words, “reading, mostly, with my

headphones in.” The back stairs opened onto the alley. The chain went on from the inside. I could see both detectives work out how it could have been dropped back behind a man by his own hand. I could have done it myself.

Dr. Ansel Pryor, the county medical examiner, put his head in around eleven. He was a long, pale man in his late fifties with a damp forehead and a pen he couldn’t stop clicking, and he looked at me once and then did not look at me again. He said a few words to Ouellette at the door. I caught *drowning* and *consistent*. I caught *old men do odd things in the night*. I caught Nell, out in the corridor, say quite clearly, “He was afraid of the water, Doctor,” and Pryor answering in the voice of someone trying to put a coat on a chair: “People surprise us.”

He left. The clicking went with him down the hall.

“Preliminary time of death is between midnight and two,” Nell told me afterward. She had the grace to look at the table. “Your clerk can’t cover it. Nothing physical ties you to the skiff. The card—”

“What card?”

She slid a photograph across the table.

It was a business card, in an evidence bag, creased across one corner. Theo Brandt, Forensic Loss Adjuster. The little blue anchor. On the back, in

blue-black ink, in a crowded hand I had been looking at on the page of my own life for forty years: *12:00 — landing.*

"They found it in his coat," she said. "Inside pocket. Dry."

I looked at the capitals. The *T*, the *L*.

It was my handwriting. Even I couldn't have told it from my own.

"I didn't write that."

"I know you say so."

"It's the same hand as page seven. It's the same person. Someone's been practicing me for six years."

"Maybe." Nell held my eyes. "Or maybe that's what a man says who's been practicing himself." She picked up the photograph, and put it away. "I'm not charging you today. I can't. You've got a story, and some of it has legs. I'd rather you were somewhere I can find you." She paused. "But I'm not stupid. I know what you are to the next person who reads this. You're going to want to go somewhere."

"Portland."

"Quill."

"He's got more. She'd have left more than a key."

"I'd have said the same." She stood and put her hands flat on the table. "You're not under arrest, and I can't stop you leaving. I can tell you the causeway

closes at 11:20 tonight, and if you're on the wrong side of it I will assume you drove into the sea. And I can tell you, Brandt, that Wednesday is the fourteenth."

"I know what Wednesday is."

"Then be careful with it." She straightened. Her voice, when it came, was nearly gentle, and she didn't look at me. "She'd want you back in one piece."

I thought about that sentence all the way out of the building, and halfway to Portland. I couldn't think what business the detective had to know what Mara would want.

Ferris Quill's office stood at the top of a flight of stairs on Exchange Street, above a shop that sold nautical antiques. The brass nameplate had been polished so many times the letters had gone soft. A radiator knocked somewhere inside. When I rang the bell, I heard a chair scrape and a long wait, and the sound of someone looking through a peephole.

The door opened on its chain.

"Mr. Brandt." He was a small, upright, white-haired man in a gray three-piece suit, seventy at least, with the dry voice of a man who had spent his

life saying *I'm afraid that's not possible*. He looked past me down the stairs, then at the street through the window on the landing, and slipped the chain. "Come in. Quickly, please. I haven't had a good week."

The office was a room of dark wood and green leather and stacked boxes. A grandfather clock. A framed photograph of a much younger Quill shaking hands with a governor. He took me to the chair opposite his desk and sat down himself without offering tea, which for a lawyer of his generation was the equivalent of a shout.

"I read about Mr. Tarbell on the radio at ten," he said. "I did not know the man. But I knew, when I heard it, that you would come."

"Why?"

"Because she told me you would." He folded his hands. "Mara came to see me in October. I won't give you the date. I've given it to myself too many times. She sat where you are sitting and she gave me two envelopes. One I sent you Thursday. The other I was to keep until you came here in person, on your own, after a second death."

"A second death."

“Her words. She said, ‘He will come when it’s no longer a coincidence.’ She said Alan Farrow would be the first, if she was right about him, and a stranger the second, and that you would walk in here with a face like a dropped plate.” He paused. “I confess I thought she was being dramatic. I thought so for five years.”

“What’s in the second envelope?”

“I haven’t opened it.” He unlocked a drawer and took out a plain manila envelope, soft with handling, a strip of tape across the flap with *FQ* initialed across the join. “She asked me not to. She asked me to ask you to read it here, while I’m in the room. She said she didn’t want it in the car.”

I took it. It weighed nothing. I peeled the tape.

There was one sheet inside, a color print on photo paper: a sheet of lined ledger, shot at an angle under poor light, a corner curling in someone’s hand. There was a thumbnail of shadow at the top edge. At the far margin, slightly out of focus, I could make out the curve of what might have been a lamp, a glass shade the color of a bottle.

The ledger itself was a column of small, tidy entries in pencil.

Initials. Dates. A dollar sum. A column headed *Adj.*

P.D. A date eight years and seven months back. \$640,000. Adj.: *T.B.*

R.A. A date seven years back. \$1,100,000. Adj.: *T.B.*

L.F. A date in March, six years back. \$2,000,000. Adj.: *T.B.*

Three lines. Beneath them, a short horizontal rule, as though someone had meant to add another and been interrupted. And to the right of every sum, in the margin, the same small figure: 30.

I read it again. And a third time, because the first two had gone through me and out the other side without leaving anything.

Peter Doyle, the cannery watchman. Ruth Anselm, who fell from a cliff path at Pemaquid and left a husband with a seven-figure claim. Lydia Farrow.

I knew every one of them. I'd opened a file on each. I had closed all three.

Doyle: I'd taken the supplemental review that spring because Hollis was stretched thin and had said the file wanted a fresh eye. Anselm: I'd signed the closing, fifteen minutes before a flight to Denver, a clean one, no questions. And Lydia, of course, was the one with my name on every page.

"Mr. Brandt?" said Quill.

"Three people died," I said. I heard my own voice come from a long way off. "Over three years. Each one an accident. And every claim was paid out because I said it should be."

"Yes," said Quill quietly. "I rather gathered."

"Who photographed this?"

"I don't know. She didn't say. She said only that you would know the chair." He watched me. "I should add that my instructions were to give you nothing else. But I was a friend of your wife's father for thirty years, and I have been sitting in this room five years waiting for someone to ask me what I thought. I think a man who knew the shape of this would have wanted your name to be the only name on it."

"Someone has been building me," I said.

"Someone has been *using* you." He leaned forward. "Which is a different thing, and the difference may save your life." He took off his glasses. His eyes were small and old and very bright. "Mr. Brandt, there's a policeman in Port Carrow who I think would be glad to see that photograph."

"She'll see it. She'll see a ledger where every line says my initials." I stared at the three small letters. *T.B. T.B. T.B.* "If I were her, I'd take that as a signature."

"If you were her, you'd take that as a motive. And you'd be right." He put his glasses back on. "That is the other thing Mara said. She said that when the ledger turned up, it would look as though it were pointing at you. And that you were to keep looking."

"At what?"

"At what it wasn't saying." He glanced at the print. "I'm an old lawyer. I read what's missing from a page. Who got the thirty?"

"What?"

"The margin," said Quill. "Thirty beside every sum. Thirty percent of the claim, I should think. And you, apparently, were the adjuster. But an adjuster takes nothing." His mouth was thin. "Thirty percent went to someone. Not the beneficiary. Not you, I trust. And somebody rules the pencil lines so cleanly they have the habit of a ledger. Someone who has done it for years."

I put the photograph on the desk between us. The grandfather clock ticked and went on ticking. In the street below a bus changed gears, and the whole building shook very slightly, like a ship.

On my phone, in my pocket, a message arrived with its small flat chime. I didn't take it out. I knew without reading who it was from. It was a Port Carrow number.

I sat in Quill's green leather chair with three sets of my own initials in front of me, and thought: *I know Doyle's file. I know Anselm's.* And then, because I'd been trained by the best: *Who put them on my desk?*

Chapter 7: Unit 114

The message was from Hollis.

I listened to it on the stairs outside Quill's office, with the old lawyer's door shut behind me and the smell of lemon polish still in my coat. Hollis never texted if he could talk. His voice came out of the phone slow and rough and kind, with a kettle ticking in the background.

"Theo. It's me. I've just heard about poor Ned Tarbell. Eddie Marsh rang me, he thought I'd want to know. I don't know what to say. I'm sorry you had to be the one who talked to him, if you did, I don't know that you did." A breath. "Don't sit in that room at the Anchor with the television. Come and eat. I've got a haddock chowder that'll stand a spoon up. Ring me when you can. Any hour."

I stood there with the phone against my ear after it ended. I'd spent five years ringing that number in every kind of weather. Quill's wall behind me was cold through my coat, and my first instinct, the one

that was older than the envelope and older than the ledger and older than the sober man I'd made out of the wreck, was to call it back and tell him everything.

Not even the people who love you. Especially them.

I typed: *Portland today. Back tomorrow, will call.* I read it twice. It was true, and it told him nothing. I sent it and put the phone in my pocket and felt, for no reason I could have defended, like a man who has just stepped over a wire.

Nell took the photograph the way she'd taken the letter. She looked at it for a long time with no expression at all, and then she looked at me.

We were in the lot behind Quill's building, and she'd driven down from Port Carrow in ninety minutes on a road I'd have taken in two hours. She stood by her unmarked Ford with her hands in her jacket pockets and the print held flat against the roof, shielded from the drizzle by her body. The ledger lay under her thumb. *T.B. T.B. T.B.*

"I should arrest you for this," she said.

"I know."

“Three dead people. Three claims. Your initials down the whole column, in somebody’s neat little hand.” She tapped the margin. “And thirty. Thirty percent of a claim is a motive any prosecutor could read aloud to a jury with one eyebrow up.”

“The adjuster doesn’t get a percentage. The adjuster gets a salary and a pension plan and a Christmas ham.”

“The adjuster gets whatever the adjuster decides to get. You know that better than I do.” She lifted her eyes. “You also came here and handed it to me. A man building his own alibi wouldn’t hand me this.”

“A man building a *second* alibi might.”

That surprised a laugh out of her, small and furious. She put the print into a clear evidence sleeve from her pocket, wrote on it with a marker, and tucked it inside her jacket. “I’m not charging you with anything today. I’m keeping this. I’m keeping the letter copy. I’ll have the lab look at the paper, and the pencil, and that lamp.” She tilted her head. “That’s a green glass shade. Banker’s lamp or one of the old library ones. Mean anything?”

I looked at the blur at the top of the photograph. A curve of bottle-colored glass, out of focus, the kind of detail a man’s mind wants to fill with a meaning.

It meant something. I could feel the shape of the meaning, the way you can feel a word on the tip of your tongue, and then it was gone, like a fish turning in black water.

"Half the offices in New England have one," I said.

"Half." She didn't believe me, and she let it go. "Quill has paperwork for the unit?"

"A certified death certificate. He was the one who filed her will. He says he can have letters on the estate drawn up by tonight, and an affidavit that I'm her husband and sole heir."

"Good. Then you'll want to be in Rockland at nine tomorrow." She pulled her car door open and stopped. "Tomorrow's the fourteenth."

"I know what day it is."

"I know you do." For a moment she looked at me the way she'd looked at me across the boathouse in the first dusk, a beat too long, like someone reading an old address off an envelope. "I'll bring the manager a letter from the county, so he doesn't give you the runaround, and I'll stand behind you while you open it. I can't search it without a warrant. I can watch a husband go through his wife's things. That's as far as I can bend."

"Why would you bend at all?"

She looked at me.

“Because you didn’t run,” said Nell Castellano, and got into the car.

I didn’t sleep. I’d stopped expecting to, the night before the fourteenth. Every year it had been the same: a cheap room somewhere, the radio low, a bottle I didn’t buy sitting in my head like a neighbor who never goes home. I’d watched dawn come up over parking lots in four states. This year I sat on the bed at a motel off Route 1 in Rockland, because I wasn’t ready to lose the half-hour of the drive, and I read Mara’s letter again by the light of the television with the sound off.

Don’t tell anyone. Not even the people who love you. Especially them.

I’d read it forty times, and I understood now what I had been refusing to understand. A warning like that has a shape. You don’t write *especially them* about a stranger. You write it because there is someone, a particular someone, close enough to ask.

I made a list on the motel pad. *Reyes. Hollis. Nell. Quill. Dolores.* I looked at it for a long time and then I tore the sheet off and ate my own handwriting, a habit from the bad years. It tasted of paper and nothing else.

The rain stopped at four. At five the first trucks started down Route 1.

Midcoast Secure Storage sat behind a chain-link fence on the Thomaston road, three long buildings with orange doors and a yard of crushed shell. It was a gray morning, a sea-smoke kind of morning, and the sky hung low enough to touch the roof. The same clerk was at the counter, a boy in a fleece with a nametag that said *DAVE*, and a heavier man came out of the back when he saw me, with the face of someone who has spent his life dealing with other people's regrets by the square foot.

"Mr. Brandt." He glanced past me. "And this is the detective."

"Detective Sergeant Castellano. Maine State Police." Nell laid her letter on the counter, the county seal at the bottom, and then Quill's papers on top of it, one after another: the certificate with its raised stamp, the letters, the affidavit with a notary's blue ink. The manager read each one with his lips moving. He was not a man who liked to be rushed and he was not a man who liked to be seen to be rushed.

“Unit’s in good standing through the thirty-first,” he said finally. “Paid cash, in advance, same as every year. Year after year, I mean. Five years.” He raised his eyebrows. “Some of these tenants, I wouldn’t have known the owner was dead if you’d not told me.”

“Five years of cash,” Nell said. “Who brought it?”

“It came in an envelope, by mail. Our own return envelope. No letter.” He shrugged. “Postmarked Portland.”

I felt Nell not look at me.

“Quill,” I said.

“I’d guess a standing order.” She turned to the manager. “Mr. Brandt will open the unit. I’ll stand in the doorway. You’ll stay out here, and you won’t touch the door until we’re done.”

He agreed to all of it. He gave us the gate code on a slip, and I took it. It was six digits, a birthday I didn’t recognize and then did: Mara’s mother’s, a date in April.

We drove in. B row. Orange door. A padlock with a brass tag on the shackle that matched, in a way my eyes couldn’t believe, the key in my hand.

I’d carried that key for four days. I’d put it beside my car keys every night. I’d thought about it in the shower. Now I stood in the cold shell-gravel yard with

the sea-smoke blowing between the buildings and I put it in the lock, and the lock was oiled, and turned without a sound.

That was the first strange thing. A lock five years old doesn't turn like that.

"Theo," said Nell behind me. It was the first time she'd used my first name.

"I know."

"Don't go in yet. Look at the floor."

I lifted the door. It rolled up on a chain with a long metallic complaint, and the dim light of the yard fell across a ten-by-ten concrete room.

She had taken the unit with a good eye for order. Mara had always been the kind of person who made a map before she went anywhere.

Banker's boxes in three tidy stacks, each labeled in blue felt-tip on a strip of masking tape. A folding card table. One chair. A desk lamp with a cord that didn't reach any outlet. A square of green carpet on the concrete. A small oil heater, unplugged. And on the far wall, pinned with thumbtacks, a map of the Maine coast with Port Carrow circled in red.

I stood in the doorway and could not make myself cross the threshold. It smelled of cardboard and cold. It smelled faintly of her: of the lemon-ginger tea she'd drunk by the quart, of the cedar-chip sachets she put in drawers. The smell was an old photograph.

"Take your time," Nell said, quietly. "I'll be here."

Two things were wrong, and I saw both of them at once, because I had been taught to see what's wrong in a room before I let myself see anything else.

The first was the floor. There were prints in the dust. Not the deep dust of five years, though there was some of that, a gray bloom along the base of the walls. The prints were around the table and in front of the stacks, and they were small and smeared by a soft sole, and they were not old.

The second was the shelf of boxes at the left. There were four stacks of boxes along the back wall, with a stencil of a dusty outline in the fourth: a rectangle, a box's width, where the dust ended on the concrete and clean gray began. A box had stood there, and been taken, and not long ago.

I didn't say anything. Nell stepped in behind me and crouched without touching, her flashlight on the clean rectangle. Then she looked at the prints, and then at me.

"Someone's been in here."

"Someone with the code," I said, "or a key."

"The manager said no one's been in through the office, as far as he knows." She stood. "I'm going to ask him for the gate log."

"Nell."

"I know," she said. "You want to look first. Go on. Don't touch anything you don't have to. Photograph everything where it lies."

I went in.

Mara's handwriting was on every label, and it was the worst thing I have ever read.

I'd carried her letter for four days and it had been a voice in a quiet room, a single page I could fold and put away. This was a library of her. *DOYLE, P. — CLAIM / FIELD. ANSELM, R. FARROW, L. — COMPLETE.* Beneath them, shorter labels: *TIPS — SENT. FONTS. ME REPORTS. CLOSING LANGUAGE — 4 OF 4. PRYOR. TARBELL (DRAFT).*

I lifted the lid on *FARROW, L.* The copy was a photocopy of the claim file with every page numbered in the corner in her small, square hand, and in the margins, little pencil notes, the way she'd annotated paperbacks and recipes and the backs of my business cards. *Same typeface as Doyle p.4. Check. Same ME.*

Same closing line. "No evidence of third-party involvement." Four files, four times. She had drawn a little wave beside it, the kind she drew in the margins of everything she cared about.

And on page seven, which I had read on a scan in a hotel parking lot with my heart going like a trapped bird, she had written one line, in red.

This is not his hand. His capitals lean. Whoever forged this has copied the signature but not the habit.

I read it, and then I understood the thing I hadn't been able to say to Nell on the phone, or to Quill, or even to myself.

She had known. In October, five years ago, my wife had sat at a card table in a rented concrete room and compared my handwriting to a forgery of it, line by line, with a magnifying glass, and she had concluded that I was innocent. And then she had gone home and tried to tell me, and lost her nerve halfway.

I put the lid back on very carefully, as if it could break.

"Theo." Nell, from the door. She had a printout from the manager's office in her hand, a single sheet. Her voice was flat in a way I had learned to listen to. "Gate log."

“Tell me.”

“Entry on the ninth of October. Eleven fifty-two p.m. Mara’s code. Out at twelve-oh-six.” She held my eyes. “Fourteen minutes. Last Friday night. The night after Alan Farrow died.”

Fourteen minutes, to take one box.

I looked at the clean rectangle on the concrete. I looked at the labels, and I read them again, all of them, in order, with the care you give a will. And at the end of the third stack, where the sequence ought to have ended, I saw what was missing, because Mara was a woman who labeled everything in order, and there were boxes for *FONTS* and *ME* and *TARBELL (DRAFT)*, and no box for the final thing.

There was only the dust outline. And there, in her handwriting, on a strip of masking tape that had come off the missing box and curled to the floor, I read the label.

OCTOBER.

It took me an hour to go through the rest. Nell didn’t leave the doorway, and I was grateful. She didn’t speak. She wrote nothing down. She held the flashlight steady and said *there* when something caught the light.

There was a spiral notebook in the *TIPS* box. A year's worth of anonymous letters to the state attorney general, to Atlantic's ethics line, to a reporter in Bangor, all unanswered, all copied in her hand with the date and the postage. *Sent 9/22. Sent 10/1. No reply.* The last was dated September 30.

And there was a single index card, thumbtacked to the inside of the lid of a box labeled *H.*, which I hadn't seen at first because the card had faded to the color of tea.

I read it under the flashlight with a feeling I can only describe as vertigo.

Oct 5. Told T. He'll know what to do.

H. — authorizes payment on all four. Has H. ever read a file? Ask who put them on T.'s desk.

I read it twice. A third time. I turned the card over and there was nothing on the back.

"Told T.," said Nell, behind me. She had read it over my shoulder. Her voice was very careful. "That's you."

"Her letter says she lost her nerve. Sunday. Halfway."

"The card says Monday. The fifth." She was quiet. "She tried Sunday and failed, and then she did it Monday. She *told* you, Theo. Whatever it was. She

told you the next day, and she wrote it down, and she believed you knew what to do about it.”

“I don’t remember.”

“I know.”

“I don’t remember any of it.” My voice cracked on it, in the cold, in the smell of cedar and cardboard. “Nell, it was the fifth. It was a Monday. I must have gone to work. I must have eaten dinner. I must have —” I stopped. “I was sober that week. I was sober till the sixth or the seventh. I would remember.”

“Would you?” she said, very gently, which was worse than if she’d shouted.

H. I looked at the single letter. The H might be Hollis. It might be Hal Rouse, the CFO, whose signature was on every claim payment at Atlantic and whose name nobody ever said aloud without the word *Hal* first, with a kind of nervous fondness. It might be Harbormaster, which was what Tarbell had been called to his face. It might be a hundred things. A single letter, in a woman’s careful hand.

Ask who put them on T.’s desk.

I held the card against my chest. She had told me, and written it down, and gone on believing I would know what to do. And I had done something, or nothing, and five years later I couldn’t say which.

“Theo,” said Nell. “What did you do on the fifth of October?”

And standing in my dead wife’s rented room, with her handwriting on every wall, I opened my mouth to answer, and found nothing there at all: not a street, not a meal, not a face. Only a white, smooth, blank place, like the surface of the sea after something has gone down into it.

Chapter 8: The Fourteenth

“Think,” Nell said. “Not hard. Hard is how you lose it. Just stand there and let it come.”

I stood in the doorway of Unit 114 with the card in my hand and the cold coming up through my shoes, and let it come.

What came was a kettle.

Not a scene. Not a face. The thin rising note of a kettle about to boil in a room I couldn’t see, and the smell of wet wool. It lasted a second. When I reached for it, the way you reach for the end of a word, it was gone. The white place returned, and my heart beat hard against it.

“Nothing,” I said. “A kettle.”

“A kettle.” Nell almost smiled and thought better of it. “That’s something. People in the middle of a shock remember the stupidest things. Write it down. Don’t build on it.”

It was nearly noon. A trooper had come from Rockland with a van and a clipboard, and for the next hour Mara's library went out into the daylight one box at a time, each one photographed, numbered, signed for. I watched them go like a man watching his house taken apart by movers who were being kind. *H.* went out last, in Nell's own arms. She wouldn't let the trooper take it.

"Copies are yours," she said at her car. "Quill's paperwork gives you the right. Everything else is evidence, and you are not going to argue with me about it."

"I'm not going to argue."

"Good. Today's the fourteenth."

I looked at her.

"I know what day it is," she said. "So do you. Where are you going to be tonight?"

"Port Carrow."

"The breakwater."

"I go every year."

"Then go." She opened her door. "But first, you and I are going to see Ansel Pryor, because I'd like to watch his face when I say your wife's name."

The county medical examiner kept his office in the basement of the county building on Mill Street, down a corridor that smelled of floor wax and formaldehyde pretending to be floor wax. Pryor was at his desk with the lamp on, in a cardigan the color of oatmeal. He clicked a ballpoint pen. Click, click. He did it the whole time we were in the room, and I began to think it was the only part of him that was still working.

“Detective. Mr. Brandt.” He didn’t stand. “I’ve told you everything I have on Mr. Tarbell. Drowning. Water in the lungs, froth, no injuries inconsistent with a fall from a small boat. Old men do odd things at midnight.”

“He was afraid of water,” Nell said. “His wife says he hadn’t been on the harbor in thirty years.”

“Fear isn’t a finding.”

“Neither is *consistent with*.” She sat without being asked. “I want a tox panel. Full. Sedatives, hypnotics, whatever you’ve got reagents for. And I want it run at the state lab, not here.”

Click. “I can request—”

“I’m not asking you to request.”

“The county has a process, Detective.”

"I've seen the process." She let that lie there. Then, in exactly the same tone, as if she were reading from a menu: "I'd also like to look at the Brandt file. Mara Brandt. Five years ago today, the breakwater. You signed it."

The pen stopped.

It was a very small thing. A man's thumb coming off a button. But the room changed around it, the way a room does when the refrigerator cuts out and you realize you'd been hearing it. Pryor looked at Nell. He did not look at me, and that was the part I noticed. In twenty years I have watched a great many people avoid the eyes of a widower, and there's a way of doing it that is only embarrassment. This was something else. It was a man trying not to see a thing he had already seen.

"That was a clear case," he said. "Accidental drowning. I don't see any reason—"

"Was she tested for sedatives?"

"There was no indication."

"There's a *reason* to test," Nell said, "every time. I'm asking if you did."

"I won't discuss a closed case with the husband in the room." His voice cracked on *husband*. "I'll answer to the state board, if the board asks me. Not

to this.” He clicked the pen twice, hard, like a man trying to restart something. “Please go.”

On the wall behind him, between a diploma and a framed tide chart, was a plaque. *Port Carrow Volunteer Rescue, with thanks.* A row of signatures. Mine was not among them, but I knew two. The chief of police, and in a looping, friendly hand I could have picked out of a thousand, *Hollis Dunn*. In a town of eleven hundred, a man like Hollis signed everything. I thought, that’s the way it is in a small place, and I looked away from it as I’d look away from any other fact I couldn’t use.

In the corridor Nell kept her face straight until the stairs.

“He knew,” she said. “Not what happened. That something had been *done* to that file. Did you see him? Like a man who’s been expecting a knock for five years and just heard it.”

“He didn’t deny it.”

“He didn’t say anything, which is what scared people do.” She stopped on the landing. “I can’t force him, Theo. A judge needs more than a flinch. But he’s going to lie awake tonight, and a man who lies awake starts to think about who he’d rather talk to. I’m going to make sure it’s me.”

The Port Carrow breakwater is a quarter mile of granite blocks thrown out into the harbor mouth in 1911 by men who didn't expect to be thanked. It ends in a little iron light on a pedestal. At the far end, on the seaward side, there is a flat slab with a drop of about six feet to the water, and weed on the lower blocks, and in October after rain the weed is the color of a bruise.

Five years ago tonight, a little before eight, my wife stood on that slab and went in.

I'd come every year. At first because I couldn't not; later because it was a thing you did, like a day-one coin, like Hollis's thermos. I didn't pray. I stood. I put my hands in my pockets, and I looked at the water, and I said what I had to say, which was always the same four words and never enough.

The light was going. There was a wind from the northeast with a wet edge. As I came down the last stretch of granite I saw there was already someone at the end of it, sitting on the slab with his legs hanging over, a gray waxed coat spread on the stone beside him and a steel thermos between his knees.

Hollis looked over his shoulder and lifted a paper cup.

"I thought you might not make it," he said. "The causeway's behaving. I took a chance."

"You didn't have to."

"I know." He moved the coat to make room. "Sit, old son. It's the only thing I've ever been any good at on this day: sitting."

He'd done it every year. The first year, when I couldn't have found the breakwater with a map, he had found *me*, three days sober and shaking in a parked car at the head of the causeway, and he'd walked me out here with a hand under my elbow. After that he'd simply been here, with the thermos and the cup, no questions. I had never once thanked him properly. You can't. It would be like thanking the tide.

I sat. The tea was black and strong, no sugar, the way he made it. I held the cup in both hands.

"You've got something," Hollis said after a while.

I didn't answer.

"I'm not asking. I know a man holding a hot thing." He watched the light. "You went to Portland yesterday, you said. You look like a man who's been to the bottom of something."

"Paperwork," I said. "Estate stuff. For Mara." That much was true, anyway. I'd meant it to sound like grief, and it did.

"Mmm." The gull noises came and went. "I'd tell you to come to dinner, but I think what you'd like is to be left alone to feel it. I'm right?"

"You usually are."

He laughed quietly. The sound wasn't quite a laugh; it was lower. "Not usually. I've been wrong about a number of things in my life. I've just been careful to be wrong in private." He tipped his cup toward the water. "She'd have been forty-three in March."

"Forty-two," I said.

"Forty-two." He nodded slowly. "So she would."

I looked at him then, in the failing light: the lines either side of the mouth, the white hair stirring in the wind, the huge capable hands around the little cup. I thought: *tell him*. I had told him everything for five years. I had told him about the night I drove to Bangor for no reason and the year I couldn't read the newspaper. The envelope was in my jacket, and I could feel its corner against my ribs.

Not anyone, she had written. *Not even the people who love you. Especially them.*

It was the *especially* that stopped me. I didn't understand it, and that was what held. You don't walk across a stretch of ice because the man beside you

says it will hold. You walk across because you know why it should.

"I will," I said. "Soon. There's something I can't say yet."

Hollis didn't push. He rarely did. He put his hand on the back of my neck, briefly, the way a father does, and took it away. "Soon," he agreed. "I'll be here." He screwed the cap on the thermos, got up with a small grunt, and shook out the coat. "Eat something. You look like a lamp that's been left on."

I watched his gray back go along the granite until it merged with the dusk.

I stood on the slab, and I said the four words, and it was no better than any other year. Then I turned around, because someone was standing on the stones behind me, thirty feet off, hat in his hands.

"I'm sorry," said Barrett Voss. "That was bad manners. I waited till he left."

"You were watching me."

"I was watching *him*, a little. Natural curiosity. He's the type people stop talking around." Voss put on the hat. "That's a joke. I'm not good at them.

Mr. Brandt, can I have ten minutes? There's something you ought to see, and I'd rather not hand it over on a rock in the dark."

We went to the diner on Front Street, to the same booth as before. Voss ordered a coffee and didn't drink it. He had a manila folder, and he laid it flat and kept one hand on it as if it might lift off.

"Cora Farrow hired me in June," he said. "You know that. She wanted to know how her mother died. I've been working the problem for four months, and I'll tell you honestly, you were my first guess. You. The man who closed the file. Then the harbormaster started dodging me and the picture went sideways."

"Voss."

"I'm getting there. Here's the thing about being hired by someone: you stop looking at the person who hired you. It's a rule. It's a stupid rule." He opened the folder. "Alan Farrow died the night of the eighth. Cora told Detective Castellano she was in Boston from the seventh through the ninth. She told *me* the same. She's a grad student at BU. Library cards. A seminar."

He turned a photograph around.

It was a still from a hardware-store security camera on the Port Carrow causeway road. Time stamp: 10/08, 10:38 PM. A small dark Subaru,

headlights on, rain slanting in them. The plate was legible. I had seen it before. It had been parked outside the Anchor Inn on Saturday.

"I got the footage Monday," Voss said. "I sat on it two days. I told myself I was verifying. Mostly I didn't want to know."

"You think she killed him."

"I think she's lying to me. And I think if I can find this, so can Castellano, and by Friday that girl's in an interview room with a public defender and nobody's asking who else was on that causeway." He rubbed his eyes. "She hired me, Mr. Brandt. I don't have to like it. But I'd rather she tell you first."

"Why me?"

"Because," said Voss, "you're the one she'll shout at. And she needs to shout at someone."

Cora Farrow was renting the downstairs of a gray-shingled house on Sparrow Lane, three doors from the harbor. The light was on. When she opened the door she had a mug in one hand and a textbook under her arm, and for a heartbeat she looked fourteen.

Then she saw Voss's face, and the photograph in his hand, and the mug went down on the porch rail with a click.

"You *followed* me?"

"I didn't," Voss said. "A camera did."

"I paid you to find out what happened to my *mother*."

"Yes."

"Not to—" She stopped. She turned on me, the way he'd said she would, and her face was white. "You came for this. That's why you're here. To watch me—"

"I came because it's the fourteenth," I said. "And I'm tired, and I don't think you killed him."

It was an odd thing to say on a porch, and it went into her like a stone into still water. She looked at me for a long time. The wind pulled at her hair. Then she turned and went in and left the door open, which was all the invitation there was.

Inside there was a card table with a laptop and four coffee cups and a corkboard of index cards, color-coded, a rope of red yarn running from one pin to another. It was Mara's unit again, on a smaller scale. I felt it in my stomach.

"I was there," Cora said.

She said it to the corkboard. She sat on the arm of a sofa with her arms folded across herself.

"He called me on the seventh. He was drunk, I could hear it, but he was *clear*. He said, *Come up. I'll tell you everything. Not on the phone.* He said he'd been a coward for six years and he was tired of it. I said I'd come Thursday. Then he rang again Thursday afternoon and said *tonight, if you can, I don't think I should wait.*" Her voice shook. "So I drove up. I reached the causeway just before ten-forty. It was already ankle-deep; I almost didn't make it. I parked on the lane. I went down the steps to the boathouse because there was a light on in the loft window."

"What time?"

"Quarter of eleven. A little before." She rubbed her face. "I knocked. I knocked and knocked. I called his name. Nothing. The door was solid, and it was *locked*, I could hear the water inside, like it was—" She stopped and breathed. "I thought he'd passed out. He did that. I was so angry I could have screamed, so I left. I didn't call anyone. I drove back across before the road closed, and I went home to Boston, and I got a call from the police the next afternoon, and I *lied*, because the only thing I could think was that I had stood at the door while he was inside."

Nobody said anything.

"Did you see anyone?" I asked.

"No."

"Anything. A car. A light."

"There was a boat." She frowned. "In the cove, past the boathouse, sort of tucked in under the rocks. I only noticed because there was no light on it at all. A small boat, one mast. The kind everybody has here." She shook her head. "I didn't think. People sail."

I looked at Voss, and Voss looked at me, and neither of us said what we'd both thought. It was a hundred boats in a town of a thousand. It could have been anyone's.

"Cora." My voice was gentler than I'd expected. "You have to tell Detective Castellano. Tonight. Before she hears it from the hardware store. If you walk in yourself it's a witness. If she comes to you, it's a suspect."

"She'll arrest me."

"She might want to. She won't have a reason."

She was quiet for a long time. Then she got up and went to the corkboard and took down one of the index cards, and held it a moment, and gave it to me.

It was in a block hand, hers. *Dad, 10/7 voicemail. Transcribe.*

“He left me a message the day before,” she said. “I’ve listened to it forty times. I didn’t tell you earlier because I didn’t think it mattered, and then I thought it would make me look guilty, and now I think it’s the only thing I’ve got.” She picked up her phone, thumbed it, and held it out at arm’s length, as though it were a thing that might bite. “Don’t say anything. Just listen.”

There was a hiss, and wind, and a glass touched down on wood. Then a man’s voice, thick, tired, a fine voice gone to ruin, and so near the phone I could hear him swallow.

“Cora. It’s me. I’m going to say it to you straight, because I’ve never said it to anyone. Your mother didn’t fall. I knew, I knew the day. I let them... I let it be what it was.” A long breath. “And the Brandt woman. She came to see me. Did you know that? Five years ago, a week before. Sat in my kitchen and told me what I was. She was right about all of it, every word. I’ve thought about her every day. I’ll tell you what I—”

The line cut off. Not a hang-up. A bump, a clatter, as if the phone had been put down on something hard, and the sound of a door and a muffled, ordinary

voice in the background that said, quite clearly, in the tone you'd use to someone who had been waiting a long time for a cup of tea:

"There you are."

Then nothing.

Cora lowered the phone. Her eyes were wide.

"I've always thought it was the housekeeper," she said. "Mrs. Aldous. But she says she was at her sister's in Camden. She says she's never heard that voice."

I couldn't speak. In that rented room, with its corkboard and rope of red yarn, I listened to the silence the recording had left behind. *Mara went to see Alan Farrow*. She had never told me. She had sat in his kitchen a week before she died and said it to his face.

And I had heard that voice before.

I couldn't say where. It was so ordinary, so kind—the sort of voice I'd heard a thousand times without listening.

Chapter 9: A Spoon Stood Up

I played the recording four times on the walk back to the Anchor Inn, standing under the one working streetlight on Front Street with the phone cupped to my ear like a man listening for a heartbeat. Cora had sent it to me from her porch, her thumb jabbing the screen, her face set. *Don't lose it. Don't let anybody delete it.*

There you are.

Three syllables. A man's voice, mild and a little amused, with a door-click behind it. It was not a stranger's voice. That was the thing that made the skin tighten on the back of my neck. I'd had the feeling before, in rooms where I hadn't yet found the reason I was uneasy, and I'd learned to trust it the way you trust a bad tooth.

I knew that voice. I'd heard it over soup, over radios, over the phone at three in the morning. I'd heard it so often that it had stopped being a sound and become weather.

So I did what Hollis taught me. I made a list.

Reyes, whose voice was brisk and nasal and had never in its life said anything kindly. Hal Rouse, whom I had met twice, a whisper of a man. Ouellette. Pryor, wheezing and damp. Quill, thin and dry as a page. Eddie Marsh the lobsterman, who talked like a man gargling gravel. Gus from the chandlery. The night clerk's boy at the Anchor. Hollis.

None of them. I sat on the edge of the bed in room six and ran every voice I'd heard in five years past my inner ear, and none of them fit, and then, because I was tired and because it was the fourteenth and because honesty is cheapest when you're too worn out to pay for anything else, I let the last name on the list in.

I let it in the way you let a dog into a house. Reluctantly, and ashamed.

I listened to the recording once more with that name on it.

It wasn't him. It was muffled. It was a man talking to a man across a room, with a door between them and a wind in the phone. You could hang any voice on it. You could hang mine.

And all the same I got up and put my coat on, because I was a man who had been told by his wife not to tell the people who loved him, and I could not

bear to carry that sentence alone one minute more without finding out whether it had a hole in it.

Quarry Lane runs inland from the harbor along an old stone-cutters' road, and Hollis Dunn's cottage sits at the end of it where the road gives up. It's a low gray-shingled place with a slate roof and a chimney that smokes in all weather. There was a light in the kitchen and a light in the study, and the gray waxed coat was hanging on the porch rail over the steps with the rain still beading on it.

I stood at the gate for a long time with my hand on the latch.

I wasn't going to tell him. That was what I'd said to myself on the walk up. I would go in, and I would sit at his table, and I would watch him. I would listen to every word with the new ear. And if there was nothing, if there was *nothing*, I'd go back to the inn, and I would have taken one worry off the list. It was the oldest rule in the trade. You clear the people nearest you first, not because they're likely but because they'll hurt the most if you've missed them.

The door opened before I knocked.

"I saw the torch coming up the lane," Hollis said. He was in his shirtsleeves and the green cardigan with the leather elbows. "I'd have put the kettle on for a stranger. For you I've put it on twice." He looked at my face and the humor went out of his own, quietly, like a man lowering a flame. "Come in, Theo. Come in out of it."

The kitchen was warm. It always was. A cast-iron range, a scrubbed table, a bowl of lemons that nobody ever ate, shelves of mismatched mugs. The coat had been on the porch, but its twin smell was in the room anyway, damp wool, drying by the stove in the form of a pair of gray socks over the rail. On the range a kettle had begun its rising note.

I stood there with the sound going through me.

A kettle. Nell's voice: People in the middle of a shock remember the stupidest things.

It was a kettle. It was Hollis's kettle, in Hollis's kitchen, where I had sat three hundred nights in five years. Of course it was familiar. What did I think, that I'd remember some *other* kettle? I let the thought go by me like a car on a wet road.

"Sit," Hollis said. "There's chowder. I've been keeping it hot since Tuesday out of spite."

It was a very good chowder. Haddock, potato, salt pork, a little cream, a great deal of black pepper. A spoon stood up in it, as promised. I ate the whole bowl without looking at it, and he put another in front of me without a word and sat across the table with his tea and his old man's patience and watched me eat.

I listened to him the whole time. He talked about the town, about Ned Tarbell's funeral, which would be Saturday if the coroner released him, about a new family who'd bought the Pruitt place and put in a *hot tub*, God help them, in a village with a ten-inch frost line. His voice rose and fell. It was warm and gravelly and unhurried and it was the voice I'd heard in my head every day for five years.

It did not sound like the recording. It did not *not* sound like it. I sat there with the spoon in my hand, trying to hold two sounds against each other, and the harder I tried the less either of them was a sound at all.

"You're not eating," Hollis said gently.

"I'm eating."

"You're doing something with a spoon." He turned his cup on its saucer. "You've been to Rockland."

I put the spoon down.

"I didn't say a word," he went on, mildly, before I could speak. "I'm not that clever. But you texted me from Portland on Tuesday and you were at the breakwater yesterday with a face like a man who's been handed a very heavy parcel and told not to put it down. And you have not asked me for one single thing in two days, which in five years is a first." He let that rest. "I'm not going to ask. I told you. I'll be here."

Especially them.

I looked at his hands round the cup, the huge scarred knuckles, the faded blue of an old tattoo on the left wrist that he said was a sailor's mistake. I looked at the man who had found me in a parked car at the head of the causeway, three days sober and shaking, and put his coat over my knees.

I thought: *If I'm wrong about this, I'm wrong about everything.*

And then I thought, with the cold clear voice that I'd learned to hate, *that is precisely what a man would think who is about to be right.*

I put my hand inside my jacket. I took out the envelope. I laid it on the table between the bowl of lemons and the sugar I'd never once seen him use.

"Mara left me a letter," I said.

He read it with his glasses on the end of his nose and his lips pressed together. He read it twice, the way I'd done, once for the words and once for the person. His hands didn't shake. When he reached the line about the people who love you, I watched his face, because I'd come here to watch it, and what I saw was a man being struck.

He took off the glasses. He put the page down on the table and laid his palm flat on it, as if it might lift.

"Well," he said, very low. "Well, there you are, then."

I'd been braced for denial, or fury, or the kind of smooth wisdom he was famous for. I hadn't been braced for him to look *old*.

"That's why you've been carrying it. That *especially*." He pressed two fingers against his eyes. "God. She wrote that on a night she was frightened of everyone. She'd have been frightened of me too, I expect. I was the man who put you in this business. The man who'd put you in front of those files." He laughed, a dry, cracked noise. "Theo, if I'd found out that my wife's husband's mentor was possibly the center of a pattern like this, I'd have said *especially* too."

"I didn't tell you because—"

"You didn't tell me because you were told not to. I'd have thought less of you if you had." He pushed the letter back across the table, gently, with one finger. "You did right to wait. And you've done right to come now. Both."

"Hollis—"

"Tell me the rest. Start with the key."

So I told him.

God help me, I told him all of it. It came out the way things came out in those years, in the kitchen, with the tea going cold. Rockland. The unit. The prints, the missing box, the gate log with Mara's own code. The red ink on page seven. The ledger photograph, with its *T.B.*, *T.B.*, *T.B.* and its thirty percent, and Nell with the print against her chest in the lot behind Quill's. The card in the box marked *H*.

I said that last quickly. I watched him while I said it.

He didn't blink. "H."

"It could be anyone. Hal Rouse. The harbormaster. A hundred things."

"Or me," said Hollis.

The kettle shrieked. He got up, took it off the range, and poured it with his back to me. His shoulders were broad and sloped under the cardigan, and the water went into the pot without a splash.

"Put me on the list, old son," he said, not turning. "At the top. I'm an H. I was the regional director who signed off half those files, and my name is on the Doyle review whether I like it or not. If I were Castellano I would have had me in a room on Sunday." He set the pot down. "I'm not offended. I'd be disappointed in you if you hadn't thought it."

I felt my face go hot with a shame that was entirely real.

"I haven't," I lied.

"You came up the lane with a very straight back," Hollis said kindly. "You have the walk of a man going to see a priest. Or a policeman." He sat down again and poured two cups with that steady hand. "It's all right, Theo. It's the right way to do it. You clear the people nearest you first."

I taught you that. He didn't say it. He didn't need to.

I drank the tea. It was black and strong and just short of bitter. I could have wept.

We talked until after midnight. Hollis had questions, and they were the right ones, which was what I'd always loved in him and what I should have noticed that night. Did Nell have the originals? Where was

the ledger photograph kept? Had the lab got the pencil? Did Quill have copies, a file note, the *original* standing instruction in Mara's hand?

"He does," I said. "He told me yesterday. He's bringing it all to Port Carrow tomorrow at eleven. A sworn statement to Nell, at the county building. He's seventy years old, and he said it's the last thing he'll be asked to do for Mara's father." I rubbed my face. "He's the one person in this who hasn't lied to me."

"Tomorrow." Hollis nodded slowly. "At the county building."

"Eleven."

"Good. That's good." He studied the lemons. "Don't tell Reyes. Don't tell anyone at Atlantic. And Theo," he lifted his eyes, "I'd stay near the water. Not in that room at the Anchor with the thin walls. If you want somewhere nobody can find you, the cutter's on her mooring. Second Opinion. She sleeps two, and I've done worse in her than a night in a bunk. Take the key from the nail by the door."

"I'm all right at the Anchor."

"I know you are." He smiled. "I'm an old man. Let me be of use."

I took the key. I'm ashamed to say how glad I was to have it in my pocket.

It was nearly one when he walked me to the door. The rain had thinned to a mist. He stood on the step in his shirtsleeves with the light behind him, and he did what he'd done on the breakwater, he put his hand on the back of my neck.

"Tell me something about her," I said.

I hadn't meant to. It came out of the dark like a boy's request.

He was quiet. "Mara?"

"I can't remember her voice," I said. "Not properly. I've got the *words* she said. Not the sound."

"Ah." His hand stayed where it was. "Well. She laughed a half-second before the joke was over, did you know that? Always. She'd see the end coming, and she'd start. At the Christmas I did the goose, the one that went up like the Hindenburg, you remember, she was already crying with laughter when I opened the oven door. She was the only person in that kitchen who got there ahead of me." His thumb moved once on my neck, an old man's small comfort. "And she said your name as if it were a place. As if you were somewhere she'd been trying to get to. I never heard anyone else do that."

I said, "Thank you."

"Go and sleep."

I went down the lane in the thinning mist with his key in my pocket and my back to his light, and I did not look round. If I had, I think I would have seen him standing there until I turned the corner. He always did.

I didn't see the lamp in the study go on behind me, or the shadow cross it, or the second cup being lifted from the table and rinsed in the sink.

I didn't see any of it. I was thinking of a laugh half a second early, and for the first time in five years I slept the whole night through, with the chain on and the key beside my car keys, and I did not once dream.

"She came in," Nell said.

It was nine in the morning, Thursday, the fifteenth, and the diner on Front Street smelled of bacon and wet newspaper. Nell had the corner booth and a plate of eggs she hadn't touched. She looked like she'd slept in her jacket, which, I understood from the line across her cheek, she had.

"Cora?"

"With Voss. Eleven o'clock last night. Sat in my office for two hours and gave me the whole thing: the calls from her father, the hardware-store footage, the knock, the boat." She picked up her fork and put it

down again. "I wanted to put her in a cell. I'm going to take her statement to the DA this morning and recommend she isn't charged with anything. I may even be right."

"And the boat?"

"A one-mast boat with no lights in a cove. I've got eleven in this harbor that match, and four more on trailers." She rubbed her eyes with the heel of her hand. "I've got Dolores Pike's archive sign-in, I've got a hardware receipt, a tea bag, a rinsed glass, a forged page seven, and a recording of an old man being interrupted by someone who sounded pleased to see him. I've got more evidence than I've ever had, and not one thing that points at a person."

"The recording," I said.

"You've heard it."

"Forty times."

She looked at me sharply. "Do you know that voice?"

I thought of the kitchen. The kettle. The hands round the cup. *Put me on the list, old son.*

"No," I said.

It was the first lie I'd told her. It was a small one. I told myself it was kindness, because the alternative was handing her the name of the one man in the

world who had done nothing but hold me up, on the strength of a *feeling*, three syllables, and a draft in my own head.

She held my eyes a moment longer than she had to.

"Quill's coming at eleven," I said. "Mara's original instruction. A sworn statement. He's bringing the file."

"I know, he rang me last night." For the first time that morning, something in her face eased. "He's a pistol, that man. He told me he'd been sitting on this for five years and he was going to enjoy it. Do you want to be in the room?"

"If you'll have me."

"I'll have you. Eat something."

At eleven Nell had cleared a conference room on the second floor of the county building, with a tape recorder and a pitcher of water and a box of tissues that someone had left there as a joke. I sat at the far end with my hands flat. A trooper stood at the door. The tide table on the wall said high water was at 5:48 that evening, and the causeway wouldn't close until after four. The morning's tide had gone out hours ago.

Eleven-oh-five. Eleven-ten.

At eleven-fifteen Nell went out and rang Quill's office. I could hear her through the door, short and level. She came back in, and she said nothing.

At eleven-thirty she rang his cell. It went to voicemail. She left a message with her name in it, and then, after a pause, mine.

"He's seventy years old," I said. "He drives a Volvo that's older than Cora. He'll be stuck behind a truck on Route 1."

"He's never late," said Nell. "Is he."

I thought about it. In thirty years of Exchange Street, the man had never once, to my knowledge, missed a thing he'd said he would do. Not a hearing. Not a deposit. Not a promise to a dead woman's father.

"No."

At noon she sent a trooper down to Portland to knock on his door. At twelve-twenty the girl who ran the nautical antiques shop beneath his office called back to say that the lights were on upstairs and his door was locked, and that she had seen him go in at seven that morning with a banker's box under his arm, and she hadn't seen him come out.

"Which would mean he's still *in* there," said Nell. "Or he went out the back."

“Or he never went in.”

Neither of us spoke. The tape recorder sat between us with its little red light off. Down in the street I could hear the first of the afternoon traffic coming off the causeway, and the long scream of a gull.

At twelve-forty her phone rang.

She looked at the screen and her face did something I hadn't seen it do, not at the boathouse, not in the unit, not on the breakwater. It went completely still.

“Castellano.”

I watched her listen. I watched her lips, and I watched her free hand go up to the back of her neck and stay there.

“Where on the causeway?” she said.

A pause.

“How long has it been there?”

Another.

“Don't let anybody touch it,” said Nell, already on her feet, already reaching for her coat. “Don't let *anybody* touch it. I'm coming.”

She was at the door before she turned. She looked at me across the little room and the pitcher of water and the box of tissues, and there was something in her face I couldn't have said I'd prepared for.

“It’s a gray Volvo,” she said. “It’s on the shoulder at the low point of the causeway, and the tide has been over it twice.”

Chapter 10: The Low Point

Nell drove the way she did everything, with the whole of her attention and none of her comfort. She took the county building's back lot in a skid, ran the Front Street light, and put the unmarked Ford onto the causeway road with the needle past seventy and her jaw set like a latch.

I didn't say anything. There wasn't anything to say that she didn't already know. The tide table on the conference room wall had said high water at 5:48 that evening. The morning's water had been and gone, and the road was dry and shining and empty, and somewhere out on it was a man I had spoken to on Tuesday afternoon, in his office above the antiques, while he made me promise to eat something.

"Don't touch anything," Nell said, to the windshield. "Don't speak to anyone from the county. If Pryor turns up, you stand behind me and you look at your shoes."

“Pryor?”

“It’s his causeway. It’s his dead.” She changed down for the bend. “Which is why I’ve already called the state lab in Augusta. I’d like somebody in this county to die without being rounded to the nearest accident.”

The causeway is a mile and a quarter of rock fill and asphalt laid across the mud flats in 1911, by men who believed the sea could be argued with. For most of its length it sits comfortably above the flat, but at the middle, in the place the locals call the low point, the road dips eight feet into a trough and the sea comes over it first and leaves it last. There’s a sign. There’s a yellow gauge post painted in feet. Every summer somebody ignores them both and the volunteer fire company winches a rental car out of the grass with the tourists crying on the shoulder.

There was a trooper’s cruiser pulled across the westbound lane, lights turning slowly in the flat noon light, and two men in orange slickers smoking by the guardrail. Beyond them, in the trough, mud-brown to the door handles and strung with weed, sat the gray Volvo station wagon that had been old when I met its owner.

I got out of the car, and the smell came up to meet me: salt, rot, wet wool.

It was nose-down in the shoulder with its left wheels on the asphalt and its right in the drainage ditch, as if the driver had just been about to turn it around. The tide had been over it. You could see exactly how far: a clean brown line across the doors, the glass, up to the middle of the roof, where the water had stood and drawn its own level and then gone away. Windrows of eelgrass hung from the wipers and the roof rack. A single crab, dead and the color of a stained tooth, sat on the hood.

“One tide,” Nell said.

I looked at her.

“Dispatch said twice. It’s once.” She crouched by the rear wheel and put her finger to the line and looked at the silt on it. “One band, no second wash mark. The high water came over at about twenty past five this morning, stood a couple of hours, and went down. The lobsterman who found it called it in at eleven-forty. He said it looked like it’d been sat in the ocean all night, and the dispatcher turned that into ‘twice.’”

“Before twenty past five,” I said.

“Before the water came, yes. It was already here.” She straightened up. “Which is where the girl in Portland and I have a conversation.”

I'd been avoiding the driver's window. I'd been looking at the crab and the gauge post and the gulls, the way you look at everything but the thing, and I could hear that I was doing it. Nell touched my sleeve once. Then she took the cruiser's torch from the trooper and shone it through the glass, and stepped aside, and let me come.

He was in the driver's seat with the belt across him.

Ferris Quill, seventy years old, in his gray overcoat and the Homburg he'd worn since before I was born, with his hands in his lap, one upon the other, like a man waiting for the clerk to call his name. The water had put his hair flat and it had taken the color out of his face, and the glasses he'd worn on a cord for thirty years hung crooked from his neck. His eyes were closed. If somebody had told me he'd dozed off, I'd have wanted to believe them for several seconds.

"Oh, no," I said. "Oh, you old—"

Nell said nothing. She let me stand there.

"He told me to eat something," I said. "On Tuesday. He made me take half his sandwich."

"I know." She said it very quietly. "He told me you'd done it, too."

I looked at the doors. Locked, all four; the little pins were down. The window, rolled up. The key in the ignition, turned off. In the passenger footwell a folded umbrella, black, perfectly dry in a car that had been under the sea. Dry because it had been on the seat, I thought, and had fallen as the water went. His briefcase, empty, lay on the back seat with its clasps open. And that was all.

"The box," I said.

"No box."

"He had a banker's box. Everything he was bringing to you."

"I saw." Nell looked at the empty back seat as though it had insulted her. "The girl said he took it in at seven. If he took it in at seven, he took it out again, and if he took it out again someone has it, and it isn't in this car."

A white county van came over the rise from the island side and pulled up behind the cruiser, and I didn't have to turn to know who got out. I heard the click first. A ballpoint, being pressed and released, pressed and released, a nervous man's metronome.

“Detective.” Ansel Pryor came down the verge in his oatmeal cardigan with a leather bag, mopping his face with a handkerchief. In the daylight he looked sick, the skin of his cheeks glossy and gray. “I’d heard there was something on the causeway. My God. Is it Quill?”

“It’s Quill.”

“A terrible thing. An old man.” He lifted the handkerchief to his mouth and lowered it. He didn’t look at me. He looked at the water line on the door. “He’ll have mistaken the tide. It’s very easy. We have one a year, Detective. People think they know the table, and then there’s a surge, and a car in the dark —”

“In the dark,” said Nell.

“At four, five in the morning. The low point is a trap. He was elderly, he’d have been tired—”

“He didn’t drive onto the low point at five in the morning, Doctor, because he’d never have been on this road at five in the morning. He lived in Portland, he took the 7:40 train, and he was careful about it.” Nell kept her voice quite level. “I’d like him to go to Augusta.”

“That’s irregular. It’s a county death—”

"It's a suspicious death in a county where the last two deaths I put in front of you were called accidents, and one of them is my case and the other was a friend of mine." She let that go by without looking at me. "I've asked the state lab. They're sending a van. If you want to be present, you're welcome. If you want to touch him before they get here—"

"I wouldn't," said Pryor.

He said it too fast. He said it to the car, to the crab on the hood, and I watched his thumb go down on the pen and stay there, and when I looked at his face he had gone to the color of paper.

"I'd never," said Pryor.

Then he went away up the bank to sit in his van with the door open and his hands between his knees, and Nell watched him go.

"He's afraid," she said.

"Of you?"

"Of whatever it is that's coming up the road behind me." She turned back to the car. "Think, Theo. Think like Hollis taught you. A man drives to the low point in the middle of the night, an old man who doesn't drive at night. Why?"

Because someone asked him to.

I said, "Nobody makes Quill do anything. He'd go, if it was Mara's father's lawyer asking. If it was a client. If it was an emergency." I heard myself and stopped. "If he thought it was me."

Nell's phone buzzed in her hand. She read it, and she was silent for a time.

"That's Portland," she said. "They've been in his office."

The detective on the line was named Ruiz and he talked in Nell's ear for four minutes while I watched the sea come back across the flats in a long bright seam. It was a mile out and turning. By five it would be over the road.

When Nell hung up she told me.

The office door on Exchange Street had been locked, and had been locked with a key, from outside. Inside, the lights were on, and the desk lamp, and the little electric heater under the desk, and every other thing in the room was exactly where Quill kept it. Except the cabinet. The big oak cabinet at the back, with the four deep drawers. The bottom drawer was labeled in Quill's cramped hand, BRANDT, M., and the drawer was empty. Not rifled. Emptied, the file folders gone and the hanging rails wiped down.

"The girl says she saw him go in at seven," Nell said.

"This morning."

"This morning is what the trooper reported. I put it to her again myself on the phone from the lot. She thinks about it. She says, 'Well, it was Wednesday, wasn't it? The day before. He said it'd be a big day tomorrow.'" Nell looked at her phone like it owed her money. "The trooper had asked her what time she saw him go in and she said seven, and he wrote *today*. Nobody asked her what day."

"So she saw him on Wednesday morning with the box."

"And not since. The lights have been on since sometime Wednesday. The man left his office on Wednesday and he took the box with him." She counted it on her fingers, quick. "He rang me Wednesday night. I told you. About nine, from home, gleeful as a boy. He's got a landline. His phone company's pulling the log. Ruiz says his neighbor heard his car start at twenty to two."

"At twenty to two in the morning."

"Which is when he leaves Portland, with a banker's box, and drives two hours to a causeway he's not supposed to be on, and gets here at about quarter to four with the tide coming. Which is, if you

work it back, about the time a person could do something to a car and leave it where the water would come." She put the phone away. "Who rings an old man at one in the morning and gets him in the car?"

I'd known it for several minutes. I had the answer ready in my mouth like a stone.

"Somebody who sounds like me," I said.

She didn't say yes. She didn't say anything. She stood with her hands in her jacket pockets and the wind taking her hair, and she let me say the rest.

"The way Tarbell's wife said. The caller who said he was Brandt. I wasn't on the phone, Nell. I was at the Anchor. The clerk—" I stopped. "The clerk saw me at ten past one. I came in. I went up. And then I slept through, and I mean through, I slept eight hours."

"Chain on."

"Chain on."

"Did your phone ring?"

I took it out. I'd muted it to hear Cora's recording, and I had never turned the sound back on. There was one voicemail on the screen, left at 1:41 that morning from a number I knew, because it was a number I'd rung on Tuesday to ask a very old man to eat lunch with me.

I handed it to her. Nell took it. She held it to her ear and I watched her listen, and then, because she was Nell, she said, "Put it on speaker," and held it between us in the wind.

"Mr. Brandt."

Quill's voice. Dry, formal, unhurried, with the faint whistle he got around the s.

"It is a quarter to two, and I am in the car, and I have decided to leave you a message, because I do not at all understand why I am doing this. You rang me at one-fifteen. You said that a thing had come up in the matter of Mara, that there was a place you wanted to meet and not the county building, and a reason. You said the low point of the causeway. I said, Why the low point? And you said, Because there's no one to see us."

A pause. The little tick of the indicator.

"It sounded like you. I want you to understand that. It sounded exactly like you, a young man's voice, rather tired, a little too polite. But you did not call me Ferris. In five years you have never once in your life called me anything but Mr. Quill, and tonight you called me Ferris, and I thought: perhaps he is frightened. Perhaps something has happened."

So I am coming, and I am bringing the original with me. I wouldn't care to leave it in the office overnight."

Nell's hand tightened on the phone.

"If this message finds you, Mr. Brandt, and you know nothing about it, then somebody wished very much to meet me alone, and I have walked into it with my eyes open, which is a thing I was always rather proud of not doing. I shall have the Homburg on. I shall be wearing the good overcoat. If anyone should wish to identify me, I'll be the man who didn't ask what chair."

Silence. Wind on the line, and the long tire-hiss of a road.

"She said you'd know. I never did. I only deliver. Goodnight."

The voicemail ended.

Neither of us moved. A gull came down on the roof of the Volvo and took a tentative step through the weed.

"I told him about the chair," I said at last. My voice sounded very far away. "No. Mara did. In the letter. He said it was on the second envelope, he never read it, he said, *you'll know the chair.*"

"Do you?"

"I don't know."

I did not say what I was seeing, which was a green glass lamp shade at the top edge of a photograph, out of focus, with a pool of yellow light under it. Nell had the photograph. She'd looked at it all night.

I thought, quickly, because I couldn't think slowly: every regional director at Atlantic had been issued the same banker's lamp, brass-armed, green glass. I'd worked under a dozen. They'd been given out in 1988 and nobody had ever taken them back. Hal Rouse had one. I'd seen it. It was on the credenza behind his chair on the fourth floor of the Portland building, the chair with the high leather back, which he'd sat in while a younger me delivered a report he'd tried to talk me out of. *Hal. H.* And on Wednesday afternoon, after Rockland, Quill had had a free afternoon.

"I'm going to Portland," I said.

"Why?"

Because there was a thing I wasn't going to tell her. Because I had put my own wife's letter in the hands of an old man, and an old man had driven to his death in the dark for the sound of my voice, and I could not stand on a causeway with an empty car and tell the detective that the only person I'd told about the eleven o'clock meeting in Port Carrow was the one I'd gone to clear first.

“Because Quill had a diary,” I said. “He kept it on his desk. Tell Ruiz to look at Wednesday.”

Nell was already on the phone. I watched her turn away and speak, listen, speak again, and I watched her face change.

“What,” I said.

She held the phone against her chest.

“Wednesday, 2:30 p.m.,” Nell said. “In his own hand. *H.R., Atlantic Mutual, 4th floor.*”

The sea was a hundred yards off now, and coming on across the mud with a sound like a thousand pages being turned.

“Theo,” said Nell, in a voice so even it frightened me more than shouting would have. “Who did you tell about the eleven o’clock?”

It was the question I’d been waiting for since twelve-forty. It had come at last, and she asked it plainly, without a trace of accusation. She asked it as someone who had lost a friend, and wanted to be told a true thing.

I thought of a kitchen. A kettle. An old man’s hand on the back of my neck. *Put me on the list.*

“Nobody,” I said.

She looked at me for a long time. Past her, in the car, the old man with the Homburg sat with his hands in his lap, waiting for the clerk to call his name.

“Okay,” said Nell. She said it very softly. “Okay.”

And she didn’t believe me. I knew it, as surely as I knew the tide was coming. I watched her put the knowledge away in the place where she kept things she meant to use.

Chapter 11: The Fourth Floor

Nell dropped me at the Anchor at ten past two, and said nothing for the whole of the ride back. At the curb she put the Ford in park and sat looking through the windshield at the Anchor's wet sign.

"Portland," she said.

"Yes."

"Rouse is a frightened man in a nice office. He didn't kill Quill. He can't change a tire."

"Then he won't mind me asking."

"I can't stop you." She turned her head. "I can tell you to call me from the lobby. And again when you come out. And if you don't come out, I'll know what building to start in." When I got out, she added, without looking at me: "Eat something, Theo."

I stood in the road a while after she'd gone. Then I got my car.

It is ninety-one miles from Port Carrow to Portland, and the first fourteen of them are the causeway, the low point, the gauge post, the place where the road remembers it was a sea floor. I took it at forty. At the trough, a county truck sat with its amber light turning while a man in a slicker hosed silt off the asphalt in broad, patient sweeps, as if the road could be made to forget. I didn't look at the guardrail. Past it, the world went back to being a state highway: a Dunkin', a tire place, a billboard for a personal-injury lawyer smiling like a man at his own funeral.

Nell called at Wiscasset.

"State's got him," she said. She sounded tired, with the careful flatness of a woman reading from something she didn't want to be true. "Augusta's van got there at three. Their man looked at him in the bay and rang me from the van, so this is a first look and I'm not going to pretend it's more. No water in the airway. No froth. Nothing in the lungs. He didn't drown, Theo."

I took my foot off the gas without deciding to.

"The tide came over a dead man. Lividity's all in the seat, consistent with sitting up. No marks. They ran what they call a rapid screen in the field lab

because I leaned on them, and it lit for a benzodiazepine. Not a little. The man said it's a level you'd put a horse down on."

"He took them?"

"Quill? He didn't take aspirin. His doctor told me last winter he wouldn't take a flu shot." A pause, a road noise. "Somebody sat with him in that car. Somebody had a thermos, or a bottle of something, and he's seventy and polite, and somebody said it was cold and they'd drink to Mara."

It sounded exactly like you.

"I'll call you from the lobby," I said.

"You do that."

The Atlantic Mutual Casualty building on Congress Street is eleven stories of brown glass built in 1979 by men who admired Mies and didn't understand him. I'd spent ten years of my life in it. I knew which of the three elevators stuck, and which stair door set off an alarm no one answered, and that the third-floor coffee machine made a sound like a drowning cat. I knew that if you came in at 3:40 on a Thursday the guard at the desk would be eating a sandwich behind the *Press Herald* and wouldn't look up.

He looked up.

"Mr. Brandt," he said, and went quietly red. He had been a different man five years ago. I couldn't think of his name. "We've had a— I'm to call upstairs."

"To whom?"

"Mr. Reyes's office. Anytime you come." He swallowed. "I'm sorry. It's the standing note."

"How long's it stood?"

"Since Saturday."

Saturday. Before Tarbell. Before Quill. The day after the body in the boathouse. I thanked him and took the elevator that stuck, and it stuck, and I got out on four with the sensation of a man arriving at a party at which his name had been called out ahead of him.

Hal Rouse had a corner office with two windows and a view of the harbor, and a secretary named Mrs. Keene who stood up when she saw me as though a policeman had come in. He was alone behind a desk the size of a door. Harold Rouse, 63, regional vice president, a long thin man with a narrow lined face and the hollowed look of someone who had been losing weight at a steady rate for years and had run out of things to lose. He wore the same

navy cardigan under the same suit jacket I remembered. He was holding a pen in both hands, upright, like a candle.

"Theo," he said. His voice was a whisper. It had always been a whisper; he'd had throat surgery in the nineties. "I thought you might come. I told Jean to let you up. I'm sorry about Ferris Quill."

"You knew him."

"Wednesday afternoon, yes. He came to see me." He put the pen down. He took it up again. "I understand he's dead. It's on the radio. A car on the causeway."

"He was seen going into this building at 2:30 on Wednesday. In his diary it says H.R."

"I'm H.R." Rouse said it flatly, with a kind of exhausted dignity. "I've always been H.R. I have every initial in this company that begins with an H and an R."

I took the visitor's chair, low and tan and ugly, and looked around. On the credenza behind him stood a brass-armed banker's lamp with a green glass shade, lit in the middle of the afternoon, pooling yellow on a blotter. Above it hung a framed photograph of Rouse with the governor.

It was the lamp. It was the right lamp. Not a trick of the light, not the angle; the green was the green in the ledger photograph, the same tilt in the shade. And behind the desk, the high-backed leather chair, cracked at one arm, the kind you sat in and heard it creak.

I'd sat in the other one. I'd always sat in the other one.

"Mr. Quill asked me about the lamp," said Rouse, who had followed my eyes. "Showed me a photograph. A piece of one. Asked if I knew it. I said every regional director of the old guard has one. The company bought three hundred in 1988 from a man in Providence and told us we were being modernized." The ghost of a smile. "I said, I expect you'd find that lamp in a good many rooms."

"What did he want?"

"He wanted to know who approved the payments." He folded his hands. "Four files. He had the names on a piece of paper, initials only, but I knew them. Doyle. Anselm. The Farrow woman. And a fourth he wouldn't tell me, and I think I know it, and I'd just as soon not say it aloud." He looked up. "He asked who signs. I told him: I signed. I'm the signature. Regional VP. Anything over five hundred thousand goes to me."

"You signed them."

"I signed forty a week. Fifty." The whisper cracked. "Do you know what a regional VP reads? The cover sheet. A one-page summary and the adjuster's recommendation. The file's behind it. I've never in my life read a file where the cover sheet was clean, Theo. If the adjuster was good and the director had initialed it—"

"Which director?"

"Whichever one it was. On those, the cover sheet said *recommend payment, no evidence of third-party involvement*, and under it a pair of initials, and they were good initials. I trusted them."

"Whose?"

A long pause. In the harbor beyond the glass a ferry was working back to the pier.

"It was a long time ago," said Rouse.

"Hal."

"Yours." He said it so gently I thought I'd misheard. "Yours, Theo. The adjuster's recommendation. T.B., T.B., T.B., and I trusted you more than I trusted myself. You were the best I had. I'd sign a file with your name on it blindfold. I *did*."

I said nothing for what felt like a minute. I had seen the ledger photograph. But there's knowing, and there is a frightened old man telling you across a desk that you were the reason it worked.

"Someone put them on my desk," I said.

"I assume so."

"Who assigns the field files? Not you."

"The regional director. Assigned, and then countersigned at the close." He rubbed his face. "I saw it, once. The language. I'd had four closing letters on my blotter over three years and I thought, they read as if they were all written by the same man. And I said so, in a meeting, to Desmond. He was assistant then. I said, *the language is very consistent in these*. And Desmond said that consistency was a sign of a well-run shop." Rouse laughed without sound. "And I thought, he's right. And I went home."

"You looked away."

"I *looked away*." It wasn't a whisper. It was only very quiet. "I have been looking away for nine years, and in all that time I have been the nicest man in this building. I'm known for it. I send flowers. It is not an accomplishment."

"The chair," I said.

"What?"

“Mara said I’d know the chair. And Quill said it on the phone before he died. That he’d be the man who didn’t ask what chair.” I looked at the leather behind the desk, and I watched him look at it as well, without comprehension, as one looks at a sofa. “I think it’s this one.”

“It’s my chair.” He seemed bewildered. “I’ve had it eleven years. It came with the office. They always do. I expect Hollis’s old fellow had it before—”

The door opened without a knock.

Desmond Reyes did not come into a room; he deployed into it. He was fifty-two and fit, with the shaved scalp and rimless glasses of a man whose self-image was a surgeon’s, and he moved with the tidy economy of someone who expected to find the furniture arranged correctly. He wore a charcoal suit and a tie with a very small knot. Behind him, in the door, Mrs. Keene put her hand to her throat and said, “I’m so sorry, he—”

“Thank you, Jean.”

She went.

“Theo,” said Reyes. He didn’t smile. He gave me my own first name the way you hand a man his hat. “I’d hoped it would be a phone call. I’ve had a bad

week. I imagine you have as well.”

“You sent the lobby a standing note on Saturday.”

“I send the lobby a note on anyone with a claims history.” His nasal voice was carefully pleasant. “Hal, you’re not feeling well. Go sit down in the other room.”

“I’m perfectly—”

“Hal.”

Rouse stood up. His chair rolled back and struck the credenza and the green shade rocked, and for a second the light swung over all of us. Then he went out through the side door, with his cardigan hanging off his narrow shoulders, and shut it behind him with exquisite care.

Reyes took the leather chair.

He didn’t ask. He sat. He put his two hands flat on the blotter, and under the green light he looked at me for what felt like a very long time.

“I’m withdrawing your engagement on Farrow,” he said. “Effective now. Atlantic thanks you for your work. You’ll bill me through Tuesday and you’ll return every document in your possession by Monday noon, and I’ll have a courier at your office if you’d prefer not to deliver them yourself.”

“On what grounds?”

"On the ground that you are no longer a disinterested adjuster. You're a witness. You're a person of interest in the death of Ned Tarbell. The state police have your business card on his body." He said it as a matter of courtesy, in the voice of a man listing the ways a window might leak. "And as of this morning, you appear in the file of a second death. I have to think about the company, Theo. I have to think about what it is if our field investigator is found to have been, in any sense, party to a—"

"Quill."

"Mr. Quill. Yes."

"You knew Quill was dead before I walked in."

"The *Press Herald* has it online, Theo, with a photograph of the car." He tilted his head. "I'd like you to hear me. I'm not warning you off because of what I fear. I'm warning you because of what I know of you. You were a good adjuster and then you were a very sad man, and then you were a sober one, and Atlantic has been grateful, and generous, and patient. I'm talking about *patience*." A small smile, at last, quick and joyless as a hinge. "If you go on—if you take what you've found, whatever it is, to people outside the company—the company will defend itself. We'll say what we know. That you had a breakdown.

That you've been sleeping rough. That you have a gap in your memory that you've never been able to account for. I can *document* it."

It was very quiet. Out in the corridor a phone rang and rang.

"Who told you about the gap?" I said.

"I read your file."

"It isn't in the file."

Reyes looked at me through the rimless lenses, and for the first time his face did not move at all.

"Mr. Dunn mentioned it," he said. "At a dinner. Years ago. He worries about you so. He asked us all to be understanding." He stood. "Go home, Theo. Go back to Port Carrow and sit with your friend. He's the only one of us who's never been anything but good to you."

The guard walked me out. He was very apologetic. On the sidewalk on Congress Street the wind had come up, with a smell of rain and diesel, and I stood with my back to the glass and called Nell and told her *I'm out*, and *Reyes pulled me*, and *Quill saw Rouse for the lamp*, *Rouse signed*, *nothing else*.

"And?"

“He’s frightened. He’s compromised. He didn’t kill anyone.”

“I told you.”

“He signed forty files a week on my name, Nell. On my name. They went through because it was me.”

She was quiet. Then she said, “I’m sorry,” in a voice that didn’t soften it, and I loved her a little for that.

I was fumbling for the car key when the lobby door opened behind me and somebody said, “Mr. Brandt?” in a whisper.

Rouse had come down the stairs. He’d put on a gray raincoat over the cardigan and he held the door with a hand that wasn’t steady, and he looked back over his shoulder at the empty lobby the way a man looks who has been followed before. He didn’t come out. He stood between the glass doors, in the little vestibule where the mats were.

“I didn’t want to say it in front of Desmond,” he whispered. “I didn’t want to say it in that room. I’m a coward, Theo, I told you. But Quill asked me one more thing on Wednesday that I didn’t tell you. It was the last thing, and I didn’t want to answer, and I did.”

“What?”

“He asked if anyone had come to see me. Five years ago. About Mara.”

The wind blew a page of newspaper across the road.

"I said no. And then I said, *well. You did.*"

"I what?"

"You came to see me, Theo. You don't remember." He wasn't asking. His eyes were wet and absolutely certain. "It was a Monday. The fifth. Mara had been dead— no. She wasn't. It was nine days before. You came in at four in the afternoon and you sat in the low chair, where you were sitting today, and you were sober. Do you hear me? You were stone sober, and white as paper, and you asked me one question. You wanted to know how an employee of Atlantic reports a fraud inside the company. Who runs the ethics line. Who reads it. Whether it goes to the director of claims."

I couldn't feel my hands.

"I said, *do you have proof?* You said, *my wife does.* And I said—" His voice failed him, and came back. "I said *be careful who you tell.* That's all. I said it as a *kindness.* And you thanked me and went out. And nine days later your wife was dead and I never said a word to anyone, because I thought: *who did he tell, after me?*"

The glass doors hummed in their frames. Across the street a bus sighed to the curb.

“I’ve been waiting five years for you to ask,” said Hal Rouse. “And you never did. And I thought: he doesn’t remember. He doesn’t *know* he came. So whoever he told next is the one person who’s never had to wonder.”

“Who did I tell?”

“I don’t know,” he whispered. “That’s what I’m asking you.”

He let the door close between us. I saw him through the glass, a thin old man in a gray coat, going back across the lobby like someone returning to a cell. I stood on Congress Street with the key in my hand, and the sky coming down, and ten days of October behind me in the dark.

I had walked into that building looking for a chair, and I had found the chair, and it was the one I’d been sitting in.

Chapter 12: Retained Sample

The causeway was closed when I got to it.

I should have known. I had a tide table in my head the way other men have a bad knee, and somewhere between Rockland and the Neck road, with Hal Rouse's whisper still going round in the car, I had stopped consulting it. High water was 5:50. It was ten past six. A sawhorse stood across the road at the mainland end with a reflective sign hung on it, ROAD CLOSED — TIDE, and beyond it the causeway ran out flat and dark into a sheet of water that shone like a tray. The low point was gone. The gauge post stood up out of the sea with its yellow feet numbered to nowhere.

Port Carrow sat out there with its lights coming on. Two hours, the sign said, give or take the wind.

I parked in the gravel lot of the Neck Texaco, the last building on the mainland, and turned the engine off, and for a while I did nothing. I'd been told to eat.

There was a rack of sandwiches in cellophane through the window. I didn't move.

Who did he tell, after me?

I tried it the way you'd try a door in the dark, with the flat of the hand. Monday the fifth, four in the afternoon. A low tan chair. I was sober, Rouse said, white as paper. And then: nothing. Not a wall, not a fog. An absence so smooth that the edges of it didn't hurt, which was the worst of it. I'd been looking for five years for the place where my memory broke, and it turned out to have been cut with a very clean blade.

A knuckle rapped the glass beside my head.

Nell stood in the rain with her hood up and a manila envelope under her jacket. I hadn't heard the Ford.

"Wiscasset to here in forty minutes," she said when I got the window down. "You didn't call from the lobby."

"I called from the street."

"I said the lobby." She went round and got into the passenger seat and shook the water off her hood onto my mat. "Your face looks like somebody read you your own obituary. Don't tell me yet. Eat first."

"Nell."

“Eat.” She put a sandwich in my hand. She’d bought it before she knocked. Egg salad. I looked at it and then I ate it, all of it, in the dark car with the windows steaming up and the sea hissing against the end of the road, and she watched me do it with the grim attention of somebody supervising a dose.

“Rouse says I went to see him,” I said, when I’d finished. “Five years ago. Monday the fifth. I asked him how to report fraud inside Atlantic.”

She didn’t say anything. Her hands were flat on her knees.

“I told him Mara had proof. He told me to be careful who I told. That’s what he said and he thought it was kind.” I rubbed my eyes. “I don’t remember a minute of it, and I don’t remember where I went when I walked out, and he thinks that whoever I told next is the one person who’s had five years to look at me and not wonder.”

“And who did you tell?”

“I don’t know.”

It was the truth. That was what made it possible to say it in her face. It was the second thing I had said to her that day that was, in the precise and literal sense, true.

She was quiet a long moment. Out beyond the sawhorse a light on a buoy came round and went out and came round.

"You said *Nobody*," she said. "About Quill's appointment. When I asked who knew."

"Yes."

"I'm going to ask you once more, because I like you, and because you've just told me something that cost you. Was that true?"

"I told you I didn't remember who I told in October five years ago."

"That isn't what I asked."

"No," I said. "It isn't."

Nell nodded slowly, as though I'd confirmed a measurement. "All right." She took the envelope from under her jacket and set it on the dashboard between us. "Then I'll tell you something, and you can decide what to do with it, and we'll both pretend we're still doing this the clean way."

She'd had the idea on Tuesday night, she said, sitting on the floor of her kitchen with the Rockland boxes spread out in photographs. Mara's folder marked ME REPORTS held copies of four death certificates and four autopsy summaries, and every one of them,

when you laid them side by side, had the same shape. A short narrative. A cause. A line near the bottom, in the same careful typeface: *Toxicology: negative*.

"Four of them," Nell said. "And Mara's own, which she couldn't have copied, because she was the body. I got that one myself, from the county, in September. Pryor's report. *Drowning, accidental. Toxicology: negative*." She tapped the envelope. "Except it's got a lab number. Every autopsy from his office gets a lab number, it's how the tox gets matched to the case. I ran that number. It doesn't exist. Nobody in this state ever filed a toxicology request on your wife."

I looked at the envelope and didn't touch it.

"So I asked what else exists," said Nell. "She didn't die in the water. Not on paper. A fisherman pulled her out at the breakwater and a volunteer rescue crew took her to the Port Carrow clinic and the clinic put her in a transport to Pen Bay, because there was a pulse, for about eleven minutes. Did you know that?"

"I knew she'd been alive when they took her out." My voice sounded odd in the car. "I didn't know it was eleven minutes."

"At Pen Bay, the ER draws blood on anything that comes in wet. It's routine. They run alcohol and a basic screen and hold the tube, and they hold it a

long time, because of lawyers. Five years, in the cold room, in a rack, by date.” She breathed out. “Nobody ever asked them for it. Nobody even remembered there’d been a draw. I got a judge to sign a paper Monday morning and I drove it to Rockport myself. They found it Tuesday. Augusta ran it yesterday. I got the result at four o’clock, in the lot behind the county building, while you were in a brown glass tower being told you had a gap.”

She opened the envelope. There was one sheet in it. She held it so I could read it by the glow of the gas-station sign.

I’m not a chemist. I read the line she showed me three times. A drug name, a unit, a number. *Present*.

“Lorazepam,” said Nell. “Same class as what was in Quill. Not the horse dose. About what you’d give a man at a dentist’s to make him stop caring. In a woman that size, forty minutes before the draw, maybe an hour. Maybe less.”

The windshield was fogging again. I put a finger to the glass and drew a line down it, and it ran.

“Mara didn’t sleep,” I said.

“What?”

“The last month. She wasn’t sleeping. She’d get up at three and sit in the kitchen with the files. I’d find the light on.” I heard myself and stopped, and made

myself go on. "If she took something. If she was frightened and she took one—"

"She had no prescription." Nell said it gently. "I pulled her pharmacy history. Nothing for ten years, not a Tylenol PM. And she never took pills. She didn't like what they did to her head. She told me that on a boat, once, with a seasick patch on her neck, because she'd rather be sick than fuzzy."

"You *knew* her."

I hadn't meant it to come out like that. Nell's face did something I hadn't seen it do. It didn't crumple, it just stopped holding.

"We met on a committee," she said. "Drowning prevention. Lifejacket loaners at the public landings, a stupid worthy thing with bake sales. Six years ago. She used to bring lemon bars and apologize for them." The corner of her mouth moved. "She called me the second week of October. The week she died. She wanted to know whether a state detective could take a complaint about insurance fraud, if it was inside a company and the company wouldn't hear it. I said bring me paper. She said she'd have it in a few days." She stared at the sea. "She never came. And on the sixteenth I was told by my lieutenant, who was kind, that a drowning on the breakwater was closed

and I was not to spend my time on a friend's grief. That's how he said it. *Your friend's grief*. Like it was my disease."

"You never said."

"Would you have wanted a cop who was grieving in your hotel room?" She folded the sheet and put it back. "I'm saying it now. I wanted you to know what I'm bringing you, and who it's from, and that I haven't forgotten any of it."

I took a long time with the next question.

"What does it prove?"

"Less than you want." She said it at once, the way she'd have said it to a jury. "It proves your wife had a benzodiazepine in her blood when she went into the water, and nobody prescribed it, and the man who signed her death certificate said he'd tested for it when he hadn't. That's all. It doesn't say who gave it to her. A defense lawyer will say she was terrified and took her sister's pills. It doesn't say she was put in the water. It doesn't even say the drug was the reason she drowned. A woman who's been given a sedative and walks into the sea on her own is still a drowning, and a good lawyer will remind the jury of that."

"But."

“But Pryor lied on the page.” She put her finger on the dashboard. “That’s the knot. He lied on her report and he lied on Tarbell’s and he was sweating through his shirt in front of Quill’s car this afternoon. Somebody’s got his name on a ledger of their own. And every man who lies like that has one night where it stops being worth it.”

The causeway sawhorse had a man at it now, a volunteer in a slicker with a flashlight, watching the water the way a groundskeeper watches a game. It had stopped raining. The tide was making its last long slack push at the bottom of the road.

“Tell me about Hollis,” Nell said.

I didn’t turn my head. “What about him?”

“He rang me. About twenty minutes before you pulled in. I’d turned my phone back on.” She sounded careful, as though stepping over something. “He was so worried. He’d heard from somebody at the county that you’d gone to Portland and he wanted to make sure you ate. He asked if I’d told you about Mara’s—” She stopped. “I had never said a word to him about a sample. I’d told no one but a judge and a lab tech. I said, *what about Mara?* and he said, oh, only that

you'd be thinking of her, with Wednesday just gone. And he laughed at himself and said he was an old woman. And that was all it was."

"That's all it was," I said.

"That's all it was." She looked at me. "It's probably all it was. Port Carrow is six hundred people and a county building with thin walls. I just thought I'd tell somebody I think too much."

Well. There you are, then.

That latch sticks in damp.

Nine-twelve.

Every one of them had a plain reason. I could have lined them up in the glovebox, a row of small excuses, each of them reasonable, each of them mine. I had given them reasons for a week as a man keeps feeding a stove that's going out. I didn't look at Nell. I looked at the water, and I thought of the green cardigan and the kettle, of a man with a blue sailor's anchor on his wrist who'd driven me to my first meeting and sat in the folding chair beside me in the church basement and held my coat, and I said:

"He's worried. That's what he does."

"It is," said Nell, after a moment. She put her hand on the door. She didn't open it. "I'm going to say one thing and then I'll leave you alone. You've got a

cutter key in your pocket, haven't you? I saw you take it out at Mara's unit, to look at it, the way people finger a coin."

My hand was in my pocket. It had been in my pocket the whole time, around a brass key on a bit of tarred string.

"Don't use it," she said, "without me." And she got out, and shut the door softly, and went back across the lot to the Ford.

The volunteer lifted the sawhorse at twenty to eight.

I'd started the engine and put the car in gear when my phone lit on the passenger seat. Port Carrow exchange. A landline. I let it ring three times, and then I picked it up and said nothing, and there was a breath on the other end, wet and quick, and the click, click, click of a ballpoint pen.

"Mr. Brandt," said Ansel Pryor.

"Doctor."

"Are you on the road?" It was hardly a voice. It sounded as though it were being held up by the person speaking. "Are you alone?"

"Why?"

"Because the detective's been to see me," he said. "At the county building, this afternoon. And she held a piece of paper in her hand and she didn't say anything, she only held it, and I watched her not say anything for about a minute, and I haven't been able to sit down since." The pen stopped. Started. "I've been a coward for nine years. I'd like to stop. I'd like to do it tonight, before I find that I don't."

"Then talk to Nell. She's ten minutes from you."

"No." It came back at once, like a blow. "Not her. Not the county. Not anyone in a uniform. They have—I don't know who they have. I'm saying it plainly, Mr. Brandt, I don't know. I've done things for these people. They're not people who need uniforms." He swallowed. "You were the adjuster. You were the *name*. I'll tell you what I know about your wife, and your file, and the others, and the person who paid me. You first. Then you can take me to whomever you like."

"Who paid you?"

"Not on a phone."

"Where?"

"Tonight." The pen again. "I'm at my house. Gannet Road, the white one, past the gravel pit. I'll leave the porch light on. Come after eleven, when the street's asleep, and come on foot from the church,

and for God's sake don't let anyone see you." I heard a door somewhere, or a gate. "And Mr. Brandt. Don't tell anyone you're coming. I mean that. Not a soul."

"I've no one to—"

"Yes, you do," said Pryor, very softly. "That's the point. You always have."

The line went dead.

The sawhorse was gone. The causeway ran out ahead of me, flat and black and glittering, with the lights of the town at the end of it like a thing seen under water. I sat with my hands on the wheel, and the cutter key pressed its small hard shape into my thigh, and for the first time in five years I understood that I had a decision to make about the one telephone number I'd never had to think about at all.

At the middle of the road, where the low point dipped, my phone lit once more on the seat. *Hollis*. A text, as it had always been, in the careful full sentences of a man who never learned to abbreviate.

Kettle's on. Come and tell me what they've done to you in Portland. I'll leave the light on.

I read it twice at forty miles an hour with the black water standing on both sides of me, a foot from the wheels, and then I put the phone face down on the seat and did not answer.

Chapter 13: The White House on Gannet Road

I did not go to Hollis's.

I want that on the record, because of what came after. The causeway took me in at ten to eight, water still sliding off its shoulders in sheets. At the first fork the town offered me two roads. Left was Quarry Lane, where a green-shaded lamp would be burning in a converted pantry and a kettle coming up to the boil in the voice I had known for nine years. Right was the Anchor. I sat at the fork with the engine running and my hands at ten and two, like a boy taking his test.

I turned right.

It was not a decision. I would like to say it was, but it was closer to what a hand does on a stove. Then I was in room 6 with the chain on and my coat still wet, sitting on the end of the bed with the phone face-down on the spread, and I couldn't have told you why.

You always have.

I have thought about that sentence more than any I've been given. Pryor had said it so softly. He had not said *Hollis*. He had said *someone*, and it was a man who'd spent nine years learning how to keep from naming things. I told myself it meant Nell. I told myself it meant Mara, who had always been the person I'd told everything. By half past eight I had run out of people it could mean, and I got up and washed my face in the sink and did not look in the mirror.

At nine I phoned Nell.

I want that on the record too. I had her number up, and my thumb on it, and I rang it, and it went to voicemail, and I listened to her recorded voice say *Castellano, leave it*, and I opened my mouth.

"It's Theo," I said. "I'm at the inn. I'm going to bed." A pause long enough that I could hear the tape running. "Thank you for the sandwich."

I hung up. *Tell no one. Not a soul. Not the county, not anyone in uniform.* I had been told it by a man whose voice shook, and I had spent my working life listening to men whose voices shook, and I knew precisely what the shake was worth and I did it

anyway. A frightened man will give you everything if you come alone. Bring a badge and he gives you a lawyer. I had told myself that in a hundred kitchens. It was true in all of them.

It is also the reasoning of every man who has ever walked into a room by himself.

At ten I went down the back stairs, through the alley the night clerk used for her cigarettes, and out into Water Street. The clerk wasn't at the desk. I took that, in my stupidity, as luck.

Port Carrow at night is a town with the lights turned down for company. The tide had gone out, and the harbor smell had come up the lanes behind it, kelp and diesel and wet rope, and everything dripped. I walked. Nobody was out. A television flickered blue in an upper window above the hardware store, and somewhere a dog was being told, patiently, to come in.

The church was at the top of Church Street, white clapboard, a steeple the color of a fish's belly under the one streetlight. St. Brendan's Methodist. I knew the basement better than the nave. I stood under the light and looked at the door I had gone in by on my

eleventh day of sobriety, on a man's arm, and I let myself stand there for exactly as long as it took to be sure no one was following me.

No one was. I'd have bet my license. I'd have lost it.

Gannet Road ran behind the church and out along the old quarry, a one-lane ribbon of tar with grass in the center and houses set back from it in the dark. Past the last of them was the gravel pit, a crater of pale stone with a chain across the mouth and a sign about trespassers. Past the pit was a white house.

The porch light was on.

It was a fixture shaped like a lantern, with a moth batting at it, and it lit a square of wet boards and a brown door mat and the front door beyond. I stood at the edge of the yard in the wet grass and looked at the whole house. A one-story ranch, white siding, a carport with a county-issue Chevy in it. Lights on in two windows at the side. Curtains drawn. No sound at all but the quarry water dripping in the pit.

It was ten past eleven.

I went up the steps, and I knocked.

The door was not latched. It moved inward under my knuckles with a small dry sound, the sound a door makes when it has been left that way on purpose, and the hall behind it was warm. A lamp on. A coat rack with a county parka on it. A smell, faintly, of lemon, and under it, wool.

“Doctor?”

Nothing. I stood on the mat and breathed through my mouth.

Come in, I thought, he’s waiting. He said the porch light on, he’s in the kitchen with the kettle, he’s afraid. And I went in, because the alternative was to go back down the steps into the dark, and I had come a very long way to hear a man say what he’d done.

The kitchen was empty. A single mug stood on the counter beside a kettle, and the kettle, when I put the back of my hand to it, was warm. Not hot. A mug, a lemon wedge pale on a saucer, the tag of a tea bag over the rim.

I looked at the tag. It was a perfectly ordinary tag. I noticed it the way you notice a stranger in a crowd and do not see his face.

Light came from the end of the hall. I followed it.

His study was the room at the back, with a window onto the pit. A big oak desk, a green blotter, a wall of grey metal filing cabinets with their drawers sitting a half inch proud. A leather chair swung around to face the window. Ansel Pryor sat in it with his head back and his mouth a little open, in the oatmeal cardigan, one hand in his lap and the other hanging.

I knew before I touched him. You know. I had been in rooms with the dead ever since I was twenty-six, and the dead have a way of occupying a chair that the living, even the sleeping living, do not.

Still, I went round and put two fingers to his neck. He was cool and slightly clammy, the way a thing is that has been at room temperature for a while. His eyes were half open. They looked at nothing in the window, and the window looked back at him, and the pit lay under it as pale as a plate.

On the desk, a bottle of Glenlivet, a third gone. A tumbler, on its side, a stain on the blotter below it. An orange pharmacy bottle, uncapped, empty, a white drift of tablets spilled beside it like a thing that had happened to a snowman. And a pen.

It was a ballpoint, a cheap blue Bic with the cap chewed. It lay across a single sheet of paper, as though set there by a man who had finished writing

and was about to put his name to it. I knew that pen. I had listened to it click for six days.

I do not remember deciding to read the note. I remember my breath, and the sound of the pit dripping, and the smell of lemon.

To whom it concerns,

I can no longer go on. I have signed what I was handed for nine years and I can't sign any more. Mr. Brandt's reports did not tell the truth and I knew it, and I wrote what he needed. He knows what I did and why. I am sorry. I am sorry for the women.

A. Pryor

It was typed. The signature at the bottom was in blue ink, shaky and good.

I didn't take the paper. I'd like that remembered too. I touched the edge of the desk, and the back of the chair, and the doorframe going out, and the kettle going in, and the knob of the front door both ways. I touched the little brass cat on the hall table, God knows why. The sum of my evening, as a forensic document, was a lamp and a coat rack and every surface in the house, and I realized it standing in the hall with my phone in my hand and my thumb already on Nell's name.

She picked up on the first ring.

“Castellano.”

“It’s me. I’m in a house on Gannet Road. The white one past the gravel pit.” My voice was steady and it frightened me. “Pryor’s dead. I got here five minutes ago. Please come.”

There was a short silence in which I heard her stand up from something. “Don’t touch anything.”

“I’ve touched everything.”

“Okay,” said Nell, and the flatness in it was the sound of a woman doing her arithmetic. “Stay in the hall. Don’t sit, don’t go back in the room. I’m eight minutes. Theo.”

“Yes?”

“How long did you know he was going to be there?”

I looked down the hall at the lit door of the study. “Since a quarter to eight.”

She said nothing. The line stayed open for a moment, and then it went dead, and out on the road, faint and getting stronger, I heard a siren I had not called.

It was a Port Carrow cruiser, a white Ford Interceptor with a bar of blue lights going round. It came up Gannet Road far too fast for the width of it and slewed onto the grass in front of the house. A big young officer got out with his gun not quite drawn. *Dill*, said the plate over his pocket. He was perhaps twenty-six, with a head like a tin of beans and the cautious white face of a man the town had hired for his mother's sake.

"Sir. Step out onto the porch with your hands where I can see them."

"I called the state police. Detective Castellano's on her way."

"We had a call." He had his flashlight in my face. "A prowler. Somebody walking up Gannet Road in a dark coat who looked to be trying the doors. Hands, sir."

"Who called?"

"Hands."

I put them up. It is one of the stranger humiliations of an honest life, how fast the body knows what to do.

"There's a man dead inside," I said. "Dr. Pryor. In the study."

Dill's face changed. It was not a face made for it. He went past me into the house with his gun now fully out, and I heard him in the hall, and then I heard him stop. And then I heard what he said, which I won't repeat.

By the time Nell's Ford came up the road he had put me in cuffs.

I have been arrested twice. The first time was the Rockport hospital corridor, five years ago, when a trooper stood me against a wall and I was too drunk to know what for. The second time was a young man named Dill reading me my rights on a porch in the rain, in a voice trembling at the edges, as though the words might go off.

Nell stood in the yard and watched it. She had her hood down. Her hair was plastered flat and she did not wipe the water from her face, and I could tell that if I looked at her too long I would say something that couldn't be said.

"Officer," she said. "Uncuff him."

"Ma'am, I've got a prowler call, he's on the property, he's got a body—"

"I know. I'm taking him in my own car." She held up her badge. "State police. This is a state-police matter, and you're going to go and stand by that cruiser, and not let anyone in the house but the people I tell you. Do you understand?"

He did, in the way a large dog understands. He took the cuffs off. I rubbed my wrists.

Nell took my arm and turned me, slowly, to face her. She stood close, so that no one else would hear.

"Did you touch the note?"

"No."

"What did it say?"

I told her, word for word. She closed her eyes through the whole of it. When I'd finished she opened them, and what was in them was neither anger nor pity, but the hard clear look of a woman reading the last page of a bill.

"You were warned," she said. "By him. *Tell no one*. And you didn't tell me. Not even me, after the car. After the sandwich."

"If I'd brought you—"

"If you'd brought me, he might be alive." She didn't raise her voice. "Or he might not. Or you might have been in that chair. I don't know, Theo, and now I never will, and that's what you gave me." Her jaw worked. "You got a call at 7:45 from a man who was

dead by midnight. It's on the phone company's log. It's on yours. I'm not going to be able to make that go away."

"I know."

"Do you know who else knew you were coming?"

It was there. The word. It was right there, behind my teeth, with its blue anchor and its green cardigan and its kettle. And Nell was looking at me, and the porch light shone on her wet face, and in that moment I could have said *Hollis texted me at 7:40*. I could have said *he said he'd leave the light on*.

Which was a thing he had said in his text, and a thing Pryor had said on the phone. The same words.

"No one," I said. "I told no one."

It is a terrible thing to watch a person decide whether to believe you. I watched her do it. I watched her look at me in the yard of a dead man's house and conclude something, and put it away.

"Get in the car," said Nell.

They held me at the county building on Mill Street, in the same basement corridor where I had first been told my wife's death certificate was in order. It was a room with a bench and a steel toilet and a drain in the floor. They took my shoelaces. A deputy I didn't

know brought me a Styrofoam cup of coffee and then took it away again, apologetically, because someone in an upstairs office had decided I should have nothing hot.

Detective Ouellette came at ten past two. He was a tall, sallow, courteous man in a cheap blue tie, and he sat on the other side of the table with a manila folder and did not open it.

"You're not under arrest yet," he said. "I want to be clear. You're being held for questioning in an unattended death, on the strength of a prowler complaint and the fact that your fingerprints appear to be on every object in the house." He smiled very slightly. "And I'm to say you may call a lawyer."

"I don't have one."

"No. I expect that's a thing that happens to a man." He opened the folder. "Dr. Pryor's time of death will be decided in Augusta, but the state man who looked at him puts it between nine and ten. You were seen entering the Anchor Inn at ten to eight. The night clerk was off her desk from nine until ten-thirty. She says she went to the bakery for a friend. The back stairs let out on an alley." He turned a page. "You'll see what I'm doing."

"I was in my room."

"Is there someone who can say so?"

I thought of the empty desk, the hotel with its lights out, the long white corridor. "No."

"I'd have thought not." He closed his eyes briefly, like a man at grace. "The detective told me what you said about the note, and I read it myself at the scene. That's one sheet. I want to show you something else."

He took a second sheet from the folder and slid it across.

It was a photocopy of a handwritten page, small, cramped, in what I knew at once to be Ansel Pryor's own hand: a doctor's hand, the letters closed up tight like fists. It had been found, Ouellette said, in the bottom drawer of the desk, under the blotter, in an envelope marked *If anything happens*. It was undated. It had two paragraphs. I read the first, and the room tilted, and I read it again.

On the evening of October 5, five years ago, Mr. Theodore Brandt came to my home on Gannet Road. He was sober and very calm. He said his wife had been going through Atlantic's files and had found things in four deaths that could not be explained, and that she meant to take them to the ethics line and from there to the police. He said there were four ME reports with my name. He said he would give me one night to decide what I would do. He said it would be better for everyone if she stopped.

I did not know what he meant. I know now.

The second paragraph was a single line.

Ask him where he was on the night of the fifth. He will not be able to tell you.

I read it a third time.

I don't remember Ouellette leaving. I remember the drain in the floor, and the light going on and off in the corridor beyond the wired glass, and sitting on the steel bench with my hands open on my knees. Hal Rouse had put me in a brown-glass office at four. Somebody had put me, at night, at a stranger's door on the same Monday, saying the thing a man says when he has already decided.

Nine days I had lost. And somebody had known the exact shape of the hole, and had found the one thing to put in it.

Chapter 14: The Person to Call

By four in the morning I had worn a pale place in the skin between my thumb and forefinger.

It was where a pen rested. There was no pen in the cell, but my hand kept making room for one. I wanted to write the fifth of October down: four o'clock, Hal Rouse; evening, Ansel Pryor. I wanted columns, a line between what somebody said and what anybody could prove. Without paper, the two men kept moving closer together until there was no space left for me between them.

In Rouse's office I had been trying to protect my wife. At Pryor's house, according to a dead man's handwriting, I had been trying to stop her.

Both accounts described me as sober.

That was the part I couldn't leave alone. I'd always put a bottle at the beginning of those missing days. A bottle was a thing you could understand. You could knock it over, pour it out, take yourself to a church basement and count the days since you'd last

touched it. But two men had now put me in rooms before the drinking, and I couldn't remember either room.

The door opened at twenty past four.

A woman in a charcoal suit stood beside the deputy. Her hair was short and silver, and she carried a leather bag with one broken handle repaired in red thread. She looked at the steel toilet, then at me.

"Theodore Brandt?"

"Yes."

"Ellen Sayer. I'm your lawyer."

"I didn't call a lawyer."

"Somebody did. Get up."

They gave us the interview room with the camera off. Sayer checked the light herself before she sat down. She put a legal pad on the table and uncapped a fountain pen.

"Who hired you?" I asked.

"Hollis Dunn. My office number is on the wall beside his telephone. He called at three seventeen."

There was a place inside my chest that had been held tight all night. It loosened before I could stop it.

"How did he know?"

"He rang the inn because you hadn't answered him. The clerk told him the police had been asking about you. He made another call. Then he called me."

"You've come from Portland?"

"I was in Camden. My sister has a guest room and a very loud clock." She wrote my name at the top of the pad. "Mr. Dunn pays the bill. You are the client. He gets no account of what you tell me unless you ask me to give him one. Do we understand each other?"

I nodded.

"Now. Did you ask to leave?"

"No."

"Have you told them you'd stay voluntarily?"

"I don't think so."

"Have they charged you?"

"They said they hadn't."

She set the pen down.

"Then we'll start there."

I tried to tell her about the note before she went out. She held up a hand.

"I will read it. First I want the room unlocked."

She was gone for twelve minutes. I counted them by the second hand on the clock above the wired glass. Through the wall I could hear Ouellette's voice

and hers, both too low to make out. Once his rose enough for me to hear *circumstances*. Hers stayed where it was.

When she came back she had copies of both notes.

"They can't keep holding you just because you spoke with Pryor," she said. "The prosecutor is reviewing the death. In the meantime they intend to book you for criminal trespass."

"He asked me to come."

"That's what you say. Their complaint describes you entering a private house without permission. The telephone records establish a call, not its contents."

"So I'll stay here."

"No. I'll challenge the complaint. Mr. Dunn is arranging the money for bail. You are going to leave this building, and then we're going to address the considerably larger problem." She put the photocopies flat between us. "Tell me everything you did last night. Actions first. Explanations after."

She didn't blink when I told her about the brass cat.

She didn't blink at the lie on Nell's voicemail either. She wrote *9 p.m.* in the margin and drew a box round it. Then she asked about Pryor's call,

where I had parked, which door I had used at the inn, whether anybody had seen me between ten and eleven.

"I didn't park. I walked."

"And nobody saw you?"

"Somebody called me in as a prowler."

"Somebody called in a man in a dark coat. We don't yet know what they saw."

She made me go through it again. By the second time I could see the evening the way the police would see it: a false message about going to bed, an unobserved exit, an unlocked door, a dead man who had written down my name.

I told her about Rouse. Then Mara's card. *Told T. He'll know what to do.* I said those words with my hands flat on the table, as though holding something down.

Sayer read Pryor's handwritten statement twice.

"Could you have gone to his house that evening?"

"Yes."

"Could you have said these things?"

"I don't know."

She waited.

"I could have told him Mara had proof. I could have asked him to go to the police. If I'd just been to see Rouse, that would make sense."

"And this?" Her pen touched *better for everyone if she stopped*.

"No."

"You remember not saying it?"

I looked at her.

"That's why I'm asking," she said. "I need to know which sort of no it is."

"I can't remember. But I wouldn't have wanted her stopped."

She wrote that down without improving it.

"A frightened man can record a conversation badly," she said. "A dishonest man can record it to suit himself. Either way, the writing is his account. We have to find something outside it."

"He's dead."

"The rest of the world isn't. Where were you living? Did you use a card to buy petrol? Did you have an appointment the next morning? Do not try to manufacture a memory to answer me. Find a record."

For the first time since Ouellette had slid the paper across, the room stopped tilting.

There might be nothing left after five years. But nothing left was different from what Pryor had said being true.

At six they took my fingerprints again, this time onto a form with a charge number. Sayer stood where I could see her. Nobody put the cuffs back on.

The deputy returned my shoelaces in a plastic bag. I threaded them with fingers that wouldn't work, and one came out a hole short. I couldn't bear to undo it. I left it that way.

There was a window high in the corridor. The glass was gray now. Somewhere upstairs a telephone kept ringing, stopped, started again. I imagined people arriving at work and being told what they had missed, putting mugs down, leaning over desks. By breakfast the town would have a version of the night. By lunch it would have had one all along.

Nell came down the stairs carrying my coat.

She didn't offer it to me. She looked at Sayer.

"Five minutes. With you present."

Sayer took her pad out again.

We went back into the interview room. Nell set my coat over the empty chair, where I could see the dark stain from Gannet Road's grass at the hem.

"I'm not asking about last night," she said. "Your lawyer has told me not to. I'm telling you what happens next. The death is being treated as suspicious. Augusta hasn't called it suicide."

"The pills—"

"Tell us what was on the desk. They don't tell us how it got there. We haven't got the toxicology. We haven't established which tablets were in the bottle before it was emptied."

She spoke carefully, each sentence smaller than what I wanted it to mean.

"The typed note goes to documents. So does the handwritten one. We have his ordinary handwriting from county records. A match would mean he wrote it. It wouldn't establish that the account is true."

"Can they tell when he wrote it?"

"Not give us a date off a photocopy. Maybe not off the original. Don't start expecting that."

"It says five years ago."

"Yes. It wasn't written on the fifth. Whatever he remembered, or wanted somebody to think he remembered, he put it on paper later."

I had read the page three times in the night. Each time I had imagined Pryor writing it with my footsteps still outside his door.

Nell watched me realize it.

"It could still be an accurate account," she said. "I won't pretend otherwise. But we need to know why he wrote it now, and why a man who called to offer you information left something saying you already knew."

Sayer made a note.

"And the prowler call?" she asked.

"We're preserving the dispatch recording. Caller didn't give a name. They said they were passing in a car. We're checking what can be checked."

"Time?"

"Eleven sixteen."

Six minutes after I arrived. Somewhere near the house there had been a person with a telephone, waiting long enough to be sure I went in.

Or a passing driver had seen a man at a lit doorway. That was possible too. I hated that it was possible.

Nell put a clear property bag on the table. My wallet, my phone, the cutter key.

"Your lawyer and I will arrange access to the calls and messages," she said. "Keep everything. Don't delete anything."

Then she looked at me instead of Sayer.

"Is there something you can tell me that will help keep the next person alive?"

Sayer's pen stopped.

I could have waited. I could have had my lawyer explain which questions I ought to answer, while Nell carried my coat back into the corridor and Hollis stood somewhere upstairs with a receipt for my freedom.

"I told Hollis about Quill," I said.

Nell didn't move.

"His appointment. Eleven on Thursday. I told him Wednesday night. I showed him Mara's letter. I told him about the unit and the missing box and the ledger."

Sayer looked at me once, then wrote.

"All of it?" Nell asked.

"Not Cora's recording. Not the boat she saw."

"You told him about Tarbell coming to see me too."

"Monday night. At supper."

The ventilation made a dry rattle over our heads. Nell waited until it stopped.

"And Pryor?"

"I told nobody. I mean it this time. Hollis texted asking me to come over. I didn't answer. I went to the inn."

"We'll need that text."

"It's there."

"Why did you tell me nobody knew about Quill?"

I put my hand on the edge of the table. The pale place between finger and thumb stung.

"Because you would ask me about Hollis."

"Yes," she said. "I would."

Sayer closed her pad halfway, then opened it again. She was giving me time to stop.

"He's kept me alive," I said. "For five years. He's the person I call when I don't know what to do."

"I know."

"That isn't evidence against him."

"It isn't evidence for him either."

She said it without cruelty. I wished she'd been cruel. I could have argued with that.

Hollis was at the top of the stairs.

He sat in a molded plastic chair beside a drinks machine, his gray coat folded over his knees, holding a paper cup between both hands. On the chair next to him was a brown bag. He stood when he saw me, slowly, the way he always stood when he'd been sitting too long.

"There you are," he said.

I stopped on the last step.

He set the cup down and came to me. He rested a hand on my shoulder, not a hug, just its weight, and I discovered I was shaking. I hadn't been shaking in the cell. I hadn't shaken with Sayer or Nell. It began under his hand, and I couldn't make it stop.

"Easy," he said. "You've been up all night."

He took the brown bag off the chair. There was a bacon roll in it, still warm, wrapped in white paper.

"You used to say these were the only things in town the seagulls wouldn't steal."

I didn't remember saying it. It sounded like me.

Behind us, Ouellette came through a door with a folder under his arm. Hollis turned without taking his hand off my shoulder.

"I've given Mrs. Sayer the number for my solicitor," he said. "Anything else you need goes through her. Theo will be at the Anchor, where you know perfectly well how to find him."

"Mr. Dunn, we're conducting—"

"A man called you because he'd found somebody dead. I'd like the next man to feel able to do the same."

Ouellette's mouth narrowed. Sayer took a step toward him, and they went aside to discuss something with no raised voices. Nell stood by the stairs and watched me holding the bag.

Bail had been posted. There were conditions on a sheet I had to sign: an address, a return date, instructions about witnesses. Sayer went through them with me. Hollis stayed at the other end of the counter. He didn't crowd the pen.

"I'll repay you," I said afterward.

"Eat the roll first."

"The lawyer. The bail."

"I heard you."

He picked up his coat. I saw the cup he had left beside the machine. Water. He'd waited for me for hours without making a ceremony of it.

That seemed a reason to trust him. I was still looking for those.

Sayer left us outside the Anchor at half past eight.

She would stay in Camden, she said. I was to call her before answering police questions. She gave me two cards and put one into my wallet herself.

Hollis carried my coat upstairs. The night clerk's replacement looked up from behind the desk, then down again too quickly. A radio in the breakfast room was giving a weather forecast. More wind from the northeast. Another system following the first.

In room 6 Hollis opened the curtains. The window faced a wall with a drainpipe on it. There wasn't much morning to let in.

He filled the kettle at the sink.

"No," I said.

He turned.

"No tea. Please."

"Coffee?"

"Nothing."

He set the kettle back on its base without switching it on.

I sat on the bed. He took the chair beside the little desk, and for a moment it was a room like any of the rooms he'd found me in five years ago: me on a bed, him between me and the door, something warm cooling in a bag.

"Ellen tells me they have a statement," he said. "From Pryor."

"She told you?"

"Only that there's a statement. I asked why they were keeping you. She said she couldn't discuss the rest."

I rubbed my wrists. There was nothing on them now, not even a red mark.

"He says I went to see him the fifth of October. That evening."

Hollis sat very still.

"And did you?"

"I don't know. Rouse says I was in his office at four. I don't remember that either."

"Hal?"

"I asked him how to report fraud. Mara had found it. I was trying to help her."

"Then that's something you know."

"It's something he's told me."

He nodded. He accepted the correction. It made me want to take it back.

"Were you with me that night?" I asked.

His eyes went to the window, then back.

"The fifth? I can't tell you without looking. Five years is a long time. I was still working then. Some nights Portland, some here."

"Would you look? Diaries. Expenses. Anything."

"Of course."

"I need somewhere I was."

"I know."

He leaned forward, his forearms on his knees. The sleeve pulled back above the blue anchor on his wrist.

"Has anything come back? A bit of a conversation? Anything you didn't remember before?"

A kettle. A smell. His voice saying my name in a kitchen that might have been any kitchen we'd shared.

"No," I said.

It was the first lie I'd told him that morning. It was so much easier than the truth I'd told Nell that I was ashamed of the relief.

"Don't force it," he said. "Remember what they told you at the hospital. You fill a hole by guessing, you can end up believing the guess. Let Ellen find the paper."

He put his hand on my knee and stood.

"Sleep. I'll be home. You know the number."

At the door he paused.

"Did Pryor say what you threatened him with?"

I looked up.

"I didn't say threatened."

"No. I'm sorry. Ellen said the statement was being used against you. I assumed—" He shook his head. "Let me read it before I say any more. If you want me to."

I could have given it to him. I had a copy in my coat. All I had to do was reach.

"I'll ask her," I said.

"Good. That's what she's for."

He pulled the door shut. His footsteps went along the carpet, stopped at the stairs, continued down.

I got up and put the chain on.

I didn't sleep.

At nine twelve I switched my phone on. The battery had seventeen percent left. A row of messages arrived, most from numbers I knew professionally, men who had heard something and wanted to know whether the hearing was right. One from Gus: *Office secure. Call when you can.*

One from Cora, sent at eight forty-six.

Voss has something of Dad's. We need you here. Don't tell anyone yet.

I looked at the last five words for a long time.

Then I rang Nell. I told her where I was going and who would be there. She told me not to touch anything Voss wanted to show me. I said I wouldn't. Sayer answered on her second ring and said she would meet me outside Cora's house.

Only then did I call Cora.

She picked up without saying hello.

"Are you alone?"

"Yes. But I've told Castellano. And my lawyer's coming."

A sharp breath. For a moment I thought she would hang up.

"All right," she said. "All right. Just come."

"What has Voss found?"

"A letter. Dad left it with somebody in case he didn't get to speak to you. They saw the news this morning."

I stood beside the bed with one shoe still laced wrong, looking at the empty chair.

"When did he leave it?"

"The afternoon before he died."

"Cora. What does it say?"

She started to answer, stopped, and I heard paper move against the phone.

"The first line is your name," she said. "Then: 'I knew what they were going to do to Mara. I let them.'"

Chapter 15: What He Owed

I put the phone on its charger and stood beside it until there was enough battery to leave.

Six minutes. I watched the little green bar grow and thought about Alan Farrow deciding which pen to use. Sitting at a desk, addressing an envelope to me, setting down the fact that he had known my wife was going to die.

He had lived another five years after knowing it.

I had spent those years learning to sleep in the middle of a bed.

At the bottom of the stairs the clerk asked whether I wanted breakfast. I was still carrying Hollis's brown paper bag. The bacon grease had made a dark circle in one corner.

"I've had it," I said.

Outside, the wind pushed me sideways against the inn's wall. The rain had stopped, but water came down from the gutters every time a gust shook them. I took the long way to Sparrow Lane, through streets

where there were people. A delivery man rolled a handcart down a ramp. Two women waited for the pharmacy to open. I wanted witnesses to the ordinary fact of me walking somewhere.

Sayer was beside her car when I reached Cora's house. She wore the same suit with a raincoat over it. Her hair was damp at the temples.

"I checked your conditions," she said. "You can meet them. If anything turns into an accusation about last night, we stop."

"This is about my wife."

"I know. That's why I wanted to be here."

She looked at the bag in my hand.

"Have you eaten that?"

"No."

"Then bring it in."

Voss opened the door before we knocked. He had his hat in his hand and his coat on, as though he had never quite committed to staying. Beyond him Cora stood beside the kitchen table. There were four chairs, three cups of coffee and a transparent folder with a cream-colored envelope inside it.

She looked at Sayer.

"She's my lawyer," I said.

"Ellen Sayer. I'm here for Mr. Brandt."

Cora nodded. Her eyes came back to me and stayed there.

"I didn't know," she said.

"I haven't read it yet."

"I know. I need you to know that first."

Voss drew out a chair without scraping it. "Castellano's coming. She said fifteen minutes. The original stays where it is. I photographed it when we opened it."

He put a printout at the empty place. Then another, the envelope front and back. Ordinary paper for me to hold. The thing Alan had touched lay under plastic a foot away.

I sat down.

Theodore Brandt, the envelope said. No street. No stamp. Under my name, in smaller writing: *To be given to him personally*.

Voss waited until I'd looked at both sides.

"Mrs. Aldous," he said. "She left a message at my office at seven this morning. Her nephew drove it down from Camden."

"She found Alan."

"Yes. She'd been looking after him twenty-three years. She went to her sister's after the funeral. I've been trying to speak with her since Monday. This

morning she saw your name in the news.”

“Why didn’t she give it to the police?”

“Ask her. Nell will. What she told me was that he made her promise to put it into your hands, nobody else’s. She thought you’d come to the house. He’d told her you might.”

“A week.”

Voss nodded once. He didn’t offer a better explanation.

On the printout of the envelope there was a second hand, rounder than Alan’s, at the lower left.

Given to me Thursday, 8 October, after lunch. M.A.

“She wrote that this morning,” Voss said. “Not the eighth. I asked.”

I had been about to believe it was a dated receipt. I looked up at him.

“And she opened it?”

“No. We did. Cora recognized his hand. That isn’t an examination. It’s just what we have.”

Cora pulled out the chair opposite mine. She didn’t sit in it. She held its back with both hands.

I put down the envelope photographs and picked up the letter.

Theo,

I knew what they were going to do to Mara. I let them.

She came here and asked me to tell the truth about Lydia. I told her she had misunderstood. She hadn't. I knew she wasn't safe after that visit. I could have warned her. I could have warned you. Instead I waited for her to stop asking, and when she died I let them call it an accident.

I have told myself that knowing isn't the same as doing. It is what has allowed me to get up in the morning. I can't make it do that any more.

I need to tell you about Lydia first. What I agreed to and what I paid. Then I need to tell you what happened after your wife came here. I won't put a name into a letter Mrs. Aldous has to carry. She knows nothing about any of this. If I get the courage to say it, I mean to say it sitting opposite you.

Please come to the house. Ask Cora to arrange it if you won't take a call from me. There is money for her now which I should have spent keeping her mother alive. It does not settle anything. I understand that.

If you take this to the police, I have no right to object. I am asking for the chance to tell you myself before I tell them.

Alan Farrow

8 October

There was a space between the last sentence and the signature. He had left himself room to say something else.

I read it again, looking for the misunderstanding. A qualification. Something that would turn *knew* into *suspected*, something I could argue with while I caught my breath.

There wasn't one.

Behind me a pipe knocked in the wall. Upstairs, somebody crossed a room. The kitchen clock made a little scraping sound each time its second hand passed the twelve.

Mara had come home from that house. She had put her keys somewhere. Perhaps she had asked what I wanted for dinner. For five years I had searched the days before her death for things I might have done differently. Alan had known what he ought to do while she was still alive.

"What happened after she came?" I asked.

Cora shook her head.

"Did he tell you?"

"No."

I heard how short the word was. I wanted her to make it longer. I wanted something to get hold of.

Sayer pushed the brown bag into my line of sight.

"Put the page down a moment."

"I don't want food."

"Then put your hands on the table."

I did. I had folded the printout across Alan's signature without knowing it.

Cora sat.

"You can hate him," she said. "I won't ask you not to."

"I don't need your permission."

She looked down. Voss moved his hat from one hand to the other.

It was an ugly thing to have said to her, and it had come out with no effort at all.

"You didn't write it," I said.

"No."

"I know."

She brought her eyes up again. We sat across from each other with Alan's letter between us. Her father had killed her mother. My reports had helped him stay her father.

Nell came through the door at ten past ten, carrying an evidence bag and a small notebook. She looked at my hands before she looked at the letter.

"Copies," Voss said. "Original hasn't been handled since we put it in the folder."

She asked him to take her through the morning. He gave her the times, his office message, the nephew's arrival, the opening. She wrote down who had touched what. Then she photographed the letter where it lay and put the folder and envelope into the bag together.

"Mrs. Aldous needs to keep the phone she used," she said. "I'll speak to her today. And the nephew. I need both numbers."

Voss gave them to her.

"Is it enough?" Cora asked.

Nell looked at her. "Enough for what?"

"To stop saying my father fell."

"We aren't saying that."

"Enough to believe him, then."

"I believe he wanted to tell Mr. Brandt something. This helps establish what. We'll check the writing and what Mrs. Aldous says. Then we'll see what we can support outside the letter."

"He wrote that he knew," I said.

"Yes."

"Don't turn that into nothing."

Nell closed her notebook, leaving a finger between the pages.

"I won't. And I won't turn it into something it can't prove. He's dead, Theo. He doesn't get to answer a question. We have to find people who can."

Cora took a phone from her cardigan pocket and set it on the table.

"He rang me on the eighth," she said. "I told you that. I didn't tell you all of it."

Nell's finger came out of the notebook.

"Why?"

"Because I thought he was trying to get me back."

The call was on Cora's log: Thursday, 8 October, 4:36 p.m., incoming, eleven minutes.

"I didn't record it," she said. "This only shows the call."

Nell nodded. "Tell me what you remember. Use his words where you're sure of them."

"He asked whether I could come home. I told him I had work. He said it mattered. I said it had mattered in June, when I asked him to speak to Barrett and he told me to get off his property."

Voss's eyes stayed on the floor.

"Then he said he'd tell me everything. About Mum. He'd said it in the voicemail, but I hadn't believed it properly. I thought he'd say he'd had an affair, or he'd

been drunk, or he'd taken her out when the weather was bad. Something he could confess to and still be a person I could stand to see."

She put her thumb against the side of her phone. The screen went dark.

"I asked him if she was murdered."

The kitchen held still around her.

"He said yes."

"Did he say by whom?" Nell asked.

"I asked. He said he couldn't do it on the telephone. He wanted me to come."

"Did he say that he killed her?"

"He said, 'I'm responsible.' Then he said he had to speak to Mr. Brandt. He wanted me to arrange it. He thought you wouldn't see him if he called you himself."

I looked at the salutation on the printout. *Theo*. A man's first name, doing work that five years of silence could not.

"What else?" Nell asked.

Cora looked at me instead of her.

"He said your wife had tried to give him a way out. She said he'd have to tell what he'd done, but he could stop anything else happening. He said he sent her away. That's when he started crying."

She gripped the chair seat beneath her thighs.

"I told him to call the police. He said he would. After he'd seen me and you. He said, 'I don't want you hearing what your father is from a stranger.'"

"And you agreed to go?"

"Not then. I was angry. I'd spent four months paying someone to ask him questions, and he'd called me cruel for doing it. I said if he had something to confess he could do it without making me drive three hours to listen."

Voss finally looked up.

"You didn't make him die," he said.

Cora shook her head hard, once, as if he had touched a bruise.

"He said someone was coming that evening. He wanted to speak to them first. I asked whether it was his lawyer. He said no. I remember what he said after that exactly."

Nell opened the notebook again.

"Someone I trusted is coming for me."

I watched Nell write it down.

"Coming *for* him?"

"Those were the words. I asked what he meant. He said, 'If I can't put this right with him, I need you here.'"

"Him," Nell said.

"Yes."

"A name?"

"No. I asked again. He wouldn't give me one. He said he had to get through that conversation first."

She looked at the black phone screen as though another call might still appear on it.

"He said ten thirty. I told him I couldn't promise. Then I sat in my room for an hour, telling myself I wasn't going."

"But you did," I said.

"Yes."

She had driven through the dark to a man who said he was responsible for her mother's murder. She had crossed a road the tide was about to close and knocked on the boathouse door. I thought of her out there with the light in the loft, waiting to hear his steps.

"I said he was apologizing," she told Nell. "When you asked what the call was about. That was true. It wasn't all of it."

Nell let a moment pass.

"If you remember more, call me. Even if it seems to contradict this. Don't rehearse it together."

Cora nodded.

Voss took another folder from his coat. This one he handed to Nell.

"The policy increase," he said. "Cora authorized me to speak to the broker about her claim. There's a recording of the instruction. I've given you his number and a copy of the email confirming it."

He had the recording on his phone too. Nell asked him to play it.

Alan's voice came out thin and businesslike. A man confirming a premium, agreeing that he understood the quoted figure. A woman asked whether he wished to retain the existing beneficiary designation.

My daughter. Yes.

And you would like the accidental-death benefit increased to four point two million?

That's what I said.

Then a pause. Paper moved. Alan spoke again, less sharply.

I'm sorry. Yes, please. Four point two.

The broker thanked him. He asked when it would take effect.

Voss stopped the recording.

"The broker says he initiated it. Rang her office, asked what cover he could buy at his age. No daughter on the call. No request sent through her. You'll want the original recording from them."

"I will," Nell said.

The money had been the first thing Reyes gave me. Four point two million dollars, followed by the name of the woman who would get it. In my work that was how a person became a suspect before I met them.

"I didn't know he'd changed it," Cora said. "The solicitor told me after he died."

"You thought he was buying forgiveness," I said.

"I think he wanted to leave me something after he went to prison."

She said it without heat. It was a worse thing to have to say about a father than anything I could offer her.

Voss tapped the folder once.

"This doesn't clear her of anything by itself. But the increase wasn't her instruction. That's a fact we can get checked."

Nell put the papers beside the evidence bag.

"All right."

For the first time Cora let go of the chair.

Nell stepped into the hall to telephone Camden. Voss went with her, taking his phone and leaving his hat on the table. Sayer stayed where she could see me.

Cora stood at the sink and ran cold water into a glass. She drank half of it, then put it down so carefully I could hear the base meet the enamel.

"He said there was something worse than going to prison," she said.

"On that call?"

"Yes. I didn't understand. I asked if he meant me finding out. He said I'd been living with it since I was a child. Finding out wouldn't be the worst part."

Sayer lifted her head.

"Tell Detective Castellano that when she comes back."

"I will."

Cora turned to me.

"Did your wife know him? Before she went there?"

"Through the file, perhaps. Not socially."

"Was she afraid of him?"

I could have invented a brave Mara for her. I had done it often enough for myself: my wife going alone into offices and houses, making copies, posting letters, leaving instructions against her own death. A woman who knew exactly what she was risking.

But Mara had been afraid of ordinary things too. Skidding on black ice. Missing a call from her mother. A pain she couldn't explain. Fear hadn't kept

her from doing anything she needed to do; that didn't mean she hadn't felt it.

"I don't know," I said. "She went anyway."

Cora turned the glass a little with her fingertip.

"I want the money held," she said. "Until we know where it came from."

"It's insurance money."

"So was the money he got when Mum died."

I had no answer to that.

Before Nell left, she made Cora repeat the last part of the call. She arranged for another officer to take a fuller statement that afternoon. Voss would stay until then. Cora agreed to tell Nell where she went, and to take no private meetings with anyone who claimed to know her father.

"That includes people who say they're helping," Nell said.

She looked at me when she said it.

Outside, Sayer stopped beside her car.

"Send me what you have on the fifth," she said. "Addresses, employers, old bank details. I'll ask for the records. You need some sleep."

I looked back at the downstairs window. Voss was pulling the blind halfway down. Cora's shape moved behind him, carrying the cups.

"Pryor wrote that I wanted her stopped," I said. "Alan knew someone wanted her stopped."

"That doesn't make them independent accounts of what you did."

"It doesn't put me anywhere else either."

"No," said Sayer. "That's the work."

Nell waited at the pavement for her to finish. The wind lifted a corner of the evidence bag against her coat.

"Where are you going?" she asked.

"The inn."

"Stay there. I'll call after I've spoken to Aldous."

"Will you speak to Rouse again?"

"Yes."

"And Hollis?"

"Yes."

I nodded. I couldn't make myself say anything more about him. He had been awake all night for me, and I was sending Nell to his door.

She put the bag into her car and returned to the pavement.

"You did the right thing this morning," she said. "Keep doing it."

I walked back with the printouts inside my coat. I still had the breakfast bag. At the inn I put it into the bin beside the stairs, then took it out again and carried it up.

I ate standing by the desk. The bread was damp and the bacon cold. Hollis had gone somewhere before dawn to buy it for me. He had sat holding water outside a room where men were deciding whether I had killed somebody. Whatever I didn't know about him, those things had happened.

I set Alan's letter beside my copy of Pryor's statement.

One man asking me to hear him. Another warning the world against me. Both dead before either could explain.

I wanted to ring Hollis and tell him about the morning. I wanted his voice to take the two pages and put them in an order I could stand to look at.

Instead I photographed my old Portland address and the account details from the papers in my bag, and sent them to Sayer. Then I plugged in the phone.

It rang before I could lie down.

Hollis.

I let it sound twice. I thought of the breakfast wrapper, and his hand on my shoulder, and answered.

“Theo.” He sounded out of breath. “Have you got a minute?”

“Yes.”

“I’ve found the book. The old desk diary. There’s something here we ought to—”

He stopped. Away from the telephone I heard a knock, three quick blows.

“Hang on,” he said. “Someone at the door.”

I waited. A chair moved. He set the phone down on a hard surface without ending the call.

His steps went away. A latch lifted.

“Yes?” he said, farther off.

Then a sound that wasn’t a word. Something heavy struck the floor.

“Hollis?”

There was a scraping noise, and a breath close to the receiver. I had already pulled the charger loose.

“Hollis. Can you hear me?”

The man who had held me through five years of nights tried to say my name.

He couldn’t finish it.

Chapter 16: Stay With Me

I said his name again. The breathing stopped long enough for me to think the line had gone dead. Then it came back, wet and shallow.

The door to my room stood open. I didn't remember taking the chain off.

I stopped on the landing and put his call on hold. My thumb missed the nine the first time.

The dispatcher asked for the address of the emergency.

"Quarry Lane. Hollis Dunn's cottage. Port Carrow. I don't know the number. He's on the telephone. Something's happened to him."

"Are you at the property?"

"At the Anchor Inn. He called me. Someone knocked. He opened the door. I heard him fall."

"Did you hear anyone else?"

"No."

She asked whether he was breathing. I told her what I had heard, and she asked for my number, then his. For a moment I couldn't find it. I knew the number well enough to dial in the dark. On the screen, among the other numbers, it looked unfamiliar.

"We've located the address," she said. "Police and medical help are going. Stay where you are. Do not enter the house."

I gave her Nell's name. She said she'd pass it on.

When I returned to Hollis's call, I heard something dragging across the floor.

"They're coming," I said. "Hollis. Help's coming."

No answer.

I listened for another voice. Feet. A door. There was only his breath and, farther away, the small hard tick of his hall clock.

Nell rang while I was listening.

"I'm coming to the inn," she said. "Wait outside."

"He can't speak."

"I've spoken to dispatch. Go downstairs."

I left my room open. At the bottom of the stairs the clerk asked whether I needed a taxi.

"An ambulance," I said, and saw her reach for the desk phone.

"They've called it. Not here."

I couldn't finish explaining. I went out into the wind.

Nell's car stopped with the passenger door level with me. She reached across and opened it before I could get my hand under the handle.

I got in holding the phone against my ear.

"Still connected?"

I nodded.

"Put it on speaker."

For four seconds we drove with the sound of Hollis trying to breathe between us. Then Nell picked up her radio and told someone the call was still open. He was alive.

Alive. It was the first time anybody had said it.

A woman pushing a pram stopped at the curb while we passed. I wanted her to keep walking. I wanted all the ordinary things in Port Carrow to continue until we had him somewhere safe.

"What did he say before the knock?" Nell asked.

"He'd found his old diary. The one I asked him to look for. He said there was something we ought to— Then he stopped."

"Did he say what?"

"No."

She took the turn onto Quarry Lane without looking at me.

“Did you hear a conversation at the door?”

“He said yes. As a question. Nothing after that.”

The cottage appeared between the trees. A police car stood across the gravel entrance, lights turning against the wet trunks. Beyond it, the front door was open.

I reached for the handle before Nell had stopped.

She caught my sleeve.

“Wait.”

Officer Dill came out onto the step. He spoke into his shoulder radio, then looked toward us and held up an open hand.

The same officer who had put cuffs on me at Pryor’s house. I knew his face before I knew what his gesture meant.

He lowered his hand and waved the ambulance in.

Nell released my sleeve.

“Behind me.”

Hollis lay in the hall with one sock caught under his heel.

That was the first thing I saw. The sock was navy, worn white at the ball of the foot. He had come downstairs at the inn that morning with his shoes polished. Now one foot was bare, and the other pointed toward the open door at an angle that looked wrong until he moved it.

His head rested beside the telephone table. The receiver lay close to his mouth, its cord stretched across his shoulder. Blood had gone into his white hair and spread onto the floor beneath it.

A volunteer in a green jacket knelt beside him, holding a dressing against his head. She looked up at the ambulance crew.

"He's answering. Confused. No one else here."

Dill stood at the study doorway. Another officer came through from the back of the house.

I stayed against the wall while the paramedics put their bags down. There was barely room for them and Nell. I could see Hollis's chest moving beneath his cardigan, quicker than it should have.

"Hollis," I said.

His eyes shifted toward me.

"Theo."

It came out clearly this time. The relief was so sharp I had to put my hand against the wall.

"I'm here."

He tried to raise his head. The woman holding the dressing told him to stay still.

"Don't get up," I said. "You don't have to do anything."

He looked at my hand on the wallpaper. Then at my face. He seemed to be working out why I was there.

A paramedic asked him his name. He gave it. Asked where he was, he said home. Asked what had happened, he closed his eyes.

"The door," he said.

"Did you fall?"

"Someone."

His right hand moved across the floor. I crouched where there was space and let him find mine.

His fingers were cold, but his grip was strong enough to hurt.

I had held this hand outside meeting rooms, in hospital car parks, at the breakwater on the anniversary of Mara's death. Hollis always knew when to let go. This time he held on while they cut his cardigan open.

There was a bruise high on his chest. Blood had soaked the collar of his shirt. He looked down at the scissors.

"Good cardigan," he said.

Nobody laughed. I wanted to. I wanted that small complaint to make him himself again.

"I'll buy you one."

His eyes came back to mine.

"You called them?"

"Yes."

He shut his eyes and kept hold of my hand.

They asked me to move while they got the stretcher into the hall.

I backed into the study doorway. Dill stepped aside but stayed close enough to stop me going farther.

Hollis had been looking through boxes. Two stood open beside the desk, and a third had been pulled halfway from a shelf. Paper folders were stacked on the visitor's chair. The quilted cover was still over the typewriter.

There was a black diary on the blotter. Closed. Its year was stamped in faded gold on the spine.

The year Mara died.

I looked at it long enough for Dill to notice.

"That?" he asked.

"He told me he'd found an old desk diary. That's why he rang. I asked him to check something."

Nell turned from the stretcher.

"Don't touch it."

"I wasn't going to."

I said it too quickly. Dill glanced at my hands.

From where I stood I could see the lamp on the desk, the window above it, the carpet worn thin under the chair. Nothing looked disturbed in the way my office had been disturbed. The boxes might have been there for an hour or a week. I had never paid enough attention to what belonged where in Hollis's house. I came here and waited for him to tell me where to sit.

Nell asked Dill to photograph the room as it was.

In the hall, a paramedic was telling Hollis they would take him across to the hospital. Hollis tried to look past her.

"Theo?"

I went back to the doorway.

"I'm coming."

"The book."

"We can get it later."

He moved his head a fraction, trying to shake it. The paramedic steadied him.

"Mr. Dunn," Nell said, "is that the black diary on your desk?"

His eyes opened.

"Yes."

“May we take it for safekeeping?”

“Take it.”

She told Dill to photograph it where it lay first and put it in a separate bag. I watched him go into the study. He didn’t open the cover.

They lifted Hollis. His hand searched beside the stretcher, and I caught it for the few steps to the front door.

Outside, two neighbors stood at the edge of the lane. One had come out with a dish towel in her hands. She watched us pass as though we were taking away someone who had been there all her life.

At the ambulance, Hollis let go.

A little blood had dried in the creases of my fingers.

Nell followed the ambulance toward the causeway.

I kept watching its rear windows. Once it slowed, and my body went forward against the seat belt before our car had even begun to brake.

“They’re taking the bend,” Nell said.

I nodded as though I had understood that already.

The tide was out. Brown weed lay flat on either side of the causeway, and the yellow gauge post rose above the water. The place where Quill’s Volvo had

stood was empty. Traffic passed it without slowing.

Yesterday I had watched men get ready to open his car. This morning I had watched Hollis eat nothing while he waited for me to be released. I couldn't keep the days separate any more. Everything seemed to have happened in the same stretch of bad light.

"Did they find somebody?" I asked.

"No."

"Did anyone see a car?"

"They're asking."

"He wouldn't have opened the door if he thought —"

I stopped. Hollis opened his door to anyone. Lost delivery drivers. Children selling raffle tickets. People who needed to borrow a pump or wanted to know whether a rope was safe. I had once watched him spend forty minutes helping a stranger decide which tide to launch a dinghy on.

Nell kept her eyes on the ambulance.

"Tell me the call again. From when you answered."

I told her. When I reached the knock, she asked whether I was sure it was three blows.

"Yes."

"Any name? Did he sound pleased? Surprised?"

"Just yes."

"And the sound afterward?"

"I don't know. Something hitting the floor. Maybe him. Maybe something he knocked over."

She nodded once.

"We'll write that down while it's fresh. After they've seen him."

"You were going to question him."

"I still need to speak to him."

"About Tarbell and Quill."

"Yes."

I looked through the windscreen at the ambulance.

"Now somebody's done this to him."

Nell's hands stayed in the same place on the wheel.

"Let the doctors help him first."

I wanted more than that. I wanted her to withdraw what she'd said in the interview room. I wanted the blood on my hands to settle every question I'd made myself ask about Hollis.

She didn't offer it. I pressed my palms together and watched the road.

At the hospital they took him through doors I couldn't follow.

Nell gave my name to a nurse and told her I had been on the telephone when it happened. Then she went aside to speak to the ambulance crew.

The nurse asked whether I was family.

"No."

It hurt to say it.

"Does he have someone we should call?"

"His wife died. No children. There's a niece in New Hampshire. I don't have her number."

"We can ask him when he's ready."

She showed me where to wash my hands.

The blood came off pink, then clear. I kept the tap running after it was gone. In the mirror I looked like a man who had been awake for two nights, which I nearly had. One end of my shoelace hung lower than the other. I bent to fix it and couldn't remember how I'd threaded it wrong.

Back in the waiting area, Nell had found a quiet corner. She sat beside me and opened her notebook.

I went through the call a third time. She asked me to describe the breathing without imitating it, and the impact without deciding what had made it. Then she asked what I had told Hollis about the diary that morning.

"I asked him where I was on the fifth. If he had records. He said he'd look."

"Did he tell you he'd found anything before today?"

"No."

"And you didn't tell him what was in Alan's letter?"

"I didn't call him after we left Cora's. He rang me."

She wrote that down.

"Did you record his call?"

"No."

"We'll need the phone again. Just to preserve what we can. You can keep it with you for now."

I put it on the chair between us. The call had finally ended at the cottage when Dill lifted the receiver. Its duration was still there, all the minutes in which Hollis had been on the floor.

"Who knows about him?" I asked.

"I'll tell Sayer. I'll let Cora and Voss know enough to keep them careful."

"Voss was staying with her."

"He still is. An officer is going there for her statement."

"Ask him to stay after."

"I will."

She closed the notebook and stood.

"There's an officer coming here. No visitors until we know who they are."

"Including me?"

"I know who you are."

She said it tiredly. For once I didn't try to work out what she meant.

I had been sitting there nearly an hour when Sayer rang.

"Castellano told me," she said. "How is he?"

"They haven't said."

"And you?"

"Here."

She let that answer stand.

"You've given them an account of the call?"

"Yes."

"Good. Don't turn it into an account of anything you didn't hear."

"I know."

"I think you do. I also think you're tired enough to agree with anyone who offers you an explanation."

Across the waiting area, a man had fallen asleep with a folded coat behind his head. A little girl stood between his knees, carefully peeling the paper from a drinking straw. I watched her lay the unbroken strip across his wrist.

"He found the diary," I said.

"Have you seen it?"

"Closed. On his desk. The police took it with his permission."

"Then we'll ask about it when they can speak to him."

"It might put me somewhere. That evening."

"It might."

She wouldn't make it a promise. I was beginning to hear how much effort that cost people.

"Ellen. He paid you."

"Yes."

"If he can't—"

"I'm still your lawyer. Get some water. Call me when you know how he is."

After she hung up, I went to the machine and bought a bottle. I opened it but couldn't swallow more than a mouthful.

The doors opened. A nurse came out and called my name.

Hollis had stitches under a dressing at his hairline. His left eye was swelling, and there was a narrow strip of dried blood behind his ear. They had put him in a hospital gown. Without the cardigan and his careful collar, his shoulders looked smaller.

The nurse told me he was being kept for observation. He was awake, she said, but he needed rest. A police officer sat beyond the curtain, facing the entrance to the room.

Nell stood at the foot of the bed.

Hollis saw me and lifted one hand off the sheet.

"There he is."

I took the chair beside him. He looked at my coat, then my shoes, as though checking whether I'd brought everything.

"You look worse than I feel," he said.

"You haven't looked in a mirror."

He smiled with one side of his mouth.

Nell asked whether he felt able to answer a few questions. He said he'd try.

"Do you remember opening your front door?"

"Yes."

"Who was there?"

His gaze moved to the curtain.

"I don't know."

"A man? A woman?"

He rubbed his thumb against the sheet.

"I think a man."

"Did he say anything?"

"Might have. It's gone."

Nell waited. Hollis looked at me.

"I was talking to you."

"Yes."

"Then the door."

"Yes."

"Didn't get very far, did I?"

His hand went toward his head. I stopped it before his fingers reached the dressing, and he left his hand in mine.

"We're here," I said.

Nell asked whether anything was missing from the house. Hollis said he couldn't know. She told him about the diary, that it had been secured unopened and they would speak to him about it when he was rested.

"All right," he said.

"Is there anyone you're afraid of, Mr. Dunn? Anyone who's threatened you?"

He turned his head toward her. The movement made him wince.

"Should have been more careful."

"About what?"

He shut his eyes.

The nurse came through the curtain and looked at Nell. Nell put her notebook away.

"We'll stop there. If something comes back, tell the officer. Don't try to force it."

Hollis nodded without opening his eyes.

At the curtain Nell paused beside me.

"I'll be outside."

For a while we listened to the cart moving along the corridor.

Hollis's breathing had become ordinary again. I kept watching the hollow above his collarbone, the small lift and fall. Each time he took a breath, I stopped holding mine.

"You don't have to sit," he said.

"I know."

"Go and sleep."

"In a bit."

His eyes opened.

"You used to do that. Say in a bit."

"I probably still do."

"At the hospital. First time. Couldn't get you to leave her room."

I looked at the sheet beneath our hands.

I didn't remember Mara's room. I remembered a corridor, a trooper's boots, someone asking whether there was a person they could telephone. For years I had thought there was nothing before that except

drink. Hollis had told me little things when I could bear them, giving me back a day in pieces: I'd sat, I'd slept, I'd let him drive.

Now I was in his room, waiting for him to remember.

"Don't talk," I said. "Just rest."

He closed his eyes. His grip loosened. I stayed because there was no one else to stay, and because an hour earlier I had heard him trying to say my name.

When his fingers moved again, I thought he was asleep.

"Theo."

I leaned toward him.

"Gray," he whispered.

I looked at the curtain. Nell was beyond it, speaking quietly to the officer.

"What was gray?"

Hollis's eyes opened. They stayed on the doorway.

"In the door. A shape."

"His coat?"

His fingers tightened around mine.

"Couldn't see. Here."

He lifted his free hand toward his mouth, then let it fall.

I reached for the call button. His grip held me.

“And the voice,” he said.

I bent close enough to hear his breath.

“What about it?”

“He said my name.”

His eyes came to mine, clear for a moment and frightened.

“Could hardly hear him. He was standing right in front of me. And I could hardly hear him at all.”

Chapter 17: The Quiet Voice

I told Nell in the corridor, before the curtain had finished swinging shut behind me.

“Gray. He said gray. A shape in the door. And the man who came spoke so quietly Hollis could hardly hear him, standing face to face.”

She didn’t take out her notebook. She looked at the officer on the plastic chair, then at the door of Hollis’s room, then at me.

“Those words?”

““Could hardly hear him at all.””

“Did you ask him anything?”

“I asked if it was a coat. He said he couldn’t see. Then he put his hand up to his mouth.”

“His mouth.”

“Like this.”

I showed her. The back of my fingers, held a little way from my lips. It looked like a man hushing a child.

Nell stood very still. I had watched her do it at the boathouse and in the Texaco lot, the way she held a thought until it stopped moving.

"Hal Rouse whispers," she said.

"Since the surgery."

"He wears a cardigan."

"Navy."

"In a doorway with the light behind him, navy is gray." She took out her phone. "I'm not saying it's him. I'm saying I'd have to be an idiot not to knock."

"He told Quill's secretary he was in all week."

"Then it won't take long."

She walked off down the corridor, already speaking. I heard *Congress Street* and *Ruiz* and *this afternoon*. I stood by Hollis's door with the gesture still in my hand.

I should have felt something close to gratitude. A man in a gray coat, a voice you had to lean toward. Someone who frightened Hal Rouse into silence for five years and had finally decided to do something else. It fit the shape I'd drawn at the Atlantic building, the terrified man on the fourth floor who had looked away.

It fitted so well I could have built it myself.

I went back in. Hollis had turned his face to the window and the dressing caught the light. I couldn't tell whether he was asleep.

"Told her," I whispered.

His fingers moved on the sheet. Nothing else.

Nell was away forty minutes. When she came back her coat was wet at the shoulders and she had a paper cup in each hand.

She gave me one. It was tea. I held it without drinking.

"Rouse left his office at eleven forty this morning," she said. "Jean Keene says he took a call, put his cardigan on over his arm instead of his shoulders, and told her he'd be back after lunch. He hasn't come back. His car isn't in the garage. His wife's in Florida with her sister; she hasn't spoken to him since Wednesday."

"Eleven forty."

"Hollis rang you at what time?"

"Twenty past one. About."

"Which gives him enough time to get to Port Carrow, if he drove straight." She looked at her cup. "It also gives him a lot of time to be somewhere else."

"The guard at the Atlantic building?"

"Saw him go. Didn't see him come back. Ruiz is at the Falmouth house. Nobody home, two newspapers on the step."

"Two."

"Yes. I noticed that too."

"Reyes?" I said.

"Reyes is supposed to be in a meeting in Boston until six, according to his assistant. She read me his calendar. I'll verify it." She drank some of the tea and grimaced. "It's very bad tea."

I looked at mine and put it on the floor.

"This doesn't clear anybody," Nell said. "Hal ran. That could be guilt. It could be fear. A man whose name Alan Farrow wouldn't write down and whom a dead lawyer went to see forty minutes before he drove his car into a tidal flat is entitled to be frightened."

"You think he's frightened."

"I think everybody in this case is frightened except you, and I'd like to know why."

I didn't tell her I was. I'd stopped feeling it somewhere around the stretcher. What remained was a hum in my forearms, like the first week without a drink.

She sat beside me for a while without speaking. Down the corridor a man was mopping the same square of floor.

"The diary," I said.

"Evidence room in Rockland. Sealed. Dill will carry it to Augusta himself. Sayer's asked to be present when it's opened. I told her yes."

"Hollis said I could—"

"Hollis said take it for safekeeping. Nobody's opening it without his lawyer or yours. That includes me."

For the first time that day I almost smiled. Even her rules had rules.

At twenty to four Cora called my phone.

She sounded flat and tired and not quite herself, as though somebody had taken her statement and kept something. I stepped into the stairwell to hear.

"They've finished. Detective Pelletier. He was kind." A breath. "Barrett's gone."

"Gone where?"

"He said he was going to buy a sandwich. He's been gone an hour and a half. He took the car. I rang and it went to voicemail."

I put my back against the cold wall.

“Did he say anything else?”

“He asked me what Rouse looked like. I told him I’d never seen him. He said, fine, I’ll go find out.” She stopped. “That’s a stupid thing for me to say. I didn’t take it seriously. He’s always saying things like that.”

“Did he say where?”

“Something about a camp. Rouse has a camp. Mrs. Keene told him. In Friendship.” Her voice cracked on the last word. “Theo, he’s fifty-six and he has a bad knee.”

“I’ll tell Nell.”

“Tell her *now*.”

I went through the door at a run. It was a stupid way to move through a hospital and a nurse called after me. Nell was standing at the nurses’ station with a clipboard I hadn’t seen her pick up.

I said *Friendship*, and *camp*, and *Voss*. She was already dialing.

“Rouse has a camp on Muscongus Bay,” she said, when she had spoken to someone and put the phone against her shoulder. “Bought it in the nineties. Keene told Voss at ten this morning. That’s the first I’ve heard of it.”

“He rang her before he rang anyone.”

“He rang her because she’s the one person who’d talk to him.” She was putting her coat on while she said it, shifting her phone from hand to hand. “Ouellette’s three minutes from Route 1. Stay with Hollis.”

“Nell.”

“Stay with Hollis. I mean it. If someone’s coming to finish a job, that’s where he’ll come.”

I stayed. I stood in the corridor with my hands against the wall and watched her go.

The call came at ten past six.

It wasn’t Nell. It was Ouellette, with the wind in his phone. The detective who had held me at two in the morning told me, in flat sentences, that Barrett Voss had been found on the camp road off Route 220 by a man walking a dog, lying in the weeds beside his car. He had been shot twice. Once through the thigh and once in the left side, under the arm. He was conscious when they put him in the ambulance.

“He asked for you,” Ouellette said.

“Where is he?”

“Coming here. Same hospital. Detective Castellano’s with the car.”

“Is he going to live?”

He didn't answer quickly enough.

They brought him in through the emergency doors at twenty to seven. I watched from the end of the corridor, where a security man held out his arm for me. I saw a gurney, a paramedic walking beside it with a bag held high, and a tweed sleeve trailing off the edge, brown and soaked black.

His hat was on the gurney. Someone had put it on his stomach, upside down, like a bowl.

Cora arrived with an officer fifteen minutes after that. She came through the doors without a coat. She didn't ask me anything. She sat on the chair next to mine, put her hands under her thighs, and looked at the floor.

"I told him to go," she said after a while. "I said, 'Fine, go.'"

"You didn't."

"I thought it."

I said nothing. I'd thought it too. I had asked Nell to ask him to stay with her.

At seven-thirty Nell came back.

She had been at the camp road for an hour. She had mud on her boots up to the ankle and she wasn't wearing her rain jacket. She told me this standing up,

in a quiet voice that wasn't kind and wasn't cruel.

Voss's car had been pulled off the road at an angle, driver's door open. Two shots. The first through the windscreen, high on the passenger side, glass all across the seat; he'd got out. The second had caught him as he ran. The shooter had been close, close enough that Voss's coat smelled of powder when they cut it off.

"The camp's a cedar-shingle thing at the end of a gravel drive," she said. "Rouse's Buick was in it. Engine cold. Keys on the kitchen table. No Rouse."

"Inside?"

"Not a mark. Table set for one, as though he'd made himself soup and stepped out. Bed made. Cardigan on the chair."

"Gray?"

She looked at me.

"It's navy," she said. "I've held it in my hands. I don't know what that tells us. A man leaves his coat behind to be found. Or he doesn't leave anything and somebody else makes it look like he did."

"Two shots," I said.

"Nine millimeter, I'd say. We'll know."

"Hal Rouse doesn't own a gun."

“No. I’ll check.” She held my gaze. “You’ve been in a room with him. Tell me honestly. Would he have shot a man in the back?”

I thought of the credenza and the green lamp. His whisper, and his hands, which had shaken so badly at the Atlantic building that he’d given up on the cardigan buttons.

“No.”

“Would he have hired someone?”

“I don’t know.”

She nodded once. It was her answer to most things when she was too tired to argue with them.

“Voss said something to the paramedic before he went under. ‘Tell Brandt. Phone.’” She took a clear evidence bag from her pocket, the kind with a red seal. Inside, a battered black phone with a cracked screen. “It was in his hand. Muddy, but it works. It’s evidence, and you can’t touch it. But he wanted you to see it, so I called Sayer, and she said I could play you what’s on it. Here. Outside.”

We went down to the parking structure and stood next to her car with the dome light on. She had plugged the phone into a cable and put it on the

hood. A rectangle of weak screen light shone up under our chins.

"He called your number at five fifty-one," she said. "You didn't answer. You were in the stairwell with Cora."

"I didn't hear it ring."

"It went to voicemail. Forty-four seconds. The recording's on his phone and yours. I wanted to hear it with you first."

She pressed play.

Wind. Gravel under feet, then a door shutting, the dull *chunk* of a car door. A man breathing hard. Voss's voice, low and conversational, as though he had walked out of the room to take a call:

"Brandt, it's Voss. I'm at the camp road. There's a gray... hold on, I'll call you back."

A pause. The sound of something heavy being set down. Then a voice that wasn't Voss's.

It was so soft the phone barely caught it. A dry, scraped whisper, with no vowels in it, only air with the shape of words:

"Mr. Voss. You have something of mine."

"Who—" said Voss.

"Put it on the ground, please."

"Hal? Hal, is that you? I'm not here to—"

A pause. Then a single sound that might have been a laugh, or might have been someone clearing a ruined throat.

The first shot.

Nell stopped it.

We stood there with the mud drying on our shoes. A truck went down the ramp behind us and its lights swung across the pillars.

"You know that voice," she said.

"It sounds like Hal."

"Does it?"

"It sounds like what I'd call a Hal." I put my hand over my mouth and took it away again. "You can't tell anything from a whisper. That's the point of one. It's the same whether it's a man with a damaged throat or a man who wants you to think so."

"Say it again."

"A person could imitate it."

"Who?"

I had my answer ready. *Anyone*. I had put that word in the air before I noticed how it had changed in my mouth, how it had come out tight, how it left room for somebody I loved in a hospital bed.

"Anyone who'd heard him," I said.

She looked at me for a long moment.

"That's what I thought you'd say."

"It's what the sound says."

"It is." She reached for the phone and unplugged it. "Voss said 'gray.' Hollis said 'gray.' Both of them in the same hour, on the same day, about the same man. I'd call that a pattern if it wasn't also the only color anybody in Maine has ever seen in the dark."

"Is that a joke?"

"I'm too tired for jokes."

She slid the phone into its bag and sealed it.

"I want you to go up and sit with Hollis until the night officer arrives at nine. I want you to sleep, if you can. And I want you to stop calling Hal Rouse a hero for trying to hide, because every time you almost do it I can see your face."

"I don't think he's a hero."

"You think he's a coward who looked away. Which is why you believe he'd run." She paused. "And I think he's the only man in this who's been scared the whole time, and I don't know whether that makes him a victim or a killer."

She got into the car. The window came down.

"Did you tell Hollis about Voss?"

"No."

"Don't. Let him rest."

I didn't go up.

I walked out of the garage and across the lot and stood on the pavement in the dark. The wind had turned colder. Beyond the hospital fence, across a four-lane road, a liquor store had its lights on. A red neon bottle, a handwritten sign. SALE ON SCOTCH.

It was a short walk.

I knew how many steps. I had learned that the way you learn the steps up to a church: not on purpose, but by looking too many times from the top. After enough days a man stops thinking about it. At eighteen hundred and twenty he thinks about it exactly as often as he thinks about breathing, and then on a night like this it all comes up at once.

Voss had a hole in his side. Quill was in a drawer in Augusta. Hollis was in a bed with stitches in his scalp. Cora had been right: everyone who touched Alan's letter, everyone who got near Mara's boxes, ended up hurt or dead. And me, standing in front of a liquor store at seven fifty in the evening with my hands in my pockets, perfectly well.

Nobody is that unlucky.

My phone buzzed against my hip.

I took it out. An unknown number, a Maine area code. I stood in the cold and let it ring three times, the way I had let Hollis's ring that morning.

Then I answered.

Nothing. Wind, again. A car going by somewhere a long way off. The hum of a line held open by someone who couldn't decide to speak.

"Hello?"

A dry rasp. Air shaped like a name.

"Theo."

My whole body went still.

"Don't tell Reyes where I am." A breath that caught and scraped. *"They're going to say I did it."*

Chapter 18: Behind the Garden Center

“Where are you?”

The line scraped. I thought he had hung up. Then the whisper came back, so close to the microphone that I could hear the wet in it.

“You’re standing in front of the liquor store with your hands in your pockets.”

I turned around.

Across the lot, past the parking structure and the dark hulk of the hospital laundry, a four-lane road ran east and west. On the far side was the liquor store with its red neon bottle. Beside it was a garden center, closed, its yard of potted evergreens lit by a single sodium lamp. Nothing moved there.

“Don’t look,” said Rouse. *“Please. Don’t look.”*

“I’m looking at a tree.”

“I’ve been here an hour. I watched you come out. I wanted to see if you’d go in.” A pause, a breath that caught on something scarred. *“I thought, if he goes*

in, I'll leave. I don't know why. A man who goes in there isn't going to hold on to anything I tell him."

"I didn't go in."

"No. You stood. I know how that is."

"Hal, I'm going to call Nell Castellano."

"No."

"I have to. A man's been shot. Barrett Voss, he's in surgery upstairs, and the last voice on his phone is yours."

The silence went on so long I heard the hospital's air handlers behind me, the dull, even breath of the building.

"I know," he said. "It isn't mine."

"Then tell her."

"Tell me what you'll say to her first. Tell me the words. I want to hear them."

I thought about the corridor and her face in the dome light of the car. *I'd have to be an idiot not to knock.* I thought about how long a man could sit on a bench behind a garden center before he decided that a stranger in a stairwell was better than a police station.

"I'll say you called me. I'll say you're alive, you're frightened, and you want to talk. I won't say you're guilty. I don't know that you are."

"And Reyes?"

"Nobody tells Reyes anything."

A long breath.

"Ten minutes," Rouse said. "Before she comes. You and me. Then you can do what you like."

I was already moving. I crossed four lanes against a red light, with the phone still at my ear and a horn going somewhere behind me, and while I crossed I dialed Nell on the second phone, the one in my other hand, which I had taken out without thinking.

She answered on the first ring.

"Yes."

"I've got Rouse."

I heard her stop walking.

"Where?"

I told her. Garden center, east of the hospital, back fence by the dumpsters. I told her he'd called me, that he said it wasn't his voice on the recording, that he wanted a few minutes. I said it fast, the way you make a confession so that it will be over.

"Don't let him out of your sight. Don't get in a car with him. Don't let him give you anything." A door slammed on her end. "Eleven minutes. I'm on Route 1 and I have to turn around."

"Nell."

"Ten more words and I'll have to hang up."

"He's scared of Reyes."

“Aren’t we all,” she said, and the line closed.

He was sitting on a plastic pallet behind a stack of peat bags with his knees pulled up to his chest, and for a moment I took him for a pile of the same thing.

Hal Rouse had been a heavy man on Thursday. In a day he had lost some of it, or the light had. He had no cardigan. He wore a green barn coat that was too short in the arms and smelled of diesel, and his trousers were black to the thigh. One shoe was wet through. His hands, held between his knees, didn’t stop moving.

“The girl at the Irving let me use her phone,” he whispered. “I told her it was my son. I gave her forty dollars. She looked at me as though I’d been in a river.”

“Have you?”

“Sort of.” His laugh was a puff of air. “The cove behind the camp. You go in to your waist. You hold on to a mooring line and you wait for the man to go away.”

I sat on a peat bag two yards from him, close enough to hear. It was colder out of the wind and the sodium light made us the same color.

“Start at eleven forty,” I said.

He shut his eyes.

"I was in my office. Jean had just brought me the file you wanted. I mean the one you didn't want, the Atlantic one, with the list of what we'd signed. The phone rang on my private line. I answered it myself, because Jean was at lunch." He swallowed. "It was Desmond."

"Reyes."

"He said, 'Hal. Don't go home. Don't go anywhere you're known. Brandt's told the state police about the fifth, and they're coming for you today.' He said I should go to the camp and sit tight, that he'd send someone, or come himself, tonight. He said not to use my phone."

"And you went."

"I took my cardigan and my keys. Forty-one years I've worked for that company. When Desmond Reyes tells me something in that voice I do what he says." His eyes opened. "There was something wrong with it."

"With what?"

"With the voice. It was Desmond's. It had his rhythm, the little hitch before a name. But it was as though he had a cold. Or was talking from inside a cupboard. I thought: he's in a car. I thought: he's at a pay phone. I didn't think what I think now."

“What do you think now?”

“That I’ve been listening to myself on a telephone for five years, and nobody’s said so.”

It took me a moment.

“You mean your whisper. Someone who sounds like a man with a cold, imitating Reyes, so you’d sit in a camp until—”

“Until a car came up the drive at a quarter to six.” He turned his hands over and looked at the palms. “I was at the kitchen window. A man got out of the car, an older man. Hat. He stood by the open door as if he was thinking about it. He had a telephone in his hand. I saw him put it to his ear. I couldn’t hear him from there, only the shape of the sentence. And then, on the road behind him, up past the second bend, I saw someone else.”

“Who?”

“Standing in the trees. Not hiding. Just standing, with his hands in the pockets of a rain jacket, gray, with the hood up. Not tall. I never saw his face. I saw him lift one hand to his mouth.” Rouse did it, the back of the fingers held a little way off the lips, and I felt the corridor tilt. “The way you do before you speak to someone you don’t want to wake.”

“Hollis did that. In the bed. This afternoon.”

“Did he?” He looked at me, very steadily. “Then I’d say it’s a common gesture.”

“What happened?”

“I went out the back. Through the pantry, down the bank, into the water. I heard Mr. Voss say my name. ‘Hal.’ As though we were friends.” His mouth worked. “And then I heard somebody answer him in my voice.”

Wind moved the evergreens in their pots.

“Do you know what that’s like?” Rouse whispered. “I do not have a good voice. I haven’t had a good voice since 1994. And there was this clean small perfect thing coming across the water, with my breath in it, my own breath, saying *put it on the ground, please*. Like a recording of a man who’d never been hurt.”

I didn’t say anything.

“Then two shots. I stayed in the water until I couldn’t feel my feet. When I came out the road was empty and there was a man lying in the weeds. I didn’t go to him.” His voice broke into nothing for a moment and came back. “Tell her that. Tell her I didn’t go to him. I walked into the woods, and I left a man bleeding by his car. I didn’t have a phone. I told myself I’d send someone.”

“Did you?”

"I told the girl at the Irving. I said there'd been a shooting on Route 220. She said, 'Sir?'" He rubbed his face. "She'll have written it down. Maybe."

"Hal. Who knew about the camp?"

"Jean. Desmond. My wife." He counted on his fingers, then stopped. "Everyone. I show the slides. The Christmas party, every year, for twenty years. The old claims department used to drive up for chowder in August. Half of them have slept on that porch. Hollis Dunn once fell off the dock and had to be dried out by the stove."

I nodded. I heard myself say, "He's in a bed with eleven stitches," and Rouse looked at me and said nothing at all.

A car went by on the four-lane. Its lights crossed the peat bags and left us.

"Monday," said Rouse. "You asked what I remembered."

"You said I was calm."

"You were *terrifyingly* calm. I've seen men come into that office after a fire. They shake. They want you to tell them it isn't their fault. You sat down in the low chair and said, 'I need to know how to report something inside the company, and I need to know

who to be afraid of.' As if you were ordering lunch." He put his chin on his knees. "Then you said, 'She told me last night.'"

"Last night."

"Sunday. You said she'd told you the shape of it. Not the names. She'd begun, and then she'd stopped, and said she'd show you the files in the morning, because she wanted you to see the pages with your own eyes before you decided what to be angry at."

Sunday night.

I didn't mean to look at it. It was the sodium light, I think, its hum, the cold coming off the concrete into the soles of my shoes. Or his whisper, close and dry, saying *last night*.

Mara had her back to me.

A kitchen. Our kitchen, the one with the radiator that knocked. Late, with the overhead off and only the light over the stove. She was standing at the counter with a mug going cold between her hands, and she hadn't turned around, and she said, "I need you not to say anything until I've finished." I hadn't. I'd stood in the doorway with my hands hanging, sober as a stone that night, whatever I told myself afterward, and listened to my wife tell me, in the

careful voice she used on files, that there were four closings with the same sentence in them, and that three of them had my name.

She told me about two of them. I remember the cold of the kitchen window against my shoulder, left open a hand's width in October. Then she turned around and her face was the color of paper and she said, "I can't. Not tonight. I'll show you tomorrow. Please just let me show you."

And I said I would.

Then the rest, in pieces. I remembered the microwave clock, green numerals, 1:12. The cordless phone, heavier than it should have been. The porch, with its one bulb. I was standing on the back porch in my socks, in the cold, the screen door shut behind me so she wouldn't hear. I had a number in my thumb that I'd dialed in my sleep for three years. It rang twice.

Somebody picked up awake. Not woken. Awake, the way a man is who has been waiting up for something else.

Theo. What's happened?

I could hear that voice. That was the horror. It was entirely there, the warmth in it, the little downward settle at the end of my name, like a man lowering a

hand onto a shoulder. I could have drawn the room it was in.

Slow down. Tell me from the beginning.

And I told it. I stood on that porch with my feet freezing and I told the voice everything my wife had told me in the kitchen, in the wrong order, in whispers, and when I was done there was a pause, and the voice said, very gently:

Let me talk to her.

“Theo.”

I was on my knees in the dirt. I don’t know how. Rouse had a hand on my coat sleeve, with his fingers shaking, and he was saying my name in his scraped voice, over and over, like a man trying to wake a child.

“I’m all right.”

“You’re gray.”

“I’m all right.” I sat back on my heels. I could taste copper. The hum of the lamp had gone back to being a lamp. “It’s coming in pieces. It’s—I remembered Sunday. The kitchen. I called someone.”

“Who?”

"I don't know." It came out too fast, and I heard it, and went on anyway. "I had a list. There were people. A man at the meetings who kept a number on a card. The state hotline. A priest I used to see. At one in the morning you call a thing that picks up. It doesn't have to be a person. It could have been any of them."

"You said *him*," Rouse whispered. "Just now. 'I called him.'"

"Did I?"

"You did."

"It was a voice. A voice says *him* if it's a man. That's all. It's a man's voice, like half the voices in the world."

He took his hand away from my sleeve.

I got up. My knees were wet. I brushed the dirt off with both hands, slowly, the way you do when you want to be doing something that has an end.

Let me talk to her.

Rouse had told me on Thursday: *be careful who you tell*. What else had I heard that day? Only that I'd already told someone. But a man who has told someone on Sunday night and sat down in the low chair on Monday afternoon has not yet decided what to be afraid of. I had gone to Rouse to ask who to be afraid of. I would not have done that if I'd known.

I held that thought like a rail.

It lasted until headlights swung into the yard of the garden center.

Nell came in on foot, with her coat unbuttoned and her badge on a lanyard. Two uniformed troopers waited at the fence. She stopped ten feet from the pallet and looked at Rouse the way you look at an animal that has crawled out of a drain.

“Harold Rouse.”

“Hal,” he whispered.

“Hal, I’m Detective Castellano. You have the right to a lawyer, and I’d like you to have one. I’m not arresting you. I’m going to put you in a car with two troopers and a heater and a blanket, and I’m going to keep you somewhere that’s not Port Carrow and not Atlantic Mutual. If you tell me where Desmond Reyes is I’ll be pleased. If you tell me nothing, I’ll still be pleased you’re alive.”

Rouse looked at her for a long moment.

“I told Mr. Brandt,” he said. “I’ll tell you.”

“In the car.”

“And—” He moved on the pallet. “If Desmond Reyes asks you where I am—”

“I won’t know,” said Nell. “I’ll make sure of it.”

She took his arm. He stood up all at once like a man unfolding. In the lamplight I saw how old he was, a worn gray man in a stranger's coat who had held a mooring line in the dark. A trooper put a blanket round him. He went to the fence without looking back.

Nell turned to me.

"Your phone is in your hand," she said.

"Yes."

"Was it in your hand at the liquor store?"

I had known she would ask. I had promised myself the truth, and still it took a moment to get it out.

"I stood there. A long time. I counted steps. I didn't go in."

"I know," she said. "I looked at the garage camera on my way out. Eight minutes." She didn't smile. "If you had, I'd have let you. I wouldn't have enjoyed it."

"That isn't what I—"

"You said it so I'd know. That's what I mean." She looked at the road. "Don't do it again. Tell me *before*. You've got my number. It's the only one I've ever given anybody who wasn't in a squad."

I didn't trust my voice, so I nodded.

"Something happened to you just now."

"A memory. The kitchen on Sunday. I don't have the rest."

“Do you want to tell me?”

“Not yet.”

She stood there, and I thought she was going to push. She didn’t. Her phone had gone, a short double buzz, and she turned her shoulder to read.

I watched her face.

“What?”

“Reyes’s assistant,” she said. “I called her back after Boston. He wasn’t at the meeting. It was canceled at ten this morning. His car’s registered at a Marriott in Portland as of last night, and nobody’s seen it since.” She put the phone away. “And the officer outside Hollis’s door says a man in a gray suit came to the floor at twenty past seven. Didn’t ask for you. Asked for Hollis. The officer sent him back down because he wasn’t on the list.”

“Reyes.”

“He left a card. At the desk. He didn’t say anything else.” She was already walking. “He was in this building an hour ago, Theo, while you were in the waiting room with Cora.”

She had two men drive me back across the road. At the door of the ward I told the night officer, a woman I hadn’t met, that I wanted to look in on Mr. Dunn

only for a moment. She checked a clipboard and said I was on the list.

The corridor was quiet. The mop man had gone. Somewhere a monitor beeped to itself.

Hollis's door stood a hand's width open, and a light on the wall behind the bed made the room amber and soft. I put my fingers against the wood.

I was going to say *I'm back* in the dark, softly, the way you do.

Before I could, the figure in the bed turned his head on the pillow. The dressing was white and the swollen eye was shut, but the other one found me instantly, clear and wet and entirely awake.

"Ah," said Hollis, in the voice I had known for twenty years. His mouth moved into something that was almost a smile. "There you are."

I stood in the doorway.

Everybody says it. It's what you say to someone who's late.

I told myself that all the way across the room, and I was still telling myself when I sat down beside him and took the hand he held out to me, and it was warm.

Chapter 19: Where It Doesn't Fit the Water

I didn't sleep. I sat beside his bed until a nurse came at midnight and said, kindly, that Mr. Dunn needed rest and so, frankly, did I. Then I walked back to the Anchor in the dark, the causeway lights strung across the water like a necklace somebody had dropped.

Room six. The chain on. The radiator ticking.

I did what he taught me. I took out the notebook, a clean page, and drew a line down the middle.

Every loss is a story somebody is telling you. Find where it doesn't fit the water.

On the left I wrote what I knew. On the right, what I'd been told. For twenty years I'd done this for strangers, and it had never felt like holding a knife.

The latch. Left: Nell told me about the hook-and-eye inside the boathouse door, on the Saturday, in the cold light of that yard. She told nobody else. Right: I told Hollis the door was *locked from inside*. That's all

I said. I'd written his answer in the margin that night, because I write down what people say to me: *That latch sticks in damp, always did.*

Not *the door*. The latch. A man who thought the door was bolted, or barred, or keyed, would have said *the door sticks*.

9:12. Left: Nell told me the minute Reyes called, after dinner, when Hollis was at his sink. Right: Hollis said "nine-twelve" on the Sunday, in his study, and when I looked at him he said Reyes had rung him Friday. Reyes had rung him Friday. I had checked. Reyes could have mentioned it. Reyes could have mentioned anything.

The coat. Tarbell told me a man took his coat off and put it back on in the harbor office, a talker, a kind one. Gray waxed cotton hangs on a hook in the hall at Quarry Lane. It has hung there my entire adult life. Every man in Maine over sixty owns one.

The tea. A used bag in a dead man's bin, with a string and a paper tag. Alan Farrow, by his housekeeper's account in every statement I'd seen, drank whisky and coffee. I put down my pen and thought about a red box in a kitchen in Port Carrow, and a paper sleeve in a coat pocket, and a man who said *hotel tea is a crime* and carried his own.

The lamp. Mara's ledger photograph, a green glass shade out of focus at the top edge. *You'll know the chair.* I knew the chair. I'd sat in it. I'd been looking for the lamp in the wrong office.

The kettle. A note, rising. Wet wool. I'd felt it twice, in my own kitchen on the fourteenth and in his, and each time I had told myself that it was the smell of being looked after.

I looked at the page.

There is a thing that happens when you stack enough small coincidences. Each one is nothing. A man gets lucky, a man gets unlucky, people say things. Then you stop adding and start *seeing*. The whole sheet rearranges itself into a shape that was there from the beginning, only now it has a face.

I turned the page over, face down.

Then I turned it back and added one more line, at the bottom, in letters so small I could hardly read them.

There you are.

A man in a doorway could have said it. A man on a stranger's voicemail could have said it. I had said it myself, to a thousand people, when they were late.

And Hollis was in a hospital bed. That was the thing I kept going back to. At 5:51 Friday afternoon, when Barrett Voss was shot on a camp road in

Friendship, Hollis Dunn had been under a blanket with a policeman outside his door and eleven stitches in his scalp. He could not have stood in those trees. Whatever else this was, a man who is bleeding in a hall at noon doesn't fire a gun at six.

Then there's more than one of them, the part of me that was still an adjuster said. You knew that. The ledger says six.

The other part said: Or there is only one, and he is in a hospital, and the one who shot Voss is a man who wanted what Voss had. And you are reading a pattern into a kind old man because you are tired, and drunk on being afraid, and you have wanted for five years to find somebody to hate.

I looked at that for a long time. It was a good argument. It was exactly the argument a man would make who needed to go on being loved.

At ten past one I picked up the phone and called Nell.

"Are you drunk?" she said.

"No."

"Then it's a bad hour." I heard a lamp click. "Go ahead."

"When you told me about the latch on the boathouse door. Did you tell anyone else?"

A short silence.

"No."

"Not Ouellette. Not Hollis, not in passing. Not in the hospital."

"Theo. I told you at the scene because you were the only one in the county who might know how a man could do that to himself with his own door. I didn't tell the lieutenant until Monday. Why?"

"I'm checking my notes."

"Don't do that to me."

"I'm checking my notes," I said, "and I want to ask about the tea."

She was quiet again, and when she spoke her voice had changed.

"Aldous," she said. "I got to her yesterday. Seventy-one, tough, a long day. The Colonel, she calls him. He didn't keep tea in the house. Never. 'A man who drinks tea,' she says, 'has something to hide.' He hated it. She emptied that boathouse bin herself on Wednesday, the seventh, because it stank. The bag came after that." A pause. "The tag says Yorkshire Gold. Red box. Half of Maine drinks it."

"And the receipt."

"You're building something."

"I'm trying to knock it down."

"Hanley's. Ten-forty on the sixth. Fifty yards of forty-pound braided line, one brass eye hook. Cash." I heard her breathe. "The clerk is nineteen and remembers nothing. Everybody who owns a boat buys line there. Everybody who owns a door buys a hook."

"Fifty yards."

"Don't say it."

"I haven't said anything."

"You've said it so loudly I can hear it from here," Nell said. "Go to sleep. The diary opens at nine at the barracks, with Sayer, in a room with a camera. I'd like you to come rested. I'm going to watch your face, and I want what I see to mean something."

I said I would try.

I lay down in my clothes. The harbor lights went in and out through a gap in the curtain, and the chain on the door shone, and I thought, *at least I know what I'll see when I close my eyes.*

I was wrong. I slept for four hours without a dream, like a man who has been shut in a dark room and told to wait.

They opened it on a steel table under a ceiling camera, at the state police barracks in Rockland, at nine-oh-six on Saturday morning.

It was a black Letts desk diary with a cracked spine, one page a day. Five years ago in tired gold. Dill had carried it from the cottage in a bag with a numbered seal, and Nell cut the seal while a trooper filmed. Ellen Sayer sat beside me in a charcoal suit with her red-stitched bag between her feet. She had told me on the stairs, in a low voice, to look at nothing but the page. "If you remember something, don't say it. Write it down. Tell me. Then we'll talk."

Nell wore gloves. She turned the pages slowly, by the corners, with a flat steel spatula.

Hollis's handwriting. I'd have known it blind. The long tails, the way he crossed his sevens like a European. *Dentist. Sailing club AGM. Rotary lunch. Call B. about the roof.* A year of a retired man's life, written in a black ballpoint that slowly ran out and was replaced by another.

Nell stopped at the first week of October.

"Fourth," she said. "Sunday."

Church. Bread. Quiet day. Nobody rang.

I read it twice.

"Fifth. Monday."

It was a small neat entry. It sat in the middle of the page in a different ink, and it took me a moment to know why my chest had gone tight, until I saw it was bluer, blue-black, the sort that dries to a shine.

T. at 7. Troubled, would not say why. Tea. Sat with me until 10. Sober, thank God. Walked him to the car.

Under it, in the same blue-black, cramped to fit:
Whatever it is, it will keep till he is ready.

Nobody said anything. The camera hummed.

"That's the night Pryor says you were at his house," said Nell, very flat.

"Yes."

"If it's true, you were here. In Hollis's kitchen. From seven to ten." She looked at me. "Pryor's handwritten statement says he saw you at eight."

"Then one of them is wrong."

"Or both of them are telling a story," said Sayer. She had not moved. "A diary is not an alibi, Detective. It's a man's account of his own evening in his own hand. I would like it very much to be true. I'd like to know when that ink was put on that page."

"It's blue-black," Nell said. "The rest of the week is ballpoint."

"Then I'd like to know when it was written."

Nell turned the pages with the spatula, three, four, five days, and I could see it. On the sixth, *Nothing. Fog.* On the seventh, *Wrote to Alan.* In black. Then the eighth, the ninth. Then the fourteenth.

She didn't read it aloud.

I read it from where I sat.

Breakwater. Rain. Mara.

Nothing else. No time. Nothing about the day, or how he had known. I looked at it and I saw a man sitting in a quiet kitchen with a pen. I saw it so clearly it was like being struck.

"It's blue-black," I said.

"Yes."

"The fifth. The fourteenth. The rest is ballpoint."

"Yes."

"The signature on page seven. My signature. In the Lydia file." I could hear my own voice, very careful. "The ink on that, Mara wrote in the margin of her copy. *Blue-black, not his.* I never use it. I use a black gel pen. I've used one for twenty years."

"I know," Nell said. "I have the copy."

Nobody breathed.

"That is a lab matter. And it could be any fountain pen in Maine. A man has been through something and writes in a diary with whatever is to hand." Sayer paused. "Mr. Brandt, I'm going to say this once so

you hear it from me. There is a version of this morning where a decent old man was kind to you in the worst week of your life, wrote it down, and was attacked in his own hall by someone who wanted what he knew. I would like you to be able to defend that version in front of a jury. If you cannot, they will not let you defend any other."

"I know."

"Do you?"

I looked at the line again. *Whatever it is, it will keep till he is ready.*

"He says," I said slowly, "that I wouldn't say why."

"Yes."

"I'd have told him. If I'd come to that kitchen that night, I'd have told him everything. He was the first person I ever told things."

"Perhaps you didn't," said Sayer. "Perhaps you'd lost your nerve."

"I didn't lose it with Rouse."

I stopped. They were both looking at me.

"That's all," I said. "I didn't lose it with Rouse."

The cutter lay at her mooring in the cove below Quarry Lane, white hull, tan mainsail furled along the boom, the name in blue script on the transom.

Second Opinion. A tide-line of green weed on her waterline and a gull on the pulpit. I'd slept on her four summers ago. I had been sick over her rail once, the first year, and he had held the back of my collar and said, "Better out than in, dear boy," and rinsed the deck himself afterward.

Sayer had asked him that morning, at the hospital, whether Nell might look aboard. He had said, through the dressing on his face and a plastic cup of apple juice, "Take whatever you need. The key's with Theo. I've nothing to hide on a boat," and Sayer had written down the sentence word for word.

Nell went down the companionway first. Dill took photographs from the cockpit. I stood in the hatch with my hands in my pockets.

It was neat. It was the neatest boat I'd ever been on. Brass polished, charts rolled, a row of paperbacks held in by a bungee. The cabin smelled of diesel and wet wool.

I stood in the smell and I did not fall down.

"Logbooks," said Nell.

They were on a shelf above the chart table, bound, a spine for each year, in a row of dark green cloth. She ran a gloved finger along them and stopped.

"There's a gap."

Five years ago. Between the book before it and the book after, an empty slot with a faint paler line in the varnish where the spine of a book had kept the sun off.

"He'll say he lost it," said Dill, from above.

"He'll say it's at the cottage," said Nell. "Which it may be." She took down this year's volume with two fingers and let it fall open on her palm. She was quiet for some time.

"Come and look."

October. Six pages of a ruled log. Each one, a neat boat-owner's record of a day: *Wind NW 12. Beat out of the cove. Nothing in the pots.* Then the sixth, the seventh, the eighth, the ninth. Four pages. Where each of them had been there was a clean straight edge close to the gutter, a hair's breadth of paper left, so exactly cut that I could have shaved with it.

"Razor," she said.

I'd seen a straight edge like that before. In a pink message binder, in the Atlantic archive, with a carbon where a carbon had been.

"Water gets into everything on a boat," said Dill, who was twenty-six and had been trying for ten minutes to be helpful.

"Yes," said Nell. "It does." She put the book into a bag. "Theo, don't touch the locker."

"I haven't."

"You were about to."

I was. A long cockpit locker, port side, under the seat. She knelt and lifted the lid. There was a coil of anchor rode. A fender, a bailer, a tin of marine varnish with a brush stuck to its rim. And in the corner, in a clear freezer bag with a zip, a spool of braided line in dull green, nearly full, and a loose brass eye hook, unopened, still in its blister pack.

"Hanley's," said Nell. She turned it over. There was a price sticker. "Same stock number. He'd have bought it on the sixth, too." She didn't look at me. "Or on the fifth, or in August, or whenever anyone buys a spool of line for a boat."

"Fifty yards. And a hook."

"A hook and eye is how you hang a hammock. A spool of line is how you do half the things on this boat." She stood up. Her knees cracked. "If I put this in front of a prosecutor, she'll show me a photograph of Hollis Dunn's boat and ask me what in it is unusual. And I'll say, *the pages are missing*, and she'll say, *water*, and I'll say, *the book from five years ago*, and she'll say, *an old man's attic*. And she'll be right. You can't convict a man for owning a boat."

"I know."

"I know you know." She put the bag down on the chart table and looked at me. "Say it."

"I can't."

"Why?"

"Because he was in a hospital bed when Voss was shot."

"Yes."

"Because Reyes came to the ward and asked for him by name."

"Yes."

"Because somebody put him in that hall. Somebody hit him. He has a bruise the size of a plate on his chest, Nell. I watched them cut the cardigan."

"Yes," she said, with her mouth hardly moving. "I watched too."

We stood there, the two of us, in that clean small cabin. Above us, the gull shifted on the pulpit.

"I don't have an explanation," I said. "I have a list. It isn't proof. It's the shape a loss makes when the story is wrong. That's all it is. I could stand in front of Sayer's jury and be torn to pieces."

"Then you need something that isn't a list."

"Yes."

"Something that only he could know."

"Yes."

“And you can’t get it by asking, because he’s smarter than both of us, and he’s been teaching you how to question people since before you could drive.”

I looked at the logbook through the plastic. The clean cut edges.

“I can get it,” I said, “by lying to him.”

Nell looked at me for a long moment.

“We’ll need Sayer,” she said.

I went to the hospital alone at five, with Nell’s officer on the door and Sayer’s number in my pocket and a paper cup of tea I had bought in the lobby, because I’d decided on the stairs that I would not refuse one.

He was sitting up. The swelling on his eye had come down a little and turned the yellow-green of an old bruise, and the white of his hair, brushed, made him look like a painting of a patriarch who has been wronged. He saw me and put down a paperback. A Patrick O’Brian. He’d read it, I knew, twelve times.

“Theo.”

“Hollis.”

“Sit, sit. You’ve been in the wars. Sayer says they opened my old diary.” He smiled, and winced, and put a finger to the dressing. “I do hope it helped, dear. I

was ashamed to give it to you in that state. My writing's gone to pot."

"It put me in your kitchen," I said. "On the fifth. From seven to ten."

"Where else would you be?"

I sat down and held the tea in both hands.

"Do you remember what we talked about?" he said. He said it lightly, the way he'd say *did you sleep?* "I've turned it over. I've thought, if I could only recall the *words*. But you wouldn't say. You sat there like a lamp with the wick down. I was so afraid you'd start drinking again."

I looked at him.

A man who had known me for twenty years was watching my face with the whole attention of his mild blue eyes, and under it, at a depth I could never have found before that night, something else was watching. Waiting. A fisherman's patience. The stillness of a man who has dropped a line and sits looking at the water, not at the float.

Have you remembered? Have you?

"No," I said. "I haven't remembered a word of it."

It was the first lie I had ever told him that I knew was a lie as I said it.

The corner of his mouth went soft. His whole face eased, like a clenched hand letting go.

"That's a mercy," said Hollis. He reached across the blanket and covered my hand. "That's a mercy, dear boy. Some things are better left."

His hand was warm. It lay over mine as it had on a hundred church-basement chairs, and I did not pull away. I sat in that amber light, holding a paper cup of tea I did not drink, and I thought, with great clarity, as though it were a sentence written on the wall: *he is relieved*.

A man who had loved me and been kind and wanted only my good would not have been relieved.

"I'll come tomorrow," I said.

"Do. Bring the paper. And, Theo."

"Yes."

"Eat something. You look like a ghost."

I said I would. At the door I looked back. He had picked up his book again, and found his place with one finger, and for a moment, with his head bent in the lamplight and his bruised face to the page, he looked as old and gentle as anyone I had ever loved.

Then he turned a page without reading it.

In the corridor I found Nell's number with my thumb, and I stood against the wall until I could trust my hands. I didn't call her. Instead I took out my notebook, and under the last line on the right-hand

side, *There you are*, I wrote, *He was relieved*, and then, because I did not want to be a man who could stop there, I wrote what I'd have to do tomorrow.

Give him one thing nobody else has.

A name. A place. A time.

And then wait to see who comes.